
A PERSONAL MASTER COURSE FOR ICSE

JULIUS CAESAR

Act 1 — Three-Day Crash Edition

*The short, exam-first cut of the Master Course: summaries • revision sheets •
quotations • keywords • examiner training • six practice extracts*

Prepared for an ICSE Class 10 student · Based on the verified Shakespeare text (Folger / Globe editions) ·
Cross-checked against Plutarch and modern Roman history · Aligned to the CISCE Literature in English paper

Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the syllabus; the Class X board paper (Acts III–V) depends on it at every turn. This book
teaches Act 1 from zero to examination standard.

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FRONT MATTER

Three-Day Crash Edition: Julius Caesar Act 1 for ICSE

What this chapter does: this is the short, exam-first version of the full Master Course, cut for a student with three days. Read it in order. Everything here is lifted from the full book, so every quotation has been checked against the Folger and Globe texts.

ICSE EXAM BOX The honest syllabus note

For the ICSE Class X board paper, the prescribed portion of *Julius Caesar* is Acts III, IV and V. Act 1 is the Class IX portion. If your examination in three days is a Class IX or school paper on Act 1, this edition is written for it. If it is the Class X board paper, use this edition for the background that Acts III–V questions constantly assume: who Cassius is, why Brutus hesitates, what "the work the ides of March begun" means, and why the crowd can be turned. No question in this edition is guaranteed to appear.

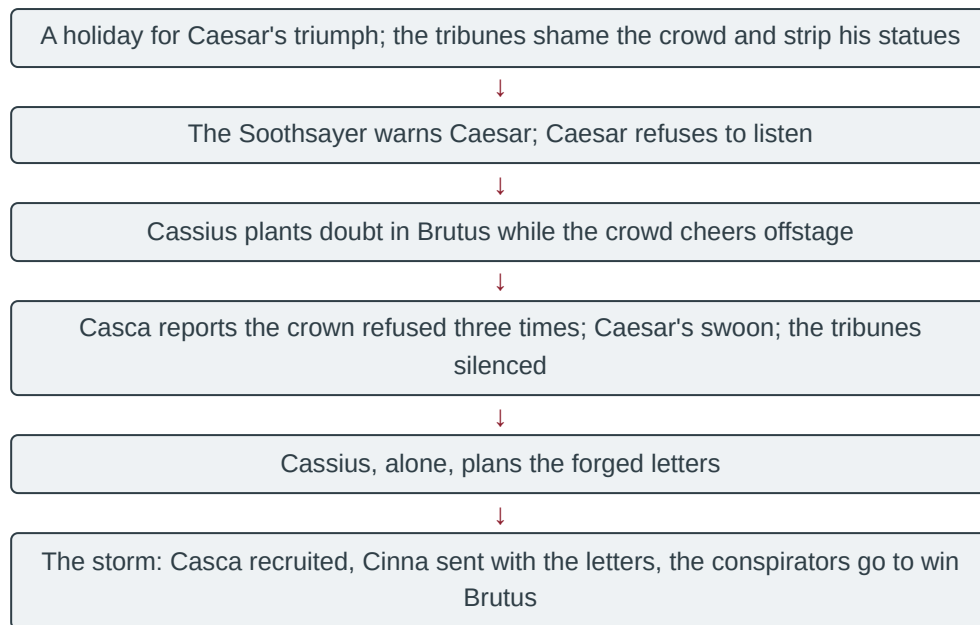
Your three-day plan

Day	Morning (90 min)	Afternoon (90 min)	Evening (45 min)
Day 1	Act 1 in One Page, then in Ten Minutes. Read Scene 1 and Scene 2 in your textbook alongside.	Scene 1 and Scene 2 revision sheets; the character map. Learn the ten essential quotations.	Attempt Extract Practice 1 and 2 in writing, then compare with the model answers.
Day 2	Scene 3 in your textbook; Scene 3 revision sheet; the Soothsayer and foreshadowing map.	Weak vs excellent answers (read all seven, then write one yourself). Keyword conversion table.	Extract Practice 3 and 4 in writing.
Day 3	Common errors; MCQ training; the 3-mark and 4-mark answer anatomy.	The connection engine in ten lines; the act in ten lines. Re-learn the quotations from memory.	Extract Practice 5 and 6 under timed conditions (18 minutes each). Sleep.

ACT 1 IN ONE MINUTE

Rome celebrates Caesar's victory over Pompey's sons, but two tribunes shame the fickle crowd and strip Caesar's statues. At the Lupercalia a Soothsayer warns Caesar to "Beware the ides of March"; Caesar dismisses him as "a dreamer". Cassius works on the troubled Brutus, using Caesar's physical weaknesses, the equality of their names and the memory of Brutus's king-expelling ancestor to argue that "The fault ... is not in

our stars, / But in ourselves". Casca reports that Caesar thrice refused a crown and then fainted; the tribunes have been silenced. Alone, Cassius plans forged letters. A month later, in a night of portents, Cassius recruits Casca, sends Cinna to plant the letters, and sets off with the conspirators to secure Brutus before dawn.



CROSS-REFERENCE Where this map leads

Everything above is sharpened in the chapters that follow. The three scene chapters teach the text line by line. *Caesar in Act 1: A Character Masterclass*, *Cassius: The Manipulation Masterclass* and *Brutus in Act 1: Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability* develop sections G to J of this chapter into full studies. *The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast* covers the figures in the lower half of the character table. The two Themes chapters develop section C. *The Scene Connection Engine* and *Where Act 1 Reappears Later* shows how each item in the chain diagram above pays off in Acts 2 to 5, which is where your Class 10 board paper will need it.

ICSE EXAM BOX How this chapter earns marks

Exam-oriented advice. Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus; the Class X board paper sets its extract questions from Acts III to V. That does not make this chapter optional. Board extract questions regularly ask what has happened earlier, why a character behaves as he does, or what a phrase refers to, and the answers lie in Act 1: Brutus's divided loyalty, Cassius's envy and forgery, Antony's loyalty, Caesar's refusal of the Soothsayer, the crowd's fickleness. A one-mark MCQ may hinge on knowing who offered the crown or who said "it was Greek to me". The mental map you have built here is what lets you answer those sub-questions quickly and accurately, so that your time and attention go to the longer analytical parts where the real marks are. No question is guaranteed; preparation that covers the causes as well as the events is what the paper consistently rewards.

ACT 1 IN ONE PAGE

It is a holiday in Rome. Caesar has returned victorious from Spain, where he destroyed the last army of Pompey's sons, and the city has turned out to celebrate his triumph; by Shakespeare's compression it is also the feast of Lupercalia. Two tribunes, Flavius and Marullus, find the streets full of tradesmen in their best clothes and are furious. A quick-witted Cobbler fences with them in puns before admitting that the people have come

"to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph". Marullus explodes. Have they forgotten Pompey, for whom they once waited all day on rooftops? Now they scatter flowers before the man "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". The crowd slinks off in shame, and the tribunes split up to strip the decorations from Caesar's statues, Flavius arguing that if Caesar's "growing feathers" are plucked he will fly at "an ordinary pitch" instead of soaring above them all.

Caesar enters in procession with his wife Calpurnia, Antony dressed for the ritual race, Brutus, Cassius, Casca, Cicero and others. He publicly asks Antony to touch Calpurnia during the race, since tradition says this cures barrenness. A Soothsayer calls from the crowd, "Beware the ides of March." Caesar has him brought forward, hears the warning again, and dismisses him: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

The procession moves on to the games, but Brutus stays behind, saying he is "not gamesome", and Cassius stays with him. Cassius complains that Brutus has grown cold towards him; Brutus confesses that he is troubled by private "passions of some difference" and "with himself at war". Cassius offers to be Brutus's mirror and show him the worth he cannot see in himself. A shout is heard from the games, and Brutus blurts out his fear that the people "Choose Caesar for their king", adding at once that he loves Caesar well. Brutus declares he values honour above death; Cassius seizes the word and makes "honour ... the subject of my story". He tells how Caesar once challenged him to swim the Tiber and had to be rescued, crying "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!", and how Caesar shook with fever in Spain and begged for drink "As a sick girl". A second shout. Cassius pictures Caesar as a "Colossus" under whose legs "we petty men" creep, insists that "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves", weighs the names 'Brutus' and 'Caesar' and finds them equal, and reminds Brutus of the ancestor who would have endured the devil in Rome sooner than a king. Brutus, moved but cautious, promises to consider all this and to meet again, adding that he would rather be a villager than a Roman under such conditions.

Caesar returns from the games looking angry, his followers "like a chidden train". He tells Antony he distrusts "lean and hungry" men like Cassius, who think too much, then insists he fears nothing, "for always I am Caesar", and asks Antony to come to his right side because his left ear is deaf. Brutus and Cassius detain Casca, who reports in sour prose that Antony offered Caesar a crown three times, that Caesar refused it each time, though "he would fain have had it", that the stinking crowd cheered the refusals, and that Caesar then fainted in the marketplace, "foamed at mouth and was speechless". Cicero spoke Greek, "it was Greek to me", and the tribunes Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence" for stripping the statues. Casca agrees to dine with Cassius. Alone, Cassius gloats that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought" and plans to throw forged letters, as if from citizens, through Brutus's windows that night.

A month later, on the night before the Ides of March, a storm of impossible violence breaks over Rome. Casca, sword drawn, tells Cicero of wonders: a slave's hand burning unharmed, a lion by the Capitol, women who saw men of fire in the streets, an owl shrieking at noon. Cicero remarks drily that "men may construe things after their fashion" and goes home. Cassius arrives, boasting that he has bared his chest to the lightning. He reads the storm as heaven's warning about a man "Most like this dreadful night", and Casca names Caesar. Casca reports a rumour that the Senate will crown Caesar king tomorrow. Cassius declares he will free himself with his dagger first, scorns the Romans, who make Caesar a wolf by being "but sheep", and Casca gives his hand to the cause. Cassius reveals that other noble Romans wait at Pompey's Porch. Cinna hurries in, longing for "the noble Brutus" to join them; Cassius gives him the forged letters to plant in Brutus's chair, window and ancestral statue. Casca observes that Brutus's reputation will turn their crime into virtue, and the two set off, after midnight, to secure Brutus before dawn.

ACT 1 IN TEN MINUTES

This walkthrough follows the act scene by scene and, for each movement, tells you what happens and what to notice. 'Notice' points are where the marks live.

Scene 1 — A street in Rome: the tribunes and the crowd

What happens. Flavius and Marullus, tribunes of the people, discover the streets full of working men who have taken an unofficial holiday. They demand to know the men's trades. A Carpenter answers plainly; a Cobbler answers in riddling puns about soles, mending and awls, and finally explains that everyone has come out to cheer Caesar's triumph. Marullus delivers a long, furious speech reminding them of their old devotion to Pompey and condemning their ingratitude; he sends them home to pray that the gods will "intermit the plague" (intermit: hold back) that such ingratitude deserves. The commoners leave in silence. The tribunes resolve to go through the city removing the "ceremonies" from Caesar's statues, and Flavius closes the scene with the image of Caesar as a hawk whose feathers must be plucked.

What to notice. - The commoners speak **prose**; the tribunes speak **verse**. Shakespeare marks class and tone through the form of the lines before you have understood a word. - The Cobbler is cleverer than his questioners. His puns ("a mender of bad soles"; "I can mend you") are small acts of insolence, and the tribunes' irritation shows that their authority is already weak. - Marullus's speech works by **contrast** and **rhetorical question**: then (Pompey) against now (Caesar), and a chain of "And do you now ... ?" questions that pile up guilt. Learn its shape; it is the first great persuasive speech in a play built of them. - The crowd that was cheering a minute ago leaves "tongue-tied in their guiltiness". This is the first demonstration of the people's fickleness, and you will refer back to it from Act 3. - Caesar never appears. The scene is *about* him, and his absence is deliberate.

Scene 2, first movement — The procession and the Soothsayer

What happens. Caesar enters with his train. He tells Antony, who is about to run the Lupercalia race, to touch Calpurnia so that she may "Shake off their sterile curse". Antony promises obedience. A Soothsayer cries out from the crowd; Caesar stops, has him brought forward, hears "Beware the ides of March" twice, and dismisses him as "a dreamer".

What to notice. - Caesar's first words are about a private matter, his wife's childlessness, spoken as public business. Watch how he treats the city as an extension of himself. - He refers to himself in the **third person**: "Caesar is turned to hear." This habit is a key to his character. - The warning is given, repeated and refused. The Soothsayer is the voice of a future the audience already knows; Caesar's dismissal is the first of many refusals to listen. - Casca is the one calling for silence when Caesar speaks. Note that the man who will strike first is here acting as Caesar's usher.

Scene 2, second movement — Cassius works on Brutus

What happens. Everyone leaves for the games except Brutus and Cassius. In a long dialogue, interrupted twice by offstage shouts, Cassius moves Brutus step by step from friendly puzzlement to a cautious promise. The steps are: a complaint about Brutus's coldness; Brutus's admission of inner conflict; the mirror image; the first shout and Brutus's fear of a king; Brutus's declaration about honour; Cassius's two anecdotes of Caesar's physical weakness (the Tiber, the fever); the second shout; the Colossus image and "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars"; the comparison of names; the appeal to Brutus's ancestor; Brutus's measured reply and his promise to meet again.

What to notice. - Brutus is troubled *before* Cassius begins. His phrase "with himself at war" is the condition Cassius exploits, not something Cassius creates. - Every one of Cassius's arguments attacks the *gap* between Caesar's reputation and his body. He never argues that Caesar has done wrong; he argues that Caesar is no better than they are. - The **offstage shouts** are a stage device that does Cassius's work for him. Each cheer from the crowd makes Brutus more anxious and more receptive. - Brutus says very little, but what he says is decisive: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", and the lines on honour and death. An examiner will expect you to know that Brutus handed Cassius the key. - The scene ends not with a yes but with a promise to think. That restraint is Brutus's character in one gesture.

Scene 2, third movement — Caesar returns; Casca's report; Cassius's soliloquy

What happens. Caesar comes back from the games visibly angry, his train "chidden", Calpurnia pale, Cicero red-eyed. Caesar tells Antony he distrusts Cassius's "lean and hungry look", analyses him with precision, denies any fear, and asks Antony to speak into his good ear. When the procession passes, Brutus and Cassius pull Casca aside. In blunt prose Casca describes how Antony offered Caesar a crown ("one of these coronets") three times, how Caesar refused each time with growing reluctance, how the crowd cheered the refusals, and how Caesar then fainted, foaming at the mouth. He adds that Caesar, before falling, offered the crowd his throat to cut, that Cicero spoke Greek, and that Marullus and Flavius have been silenced. Casca leaves; Brutus departs after arranging to meet Cassius tomorrow; Cassius, alone, reveals his plan to forge letters in several hands and throw them in at Brutus's windows.

What to notice. - Caesar's analysis of Cassius is **correct in every detail** and is then overridden by his vanity. This pattern, insight cancelled by pride, is the Caesar you must be able to describe. - "for always I am Caesar" followed immediately by "this ear is deaf" is one of the sharpest juxtapositions in the play: the public name and the private body in two consecutive lines. - The crown scene is **reported, not shown**. Shakespeare lets us see it only through Casca's contemptuous eyes, so that we never know whether Caesar truly wanted the crown. Casca says "to my thinking, he would fain have had it"; that is an opinion, and you must present it as one. - Casca's prose is a mask. Cassius calls his "rudeness ... a sauce to his good wit"; Brutus remembers him as "quick mettle" at school. The blunt manner hides a sharp observer. - The soliloquy is the only time in Act 1 that a character speaks alone. It tells you the conspiracy will be built on forgery, and it should colour every later claim the conspirators make about honour.

Scene 3 — The storm: Casca, Cicero, Cassius, Cinna

What happens. A month has passed; it is the night before the Ides of March. Thunder and lightning. Casca, sword drawn and breathless, tells Cicero of supernatural sights. Cicero answers that men interpret things to suit themselves, asks whether Caesar will go to the Capitol tomorrow (he will), and leaves. Cassius enters, exhilarated by the storm, and rebukes Casca for fearing it. He explains the portents as heaven's warning against a man grown "prodigious" like the night itself; Casca guesses Caesar. Casca reports the rumour that the Senate will make Caesar king tomorrow. Cassius vows that his dagger will free him from bondage, and launches into a bitter attack on Romans who make Caesar great because "the Romans are but sheep". Casca offers his hand. Cassius reveals that conspirators wait at Pompey's Porch. Cinna arrives, asks whether they can win "the noble Brutus", and is sent to plant the forged letters. Cassius and Casca go to visit Brutus before dawn, Casca noting that Brutus's good name will turn their offence into virtue.

What to notice. - The storm is **read three ways**: as divine anger (Casca), as nothing certain (Cicero), as a political portrait of Caesar and a call to action (Cassius). The scene is a lesson in interpretation itself. - Cassius, who told Brutus that fate is "not in our stars", now uses the heavens as evidence. He is not a consistent philosopher; he is a persuader who uses whatever lies to hand. - The rumour of a crown "In every place save here in Italy" gives the plot a deadline. Act 1 ends with the clock running. - Cassius recruits Casca

by a different method from the one he used on Brutus: shame about manliness ("womanish"), contempt for the crowd, and a theatrical display of courage. Compare the two methods; the comparison is the heart of the Cassius chapter. - Everyone agrees that the conspiracy needs Brutus. The act closes with the conspirators going to collect him, and the forged letters already on their way.

D. Who the important people are

You cannot follow a conversation if you do not know who is speaking, and in Act 1 Shakespeare introduces more than a dozen named Romans in under nine hundred lines. The table below is your cast list. The second column is **historical record** (who the real man was); the third and fourth are a mixture of **Shakespeare's text** and **literary interpretation**, and they tell you what each figure wants in Act 1 and the question you should hold in your mind whenever he appears. Learn the names and the one-line descriptions now; the detailed character chapters later in the book will deepen every entry.

Name	Who he is (historical record)	What he wants in Act 1	How to watch him
Julius Caesar	Rome's greatest general and politician; victor of the civil war against Pompey; dictator, and from February 44 BC dictator for life	To be seen as supremely powerful without being seen to grasp at a crown; to keep the crowd's love	Measure the gap between what is <i>said</i> of him and what he <i>does</i> . He is on stage twice, briefly, and is talked about constantly
Marcus Brutus	A senator of ancient republican family, claiming descent from the Brutus who drove out Rome's last king; fought for Pompey, was pardoned by Caesar and promoted by him; urban praetor in 44 BC	To be left alone with his private trouble; to remain honourable; not to see Caesar made king	Watch him being <i>worked upon</i> . Count how little he says compared with Cassius, and notice every word that reveals he is already half-persuaded
Caius Cassius	A senator and experienced soldier; survived the disaster at Carrhae; fought for Pompey, was pardoned by Caesar; praetor in 44 BC; married to Brutus's sister	To bring Brutus into a conspiracy against Caesar, by any means that work	Watch his <i>technique</i> . Every speech is a tool chosen for a particular listener: one method for Brutus, another for Casca
Mark Antony	Caesar's loyal officer in Gaul and the civil war; consul alongside Caesar in 44 BC; ran as a priest in the Lupercalia race	To serve Caesar and to be seen serving him	Count his lines in Act 1 (very few) and remember them. Shakespeare is hiding something in plain sight
Casca	A senator; historically the man who struck the first blow on the Ides of March	To appear bored and blunt while telling Brutus and Cassius exactly what they need to know; later, to join Cassius	Watch the mask. Is his bluntness real stupidity or a protective disguise? Brutus and Cassius disagree about this in Scene 2
Flavius and Marullus	Tribunes of the people in 44 BC; historically deposed by Caesar for removing a diadem from his statue	To send the crowd home and strip Caesar's statues of their decorations	They are the Republic's conscience in Scene 1 and are "put to silence" by Scene 2. Ask what their fate tells you about Caesar's power
The Soothsayer	A fortune-teller; Plutarch names a seer, Spurinna, who warned Caesar	To warn Caesar of the Ides of March	He speaks one sentence twice. Watch how Caesar handles him

Name	Who he is (historical record)	What he wants in Act 1	How to watch him
Calpurnia	Caesar's wife since 59 BC; childless	Nothing in Act 1; she obeys	Her childlessness is made public business in Caesar's first speech. Remember her pale cheek when Caesar returns from the games
Cicero	Rome's greatest orator; not a conspirator	To go home out of the storm, having said something sceptical	He is the one man who refuses to <i>interpret</i> the storm. Cassius does not invite him in
Cinna	A praetor in 44 BC and a conspirator (not the poet of the same name killed later in the play)	To carry Cassius's letters and to see Brutus won over	He voices aloud what Cassius has been thinking: the conspiracy needs Brutus
Decius Brutus, Metellus Cimber, Trebonius	Senators and conspirators; Decius Brutus was one of Caesar's most trusted officers	To wait for Cassius at Pompey's Porch	Names only in Act 1; you will meet them properly in Act 2
The Carpenter and the Cobbler	Ordinary tradesmen; Shakespeare's invention, standing for the Roman people	To take a holiday and cheer Caesar	They are the crowd given faces and voices. Notice that they are funnier and quicker than the tribunes who scold them
Pompey	Caesar's rival, defeated at Pharsalus in 48 BC and murdered in Egypt; dead four years before the play opens	Nothing; he is dead	He is the ghost of Act 1. The tribunes invoke him, the triumph celebrates victory over his sons, and the conspirators meet at his porch

Two people in that table deserve an extra word now, because students regularly confuse them. There are **two Brutuses** among the conspirators: Marcus Brutus, the hero of the play, and Decius Brutus, a different man entirely (historically Decimus Junius Brutus Albinus) who is merely named in Act 1. When Cassius or Cinna say 'Brutus' without a first name, they always mean Marcus. And there are **two Cinnas** in the play: Cinna the conspirator, who appears in Scene 3, and Cinna the poet, who does not appear until Act 3 and is torn apart by the mob for sharing a name. Keep them apart from the start.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Where Shakespeare found his people

Nearly every named character in Act 1 comes from Plutarch's *Parallel Lives*, written in Greek around AD 100 and translated into English by Sir Thomas North in 1579. Shakespeare read North closely, sometimes lifting whole sentences into verse, and he drew chiefly on three of the Lives: those of Caesar, Brutus and Antony. But he also *changed* what he found. Plutarch's tribunes acted in January 44 BC, weeks before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare puts their protest on the same day as the triumph and the festival. Plutarch's diadem was offered twice; Shakespeare's Casca says three times, which makes the ritual feel more deliberate. Plutarch records that anonymous messages were left for Brutus urging him to act; Shakespeare gives the forgery to Cassius, so that the conspiracy's noblest recruit is won by a lie. Caesar's epilepsy, his "falling sickness", is in Plutarch and Suetonius; his deafness in one ear is not in any ancient source and appears to be Shakespeare's own invention. Whenever you meet a vivid detail in Act 1, it is worth asking: did Shakespeare find this, or make it? The additions are where his purposes show most clearly.

CHRONOLOGICAL TIMELINE LEADING INTO ACT 1

Read this table from top to bottom once, then use it for revision. Dates are the historical record; the last column tells you why each one matters to the play.

Date	Event	Why it matters to Act 1
509 BC (traditional)	Lucius Junius Brutus expels King Tarquin; the Republic is founded on hatred of the word <i>rex</i>	Cassius's "There was a Brutus once"; the forged letters on "old Brutus' statue"; the horror at "king"
494 BC	First secession of the plebs; tribunes of the plebs created, sacrosanct and armed with a veto	Flavius and Marullus in Scene 1 are exercising this ancient protective office
287 BC	Plebeian assembly's decisions become binding on all Rome; legal equality of plebeians complete	The commoners of Scene 1 are full citizens whose votes and cheers carry political weight
107–100 BC	Marius holds repeated consulships; the legions become long-service armies loyal to their generals	Caesar's power in the play rests on soldiers; the war of Acts 4–5 follows this pattern
88–81 BC	Sulla marches on Rome and rules as dictator beyond the six-month limit	Precedent for a general seizing Rome and for a dictatorship without end
60 BC	Caesar, Pompey and Crassus form the First Triumvirate	Beginning of Caesar's climb; origin of his alliance with Pompey
59 BC	Caesar consul; Pompey marries Caesar's daughter Julia; Caesar marries Calpurnia	Calpurnia is the wife Caesar asks Antony to touch; Julia is the bond that will break
58–50 BC	Gallic Wars; Alesia 52 BC	The conquests behind the "conquest" Marullus questions
54 BC	Julia dies	The personal tie between Caesar and Pompey is gone
53 BC	Crassus killed at Carrhae	Two rivals remain; Cassius survives the disaster
10–11 January 49 BC	Caesar crosses the Rubicon after tribunes (including Antony) flee to him	Civil war begins; Antony's loyalty to Caesar dates from here
49 BC	Caesar dictator for the first time, briefly	First step in the sequence 49 → 46 → 44
9 August 48 BC	Pharsalus: Pompey defeated; Brutus and Cassius later pardoned	The "pardoned Pompeians" of the conspiracy owe Caesar their lives
28 September 48 BC	Pompey murdered in Egypt	Marullus's "Knew you not Pompey?"; "Pompey's blood"
46 BC	Thapsus; Cato's suicide; four triumphs; Caesar dictator for ten years	Honours begin to look royal; Cato, Brutus's kinsman and later father-in-law, becomes a republican martyr
17 March 45 BC	Munda: Pompey's sons defeated; Gnaeus killed	The Roman-versus-Roman victory that the Scene 1 triumph celebrates
October 45 BC	Spanish triumph, resented as a triumph over Romans	Marullus's "What tributaries follow him to Rome"
1 January 44 BC	Caesar and Antony consuls; Brutus urban praetor, Cassius praetor	"the praetor's chair" in Scene 3; Antony's official standing

Date	Event	Why it matters to Act 1
January 44 BC (most reconstructions)	Diadem placed on Caesar's statue; tribunes Marullus and Flavus remove it and are deposed	Scene 1's "Disrobe the images"; Casca's "put to silence"
February 44 BC	Caesar named <i>dictator perpetuo</i>	The last constitutional brake removed; "Age, thou art shamed!"
15 February 44 BC	Lupercalia: Antony offers the diadem (twice in Plutarch); Caesar refuses and sends it to Jupiter	Casca's report of the crown refused "thrice"
14 March 44 BC	Eve of the Senate meeting; Plutarch lists portents before the Ides but does not date them to this one night	Act 1 Scene 3 places the storm and omens here: "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?"
15 March 44 BC	Caesar assassinated in the Curia of Pompey	"Beware the ides of March"; the day the whole of Act 1 points toward

HISTORICAL CONTEXT What the Ides actually were

The Roman month had three fixed marker days: the Kalends (the 1st), the Nones (the 5th, or the 7th in March, May, July and October) and the Ides (the 15th in those same four months, the 13th in all the others). The Ides were sacred to Jupiter. So "Beware the ides of March" would have sounded to a Roman exactly like 'beware the fifteenth of March': a date, not a riddle. The eeriness is Shakespeare's; to Caesar it is a calendar entry, which is partly why he can dismiss the speaker as "a dreamer". There is a historical root. Plutarch and Suetonius record that a seer named Spurinna warned Caesar of danger coming no later than the Ides of March; Shakespeare strips away the name and gives the warning to a nameless Soothsayer in the crowd. The ICSE 2025 board paper asked candidates what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to: a student who knows that the Ides is simply 15 March, the day of the assassination, answers in one clean sentence.

WHAT SHAKESPEARE CHANGED

This section is the one that will most distinguish you from other students. Shakespeare read history carefully and then altered it deliberately. Below, each change is set out as **HISTORICAL RECORD** against **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT**, followed by the likely reason (**LITERARY INTERPRETATION**). Keep these labels in your own notes; confusing the two is the most common error in student writing about this play.

Three events compressed into one day

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Spanish triumph took place in October 45 BC. The tribunes' removal of the diadem from Caesar's statue is placed by most modern reconstructions in January 44 BC. The Lupercalia was 15 February 44 BC. Three separate events, spread over four months.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. In Act 1 Scenes 1 and 2 they all happen on a single day. The commoners "make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph"; Marullus says "it is the feast of Lupercal"; the tribunes strip the statues; Antony runs his course; the crown is offered; and by the end of Scene 2 the tribunes "are put to silence".

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Compression gives the opening of the play a single, overwhelming day of Caesar's glory, and it lets cause and consequence sit side by side: the tribunes act in Scene 1 and are destroyed in Scene 2. It also means Shakespeare can show the fickle crowd, the childless ruler, the refused crown and the

first stirrings of conspiracy within the first forty minutes of stage time.

The silent month before Scene 3

HISTORICAL RECORD. From the Lupercalia (15 February) to the Ides (15 March) is one month.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Scene 2 ends with Cassius planning to throw letters "this night"; Scene 3 opens in a storm, and Cicero asks "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" Casca replies that Caesar "did bid Antonius / Send word to you he would be there tomorrow." Cassius says "it is after midnight". So Scene 3 is the night of 14 March. A whole month has passed between two consecutive scenes, and nothing in the dialogue marks it. Some editors and readers feel that Scene 3 follows Scene 2 on the same night; the text supports the month-long gap through Cicero's question, but leaves the sensation of continuity intact.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Shakespeare wants the conspiracy to feel like a single accelerating movement from the first shout to the first blow. A month of quiet plotting would dissipate that energy. He simply omits it, trusting that an audience feels time as pressure, not as a calendar.

The Capitol versus the Curia of Pompey

HISTORICAL RECORD. Caesar was killed on 15 March 44 BC in the Curia of Pompey, a meeting hall attached to Pompey's theatre complex, beneath a statue of Pompey. He was not on the Capitoline hill.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Act 1 repeatedly places the coming Senate meeting at the Capitol: Cicero asks "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?"; Casca has met a lion "Against the Capitol"; and the assassination in Act 3 takes place there. At the same time, the conspirators meet at "Pompey's Porch" and "Pompey's Theatre", so the real location survives in the play as the plotters' base rather than the murder site.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Elizabethan writers commonly imagined the Capitol as Rome's seat of government, much as we say 'Westminster' for Parliament. Shakespeare follows that habit, and gains a symbolic setting: the hill of Jupiter, where triumphs ended, becomes the place where the triumphant man is cut down.

Caesar's deafness

HISTORICAL RECORD. No ancient source says Caesar was deaf in one ear. Plutarch and Suetonius do record epileptic seizures, the "falling sickness" Brutus diagnoses.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Caesar tells Antony, "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him."

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. The deafness appears to be Shakespeare's invention, and it arrives at a perfectly chosen moment: immediately after Caesar's most penetrating speech about how well he reads men. The man who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men" cannot hear on one side. Many critics read this as a small emblem of the whole character, magnificent in judgement and defective in perception, though the text does not label it so.

Three crown offerings versus Plutarch's two

HISTORICAL RECORD. In Plutarch's account Antony offered the diadem twice, and both times the refusal drew louder applause than the offer.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Brutus asks Casca "Was the crown offered him thrice?" and Casca answers "Ay, marry, was 't, and he put it by thrice, every time gentler than other" ('marry' is a mild oath meaning 'indeed'; to 'put by' is to push aside). Cassius has already counted the offstage noise: "They shouted thrice."

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Three is the number of ritual and folk tale, and it lets Casca chart a decline: each refusal "gentler than other", each one, in his telling, more reluctant. Two refusals could be modesty; three graded refusals look like performance. Shakespeare also adds Casca's cynicism that Caesar "would fain have had it", which is nowhere in Plutarch, so the audience receives the event already interpreted by an enemy.

The tribunes' timing and fate

HISTORICAL RECORD. The tribunes removed a diadem from a statue and arrested men who hailed Caesar as king, most probably in January 44 BC. Caesar deposed them from office.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. The tribunes act on the day of the triumph and the Lupercalia, and Casca reports that they "for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. By moving their action onto the festival day and leaving their fate ambiguous, Shakespeare makes the punishment fall with shocking speed and lets the audience fear the worst. The phrase 'put to silence' is deliberately colder than 'removed from office'.

Graffiti into forged letters

HISTORICAL RECORD. Plutarch says that anonymous messages appeared on Brutus's praetor's chair and on the statue of his ancestor, urging him to act. Their authors are unknown.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cassius plans the letters himself: "I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name", and in Scene 3 gives Cinna the papers for "the praetor's chair" and "old Brutus' statue".

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. This is the change that most alters the moral shape of the play. In history, Brutus may have been responding to real public feeling; in Shakespeare, he is deceived by a friend. One strong reading is that the forged letters compromise the conspiracy's claim to honour from the outset, and that the audience, unlike Brutus, knows it.

REVISION The changes in one glance

Triumph (October 45 BC) + tribunes (January 44 BC) + Lupercalia (15 February 44 BC) → one day. One silent month between Scenes 2 and 3. Curia of Pompey → the Capitol. Deafness → invented. Two offerings → three, plus Casca's cynicism. Tribunes deposed → 'put to silence'. Anonymous graffiti → Cassius's forgeries. Learn these seven and you will never again write history as if it were the play, or the play as if it were history.

Scene 1: what to carry into the exam

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 1 Scene 1

Five must-remember events. (1) The tribunes Flavius and Marullus find tradesmen in holiday clothes on the street and order them home. (2) The Cobbler evades their questions with a chain of puns about soles, mending, the awl and being a surgeon to old shoes. (3) The Cobbler admits the crowd is out to see Caesar and rejoice in his triumph. (4) Marullus denounces the crowd for forgetting Pompey and cheering the man who triumphs over "Pompey's blood"; the commoners leave in silence. (5) Flavius and Marullus split up to strip Caesar's statues of their decorations, despite Marullus's worry that it is the feast of Lupercal.

Five keywords. Fickleness; ingratitude; republicanism; public opinion; hierarchy (class).

Three quotations. "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" (Marullus to the crowd). "And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?" (Marullus — the proof of fickleness). "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch" (Flavius — the republican fear).

Three character insights. The Cobbler is witty, self-interested and never quite insolent — proof that the common people are not fools. Marullus is the orator and the pious one; he moves the crowd but hesitates on a holy day. Flavius is the man of action and the clearest political thinker; his decisiveness gets both tribunes silenced.

Three themes. The fickleness of public opinion (Pompey → Caesar). The fear of one man rising above the Republic. Class conflict between officials and commoners, marked by verse against prose.

Two literary devices. Pun (soles/souls, awl/all, withal/with awl, recover/re-cover). Extended metaphor (Caesar as a falcon whose feathers must be plucked) — with anaphora ("And do you now...") and rhetorical question as the next two to name.

Two historical points. Caesar's Spanish triumph (October 45 BC) celebrated victory over Pompey's sons at Munda and was resented because it was a victory over Romans. The historical tribunes removed a diadem from Caesar's statue and were deposed; Shakespeare moves the episode to the day of the triumph and the Lupercal.

Three connections. Casca in Scene 2: the tribunes "are put to silence" for pulling scarves off Caesar's images. Cassius in Scene 2: the Colossus speech is Flavius's falcon fear restated with envy. Act 3 Scene 2: the crowd that swung from Pompey to Caesar swings from Brutus to Antony.

One central idea. The crowd's love makes a man great and can be moved by anyone with words — so whoever controls the crowd controls Rome, and the republicans who despise the crowd have already lost it.

ICSE EXAM BOX How Scene 1 earns marks — honestly stated

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. For the ICSE Class X board paper, the prescribed portion of *Julius Caesar* is Acts III, IV and V; Acts I and II are the Class IX portion, examined in school. So an extract from Scene 1 in the board paper is not to be expected, and no one can promise you any question. But the Class X drama extract question — worth 16 marks, and in the 2025 paper divided into five sub-questions marked [3], [3], [3], [3] and [4] — repeatedly asks what happened earlier, why a character behaves as he does, and what a moment reveals about character or theme. Those are exactly the places where Scene 1 knowledge lifts an answer from adequate to excellent. Three uses to memorise: (1) any question on the crowd in Act 3 Scene 2 or 3 Scene 3 — cite the Pompey-to-Caesar shift as the first swing of a pattern; (2) any question on the conspirators' motives or on Caesar's tyranny — cite the tribunes' fear of a man who would "soar above the view of men" and their punishment for touching his statues; (3) any question about Antony's or Brutus's rhetoric — note that the play's first orator, Marullus, also used rhetorical questions and shaming to move a crowd, and that it worked only briefly. For Class IX internal tests, reference-to-context questions on the Cobbler's puns, Marullus's speech and Flavius's closing image are the usual fare (though no particular question can be predicted); the line-by-line section later in this chapter is built for those.

WEAK ANSWER A weak answer

Marullus is angry with the commoners because they are celebrating Caesar's triumph and not working. He insults them by calling them blocks and stones because they are stupid.

EXCELLENT ANSWER An excellent answer

Marullus is enraged that the commoners are celebrating Caesar's triumph, which he regards as a victory "over Pompey's blood" — over fellow Romans — rather than a true conquest. He calls them "blocks" and "stones" because, like inert matter, they seem incapable of feeling or memory: they have forgotten how they once cheered "great Pompey" until the Tiber trembled. But they are "worse than senseless things" because stones cannot be ungrateful, whereas the crowd has feelings and yet has betrayed its old hero. The insult thus introduces the theme of the crowd's fickleness, which Shakespeare will develop when the same crowd turns from Brutus to Antony in Act 3.

Scene 2: what to carry into the exam

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 1 Scene 2

5 must-remember events 1. Caesar's procession returns angry; Brutus reads the faces — the "angry spot", the "chidden train", Calpurnia pale, Cicero's "ferret and such fiery eyes". 2. Caesar tells Antony he distrusts "lean and hungry" Cassius; Antony calls him "a noble Roman, and well given"; Caesar claims "always I am Caesar" and admits "this ear is deaf". 3. Casca reports that Antony offered Caesar a coronet three times, that Caesar refused it "every time gentler than other", that the crowd cheered the refusals, and that Caesar "swooned and fell down". 4. Casca adds that Cicero "spoke Greek" and that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence". 5. Brutus and Cassius agree to meet tomorrow; alone, Cassius plans forged letters "in several hands" and vows "we will shake him, or worse days endure".

5 keywords soliloquy · reported action · dramatic irony · illeism · forgery

3 quotations "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." (Caesar) "for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" (Caesar) "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed" (Cassius)

3 character insights Caesar reads Cassius accurately and acts on comfort rather than truth — a perceptive man, not a blind one. Casca hides a sharp political eye under a "tardy form" of bluntness; his "to my thinking" is opinion, not proof. Cassius is sincere and manipulative at once: he believes Caesar must fall and he forges letters to make Brutus believe it too.

3 themes Appearance versus reality (the public Caesar and the private one) · Manipulation and the ethics of means (the letters) · Public opinion and politics as theatre (the clapping, hissing crowd)

2 literary devices Pun — "the falling sickness" (epilepsy / Rome's political fall) · Rhyming couplet — "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure"

2 historical points Plutarch records Caesar's remark about fat and thin men, the diadem offered at the Lupercalia (twice, not thrice) and the deposition of the two tribunes; the deaf ear is Shakespeare's invention. The anonymous messages that historically urged Brutus to act become, in Shakespeare, Cassius's personal forgeries.

3 connections Scene 1 → Scene 2: Flavius's "Disrobe the images" leads to the tribunes "put to silence". Scene 2 → Act 2 Scene 1: "Come home to me" and the forged letters lead to Brutus's orchard and the conspirators at his door. Scene 2 → Act 3 Scene 2: Casca's cynical account of the triple refusal is retold by Antony as proof that Caesar was not ambitious.

1 central idea Rome judges Caesar by signs and reports it cannot verify — and the conspiracy is built on an interpretation, not a proof.

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer — what not to write about Casca's report

'Casca tells Brutus and Cassius that Antony offered Caesar the crown three times and Caesar refused it three times. The people cheered. Then Caesar fainted because he had epilepsy. Casca also says Cicero spoke Greek and the tribunes were punished. This shows that Caesar was a hypocrite who really wanted the crown.' — This retells the plot, treats Casca's opinion as fact ('really wanted'), quotes nothing, names no device, and makes no connection to the rest of the play. It would earn little beyond the marks for basic recall.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer — the same material, properly used

'Shakespeare does not stage the crown offering; he lets Casca report it in sour prose, so that the day's most important political event reaches us filtered through a cynic. Casca twice marks his account as opinion — "to my thinking" — and his claim that Caesar "would fain have had it" is an inference from a hand that was "very loath to lay his fingers off it". The crowd, meanwhile, cheered every refusal "as they use to do the players in the theatre", an image that makes Roman politics a performance judged by its audience. Two further details carry weight: Caesar "swooned and fell down" at the third refusal, completing Cassius's earlier catalogue of the weak body behind the great name, and the tribunes "are put to silence", dropped by Casca as an afterthought though it is the scene's hardest evidence of tyranny. The effect is that the conspiracy will act on interpretation rather than proof — which is exactly what Antony exploits in Act 3 Scene 2 when he turns the same triple refusal into evidence of Caesar's humility.' — Short quotations, the report/fact distinction, a device named and explained, and a connection forward.

PUBLIC CAESAR / PRIVATE CAESAR

Scene 2 is the only scene in the play that shows you both Caesars on the same day, and most of the private evidence comes from Part Two. The table separates what Rome sees from what the audience is allowed to see. Remember the labels: the left two columns are SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT; the right-hand column is LITERARY INTERPRETATION.

Aspect	PUBLIC CAESAR (what Rome sees)	PRIVATE CAESAR (what the audience learns)	What the gap tells you
Fear	"I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear"; "always I am Caesar"	He names the one man he "should avoid / So soon as" — Cassius — and asks Antony to "tell me truly"	The denial of fear and the description of fear are the same speech; the public self is a performance for the private self too
The body	He strides at the head of a "chidden train", refuses a crown with "the back of his hand", bares his throat	"this ear is deaf"; he "swooned and fell down"; "foamed at mouth and was speechless"	The name is immortal; the man is not. The play's whole treatment of Caesar lives in this gap
Kingship	Refuses the coronet "thrice, every time gentler than other" while the crowd cheers	Casca's reading: "he would fain have had it"; "very loath to lay his fingers off it"; the "angry spot" Brutus sees afterwards	We are never shown his desire — only a cynic's inference and a flush of anger. Shakespeare keeps the private wish unprovable
Judgement of men	Wants "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights"	Reads Cassius exactly: "He reads much, / He is a great observer... Seldom he smiles"	Caesar is perceptive about his enemy and chooses comfort over truth; the tragedy is in the choice, not in blindness
Humility	Apologises to the crowd and asks them to blame "his infirmity"; the wenches forgive him "with all their hearts"	Has the tribunes "put to silence" the same day for touching his statues	Public humility and private absolutism coexist; the apology is theatre, the silencing is power
Relationship to warnings	Dismisses the Soothsayer as "a dreamer" before all Rome	Turns his good ear to Antony because the other is deaf	The man who cannot hear on one side is the man who will not hear; many readers take the deaf ear as an emblem of this

Aspect	PUBLIC CAESAR (what Rome sees)	PRIVATE CAESAR (what the audience learns)	What the gap tells you
Language	Commands and maxims: "Set on, and leave no ceremony out"; "Such men are dangerous"	Hesitations and reversals: "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. / Yet..."	In public Caesar speaks in rules; in private his sentences double back on themselves

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The two Caesars and the problem of the 'tyrant'

Students are often taught to decide whether Caesar 'is' a tyrant, and to collect evidence on each side. Scene 2 suggests that this is the wrong question, or at least a question Shakespeare deliberately refuses to answer. Look at the evidence the scene actually supplies. For tyranny: a court that looks "chidden", tribunes "put to silence", a Caesar who speaks of having "men about me" as a king speaks of courtiers. Against tyranny: a crown refused three times before a cheering crowd, an apology to the people, a sick and deaf man of middle age. For ambition: a cynic's "to my thinking" and a flush of anger. Against: nothing Caesar says or does on stage. The balance is not accidental. Shakespeare has built a Caesar whose public gestures can be read either way and whose private wishes are never shown, so that the conspirators must act on interpretation — and so must we. This is why Brutus, in Act 2, will have to reason from what Caesar 'may' become rather than from what he has done, and why Antony, in Act 3, will be able to turn the same facts the other way. When you write about Caesar's character, resist the verdict and describe the design: a man built to be construed. That is a far stronger answer than 'Caesar was arrogant' or 'Caesar was not really ambitious', and it is the answer the text supports.

Scene 3: what to carry into the exam

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 1 Scene 3

5 must-remember events 1. A night of thunder and "a tempest dropping fire": Casca, sword drawn, reports four prodigies to Cicero (burning hand, lion at the Capitol, women who saw men on fire, owl at noon). 2. Cicero warns that men construe things "after their fashion", fixes the date by asking whether Caesar comes to the Capitol tomorrow, and goes home. 3. Cassius, bare-chested in the lightning, reinterprets the storm as a warning against a man "Most like this dreadful night"; Casca reports the rumour that the senators will crown Caesar tomorrow. 4. Cassius vows suicide before slavery, blames Rome's sheep for Caesar's wolf, tests Casca ("Before a willing bondman"), and Casca gives his hand and his oath. 5. Cinna arrives; Cassius sends him with forged letters for Brutus's chair, window and ancestor's statue; the conspirators plan to visit Brutus before dawn.

5 keywords — portent (omen) · construe (interpret) · bondage / bondman · factious / redress · alchemy (transformation of appearance).

3 quotations - "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" (Cicero). - "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" (Cassius). - "His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" (Casca, of Brutus).

3 character insights - Casca: the sneer of Scene 2 was armour; under it is a frightened believer who is recruited through fear and shame and will strike first. - Cassius: he does not believe or disbelieve the omens — he uses them; yet by the scene's end he reads the sky as his own omen, and his control twice slips. - Cicero: the only cool head, given the truest line and removed before it can interfere — reason's fate in a time of faction.

3 themes — Superstition and interpretation (three readings of one storm) · Liberty versus bondage (the dagger as freedom) · Honour and deception (forged letters to win an honourable man).

2 literary devices — Extended simile/metaphor (Caesar as the storm; wolf and sheep) · Dramatic irony ("A very pleasing night to honest men"; the letters the audience knows are forged).

2 historical points — Plutarch supplies the prodigies, the rumour of kingship outside Italy and the anonymous messages to Brutus; Shakespeare adds the lion, makes the messages Cassius's forgeries, and moves the killing from the Curia of Pompey to the Capitol · The historical Cassius was an Epicurean who did not believe omens were divine messages — which colours his use of them here.

3 connections — Backwards: the letters execute the plan of Cassius's Scene 2 soliloquy · Forwards: the storm runs on into Brutus's orchard and Caesar's house (Act 2), and "opens graves" prepares Caesar's Ghost · Fulfilment: the dagger named here kills Cassius at Philippi; the hand given here strikes first at the Capitol.

1 central idea — The storm decides nothing; the interpreter does. Scene 3 is about how fear is given a meaning and a target, and how a conspiracy that calls itself honourable begins with a forgery.

WEAK ANSWER A weak use of the scene (do not write this)

'In Act 1 Scene 3 there was a big storm and Casca was scared. Cassius was not scared. They decided to kill Caesar. This shows the theme of fate.'

EXCELLENT ANSWER A strong use of the scene

'Scene 3 shows Shakespeare's method of turning atmosphere into argument. Casca reads the storm as divine anger, Cicero warns that men "construe things after their fashion", and Cassius immediately proves Cicero right by construing the same omens as a warning against a man "Most like this dreadful night". The storm does not decide anything; the interpreter does — which is why the scene is about persuasion, not fate.'

The Soothsayer and the Ides of March

The moment itself: what actually happens

Before we analyse anything, you must be able to see the moment. Read it as a director would.

Caesar has just entered Rome's public square in procession. It is the feast of Lupercal (the Lupercalia, a February festival of purification and fertility at which young men ran through the city striking bystanders with goat-hide thongs). He gives two brisk domestic orders: Calpurnia must stand in Antony's way as he runs the ritual race, and Antony must remember to touch her so that she may "Shake off their sterile curse". Antony answers with a line of total obedience. Caesar closes the business with "Set on and leave no ceremony out." The procession begins to move.

Then a single voice cuts through the trumpets:

Soothsayer: *Caesar.*

Caesar stops. "Ha! Who calls?" Casca, who has already once shouted the crowd into silence, does it again: "Bid every noise be still. Peace, yet again!" Caesar, now attending, speaks a line that tells us he has actually heard something unusual: "I hear a tongue shriller than all the music / Cry 'Caesar.' Speak. Caesar is turned to hear." And the Soothsayer says the five words that the entire play will circle:

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar does not understand at first — or pretends not to: "What man is that?" It is Brutus, of all people, who repeats the warning to him: "A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March." Caesar demands to look at the man — "Set him before me. Let me see his face." — and it is Cassius, the future instigator, who fetches him: "Fellow, come from the throng. / Look upon Caesar." Caesar gives the man a second chance: "What sayst thou to me now? Speak once again." The Soothsayer simply repeats himself, word for word: "Beware the ides of March." And Caesar delivers his verdict in three short sentences:

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

A trumpet call (the stage direction says *Sennet*) and everyone leaves except Brutus and Cassius. The whole exchange is fifteen lines long. Shakespeare spends more time on the Cobbler's puns than on the prophecy of Caesar's death. That brevity is itself a choice, and we will come back to it.

Difficult words in this passage (learn them now; they recur in exam extracts):

Word / phrase	Simple meaning	Note
soothsayer	a truth-teller; a fortune-teller or prophet	Old English <i>sooth</i> = truth. The word itself claims that what he says is true.
the press	the crowd, the crush of people	Not a newspaper. Caesar asks who "in the press" is calling him.
shriller	higher and more piercing	The voice is thin and sharp enough to cut through music.
ides	the middle marker-day of a Roman month	Explained fully below.
throng	crowd	Cassius tells the man to "come from the throng".
dreamer	someone who sees visions; also, dismissively, someone whose head is in the clouds	Caesar's word deliberately allows both meanings.
Sennet	a set of trumpet notes announcing a ceremonial entrance or exit	A stage direction, not spoken.

Literal meaning: what the sentence actually says

Take the sentence at its plainest. **Beware** means 'be on your guard against'. **The ides of March** is a date, and only a date: the fifteenth of March. So the literal instruction is: 'be careful on 15 March'.

Notice what the sentence does *not* say. It does not say what to fear, or from whom, or where, or how. It names a time and nothing else. This is the classic shape of a prophecy in literature — precise about one thing and silent about everything that would allow the hearer to act on it. A warning that only names a day is almost useless as advice; Caesar could stay at home on 15 March (and in Act 2 he very nearly does), but he cannot know what he is avoiding. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics observe that the vagueness of the warning is exactly what allows the play to test Caesar's character rather than his information. He is not given a fact to check; he is given a choice about whether to take a stranger seriously.

Notice, too, that the Soothsayer says it twice, in identical words. When Caesar asks him to "Speak once again", a lesser dramatist would have had the man elaborate. Shakespeare has him repeat. The effect is of a message that cannot be negotiated, expanded or bargained with. It simply is. The repetition is also practical stagecraft: an Elizabethan audience in a noisy open-air playhouse hears the key line twice, so no one misses it.

Finally, look at the grammar of the name. **Ides** looks like a plural, and in Latin (*Idus*) it is a plural noun — yet it names a single day. English keeps the plural form: we say 'the Ides of March *are* come', never 'is'. When you meet this in Act 3, do not think it is a mistake.

Historical meaning: the Ides of March in the Roman calendar

HISTORICAL CONTEXT How Romans dated a month: Kalends, Nones, Ides

HISTORICAL RECORD. Romans did not count the days of a month from 1 to 30 as we do. Each month had three fixed marker-days, and every other date was reckoned by counting *backwards* from the next marker:

- **Kalends** — the first day of the month. The word comes from the Latin verb meaning 'to call out', because the priests originally announced the new month aloud. Our word *calendar* descends from it.
- **Nones** — the fifth day of most months, but the seventh in March, May, July and October. The name means 'ninth', because the Nones fell nine days before the Ides by the Roman inclusive way of counting.
- **Ides** — the thirteenth day of most months, but the **fifteenth** in March, May, July and October (the four months that were originally longer). In the oldest Roman calendar, which followed the moon, the Ides marked the full moon.

The Ides of every month were sacred to **Jupiter**, the king of the gods; a sacrifice was offered to him on that day. So the Ides of March means the fifteenth of March, a holy day of Jupiter, in the middle of what had once been the first month of the Roman year.

In **44 BC** the Ides of March was the day on which the real Julius Caesar was assassinated at a meeting of the Senate held in the Curia of Pompey, a hall attached to Pompey's great theatre complex — not, as Shakespeare has it, on the Capitol. The ancient biographers record that a seer — Suetonius names him **Spurinna**; Plutarch leaves him nameless — had warned Caesar that he faced danger which would come no later than the Ides of March. Shakespeare's Soothsayer has no name; he is Spurinna stripped down to a voice.

Why does this matter to you as a reader? Because Shakespeare's Soothsayer is not inventing a superstition; he is naming a date that every educated person in the 1599 audience already knew. The Ides of March was, and remains, one of the few dates from antiquity that ordinary people can recite. That fact changes everything about how the line works in the theatre, which brings us to dramatic irony.

TEXT NOTE The word 'ides' in your edition

Some school editions print 'Ides' with a capital letter, some without; Folger and the MIT text both use lower case within the line. Neither is wrong. In an answer, either is acceptable, but be consistent. What matters is never to write 'Ide of March' in the singular.

Dramatic irony: the audience knows the date; Caesar does not

Dramatic irony is the gap between what a character knows and what the audience knows. It is not the same as sarcasm or verbal irony (saying one thing and meaning another). It is a structural device: the playwright arranges for us to hold knowledge that the person on stage lacks, so that we watch every word and gesture with a double awareness.

Here the gap could hardly be wider. Caesar hears 'the ides of March' as an empty date — one more day in a busy calendar. We hear it as the day of his death. When he says "He is a dreamer", we know that the dreamer is the one person on stage who is fully awake to reality. When he says "Pass", he is dismissing not a beggar but

the truth. And there is a further twist that repays close reading: Caesar says "Caesar is turned to hear" and then does not, in any meaningful sense, hear. He demands to see the man's face — "Let me see his face" — and, having looked, sees nothing. The whole exchange is built around eyes and ears that do not do their job.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: this is one of the reasons the exchange sits so close to Cassius's mirror speech a few lines later, in which Brutus admits that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things." Act 1 Scene 2 is full of failures of sight: Caesar looks at the Soothsayer and sees a dreamer; Brutus cannot see himself; Caesar reads Cassius's danger correctly but then boasts he does not fear him. The Soothsayer scene is the first and clearest instance of a leader looking straight at a warning and not seeing it.

The word **dreamer** rewards a second look. To an Elizabethan, a 'dreamer' could be a visionary — someone to whom truths are revealed in dreams — or simply an idle fantasist. Caesar means the second; the play proves the first. And there is a sting the audience may feel that Caesar cannot: the man who dismisses a dreamer will, in Act 2, be given a true dream by his own wife, and will dismiss that too. The pattern is set here.

There is one more layer. Dramatic irony works only if the audience genuinely knows. Shakespeare could rely on it because the death of Caesar was among the best-known stories in Europe: grammar-school boys read Caesar in Latin, Plutarch's *Lives* had been available in Sir Thomas North's English translation since 1579, and the title of the play itself promised a tragedy. In this play, then, dramatic irony is not a trick played on a few sharp spectators. It is the play's basic condition, shared by everyone in the house. You, reading it in Class 10 already knowing how Act 3 ends, are in exactly the position Shakespeare designed the play for. That is not a disadvantage; it is the intended experience.

Foreshadowing: the difference between a prophecy and a plant

Students often use 'foreshadowing' and 'prophecy' as if they were the same thing. They are not, and the distinction earns marks.

A **prophecy** is something a *character* does: the Soothsayer predicts the future inside the story.

Foreshadowing is something the *author* does: Shakespeare plants a hint early so that a later event feels prepared, inevitable, and rich with meaning when it arrives. The Soothsayer's line is both at once — a prophecy inside the fiction and a piece of foreshadowing in the design — which is why it is such a useful example to write about.

But the Soothsayer is only the loudest of several plants in Act 1. Some are spoken warnings; some are images; some are small facts that will grow. Flavius's fear that Caesar will "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness" foreshadows the tyranny the conspirators claim to prevent. Brutus's confession that he is "with himself at war" foreshadows the sleepless orchard soliloquy (a speech spoken alone on stage, thinking aloud) of Act 2 and, ultimately, his self-destruction. Cassius's plan to throw "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" through Brutus's windows foreshadows the moment Brutus reads them. Casca's storm foreshadows Calpurnia's omens. Even the offhand news that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" foreshadows how this Rome will deal with dissent — with a knife, in the end, in both directions.

You will find all of these gathered in the **FORESHADOWING MAP** later in this chapter, with a third column telling you exactly what to say about each in an answer. For now, hold on to the principle: *foreshadowing is not a guessing game about the plot. It is the way a tragedy teaches its audience to feel that what happens had to happen.*

Fate: the reading in which the Soothsayer is the voice of destiny

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. One strong and long-established reading treats the Soothsayer as the voice of **fate** — the Roman *fatum*, the thing that has been 'spoken' by the gods and cannot be unspoken. On this reading, the play's universe is one in which the future is fixed, the signs of it are everywhere (the Soothsayer, the storm, the lion, the owl at noon, Calpurnia's dream, the birds that will hover over Cassius's army before the battle of Philippi in Act 5), and human beings are free only to read the signs well or badly. Caesar reads them badly and dies. Cassius, who begins by denying the signs, ends by half-believing them, and also dies. Brutus pays the signs almost no heed until Caesar's ghost visits him in Act 4, and dies. The Soothsayer, in this reading, is the still point around which the whole machine turns: he knows, and knowing does him no good, because knowledge cannot alter fate.

There is a real philosophical puzzle buried here, and a good student should be able to state it. *Why warn a man of something that cannot be avoided?* A warning only makes sense if the future is open. Yet the play never gives Caesar a realistic chance of avoiding the Ides — every attempt to keep him home is overturned. So the Soothsayer's warning is at once an invitation to choose and a proof that choice is useless. Tragedy lives in exactly that contradiction. You do not have to resolve it. You have to be able to see it and say it.

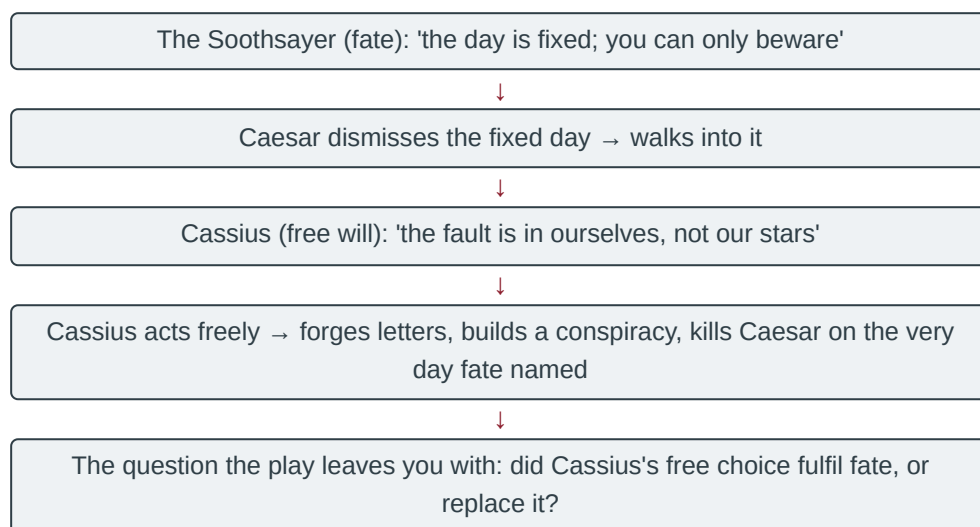
Free will: Cassius's counter-claim, and the play's central tension

Now set against the Soothsayer the most famous sentence Cassius speaks in Act 1, in the middle of his long attempt to win Brutus:

Cassius: *Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings.*

Stars here means astrological destiny — the belief, very much alive in 1599, that the positions of the planets at one's birth shaped one's life. **Underlings** are inferiors, people beneath others. Cassius is saying: the reason we are Caesar's inferiors is not written in the heavens; it is our own fault, and therefore our own to correct. This is a declaration of **free will** — the doctrine that human beings choose and are responsible for their choices.

Here is the shape of the tension, laid out as a chain:



LITERARY INTERPRETATION — presented as interpretation, not fact. Notice that the Soothsayer and Cassius never meet or argue, yet the play sets them side by side within a hundred lines of each other, as if to stage a debate without telling us who wins. Three observations are worth making in any essay:

1. *Cassius's free will produces exactly what fate predicted.* The conspirators choose the Ides of March for their own practical reasons, yet by choosing it they make the Soothsayer right. Free action and destiny arrive at the same place. Many critics read this as Shakespeare's refusal to decide between the two — or as his suggestion that human choices *are* the instrument through which fate works.
2. *Cassius does not even believe his own doctrine consistently.* In Act 1 Scene 3, on the night of the storm, the man who said the fault is not in our stars is busily reading the heavens: he tells Casca the prodigies (unnatural, ominous happenings) are heaven's way of making "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", and that the night resembles a man — Caesar. He uses omens when they are useful to his argument. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the real Cassius was a follower of Epicurus, a philosophy that dismissed omens; Shakespeare seems aware of this, because (GLANCE AHEAD to Act 5) Cassius will admit before Philippi that he has begun to give some credit to things that presage. The 'master of his fate' ends up superstitious.
3. *Brutus stands between them.* He belongs to neither camp: he is not a reader of signs like the Soothsayer and Casca, nor a proud denier of fate like Cassius. He simply acts on what he believes to be right and lets consequence follow. (GLANCE AHEAD) This is why his last words in Act 5, in which he speaks of the Ides of March as the beginning of a 'work' that the day of Philippi must end, are so moving: he adopts the Soothsayer's date as the name of his own free choice.

This is the tension that teachers and examiners usually label 'fate and free will', and *The Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)* chapter develops it across every scene. What you should take from this chapter is the pairing itself: the Soothsayer and Cassius are the two poles, and Caesar and Brutus are the men crushed between them.

Caesar's response: three sentences and a gesture

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

Read this aloud. Eleven words, three sentences, almost every word a single syllable. After the ceremonial fullness of "Set on and leave no ceremony out" and the alert curiosity of "Caesar is turned to hear", the rhythm snaps shut. Each sentence is shorter than the one before: a judgement, a decision, a command. The last word, "Pass", is an order to the whole procession — and to the future — to move along.

What does this reveal? Three things, which you can use in any question on Caesar's character.

First, the public Caesar. He speaks of himself in the third person — "Caesar is turned to hear" — a habit that will grow through the play until he talks about 'Caesar' as if the name belonged to a statue rather than a man. The Soothsayer scene is where you first hear it clearly. It is the voice of a man who has become his own public image.

Second, the judge by appearances. Caesar's instinct, faced with a warning, is to *look at the man* — "Set him before me. Let me see his face." He believes that he can read danger in a face; he will say so at length about Cassius later in the scene, when he calls for "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights." His reading of the Soothsayer's face produces the word 'dreamer'. It is the wrong reading, and the audience knows it; the play has quietly told us that Caesar's confidence in his own eye is misplaced, a full act before it kills him.

Third, the man who cannot afford to be seen fearing. Consider where he is: in the public square, on a feast day, with the crowd watching. A leader who stops a procession because a stranger shouted a date would look frightened. "Pass" protects the image. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers feel that Caesar's

dismissiveness is not stupidity but performance — that he must be seen to disdain fear because, as he says later of himself, "always I am Caesar". This reading makes his fate more tragic, not less: he dies of the role he has to play.

HISTORICAL RECORD, for a deeper point: the real Caesar held the office of *pontifex maximus*, the chief priest of Rome, who presided over the state religion — including the colleges of priests whose business was the reading of omens. Shakespeare does not mention this, but the historically informed reader sees an additional irony: the head of Rome's official religion brushing aside a reader of signs.

Now look at who else speaks in this exchange, because it is the detail that separates a good answer from an excellent one.

Brutus: *A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March.*

Why Brutus? Shakespeare had a stage full of people who could relay the words; he chose the man who will strike Caesar on that day. There is nothing sinister in Brutus's tone — he is simply being helpful, standing close enough to Caesar to answer for him, which tells us how intimate the two men are. But the audience hears the future assassin pronouncing the sentence of death in the form of a courtesy. And then Cassius, the instigator, physically brings the prophet forward: "Fellow, come from the throng. / Look upon Caesar." The warning is framed between the two men who will make it come true. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the text leaves their inner states unreadable here — this is before Cassius has said a word of temptation — and that is precisely why the framing works. Neither man yet knows he is the danger being announced.

Audience knowledge: why a play with no suspense is still gripping

A film director once distinguished between *surprise* and *suspense*. Surprise is a bomb going off under a table without warning: a few seconds of shock. Suspense is showing the audience the bomb under the table and then letting two characters chat about the weather for ten minutes: every trivial word becomes unbearable, because we know and they do not. *Julius Caesar* is a suspense play in this sense, and the Soothsayer is the moment Shakespeare shows us the bomb.

From this line onward the audience carries a date. Every scene in Acts 1 and 2 is measured against it. When Cicero asks Casca in the storm, "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?", the word *tomorrow* lands with a weight it would not otherwise have, because we can count. When Cassius tells Cinna it is "after midnight", we know which day has just begun. Shakespeare has turned his entire audience into soothsayers: we all know what Caesar does not, and we watch him with the helpless clarity of the man he called a dreamer.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the Soothsayer appears so early

Caesar has been on stage for barely a dozen lines — a summons to his wife, an order where she should stand, an instruction to Antony, a command to the procession — when the Soothsayer's voice interrupts. Shakespeare gives us the prophecy of the death before we have properly met the man who will die. Why not save it, build Caesar up, and then puncture him?

Three answers. First, *the play is not a mystery*. Shakespeare knows that his audience knows the ending; pretending otherwise would be false. By announcing the date at once he converts a plot into a countdown, and a countdown creates a far more intense kind of attention than a puzzle does. Second, *character before biography*. Shakespeare never shows us Caesar's conquests; he shows us Caesar dismissing a warning. The first substantial thing this Caesar does is refuse to listen, and that single act tells us more about why he will die than any account of Gaul could. Third, and most subtly, *the source of the warning*. The voice comes from "the press", from the anonymous crowd, not from a senator or a priest. Truth in this play speaks from below — a nameless man, later a poet in the street — and the great men do not hear it. Placing the Soothsayer in the first minutes of Caesar's entrance establishes the pattern that will destroy him: the people at the top of Rome are surrounded by information they are too grand to use.

The five levels: how to hold this moment in your head**LEVEL 1 — What happened?**

During the Lupercal procession, a soothsayer in the crowd calls out to Caesar and warns him, twice, to beware the ides of March. Brutus repeats the warning; Cassius brings the man forward; Caesar looks at him, calls him "a dreamer", and orders the procession to move on.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The Ides of March is 15 March, the historical day of Caesar's assassination. The warning names the day without explaining the danger. Caesar's dismissal shows his public confidence, his reliance on reading faces, and his refusal to appear afraid in front of the crowd.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Because the audience already knows the date, the scene creates dramatic irony rather than suspense about *what* will happen; the interest shifts to *how* and *why*. The brevity and repetition make the warning feel absolute. Giving the relaying line to Brutus and the fetching line to Cassius quietly frames the warning between the two men who will fulfil it. Placing it in Caesar's first minutes on stage makes dismissal of warnings the very first thing we learn about him.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

It opens the fate-versus-free-will argument that Cassius answers with "Men at some time are masters of their fates." It begins Caesar's pattern of ignoring warnings (Calpurnia's dream, the augurers — the priests who read omens — and Artemidorus's letter in Act 2). The Soothsayer returns in Act 2 Scene 4 and Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar's remark that the Ides have come is answered with the reminder that they have not yet gone. Brutus, in Act 5, names the Ides of March as the beginning of the 'work' his death must finish.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

In a Class IX extract question on this passage, the sub-questions are likely to ask where the scene is set and what is happening, what the Soothsayer's words mean, why Caesar reacts as he does, what his reaction reveals about him, and what happens immediately afterwards (Brutus and Cassius are left alone). For Class X use, see the exam box below. In either case, always connect: 'Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer in Act 1 is the first of several warnings he ignores.'

ICSE EXAM BOX Where this actually earns marks

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion of the syllabus, so the Soothsayer passage itself is a school-examination extract, not a board-paper one. But the 2025 ICSE board paper asked candidates to explain what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to — a Class X question that cannot be answered without this Act 1 scene. Expect the phrase 'the ides of March' to surface in Acts III and V extracts, and be ready to explain in one clean sentence: the Soothsayer's warning in Act 1 Scene 2, the date of the assassination in Act 3 Scene 1, and Brutus's use of the phrase before Philippi. No question is guaranteed; the knowledge is.

WEAK ANSWER A weak answer to 'Why does Caesar dismiss the Soothsayer?'

'Caesar dismisses the Soothsayer because he is arrogant and does not believe in fortune-tellers. He calls him a dreamer and goes away. This shows he is overconfident.'

EXCELLENT ANSWER An excellent answer to the same question

'Caesar dismisses the Soothsayer with three short, dismissive sentences — "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." — after insisting on looking at the man's face. His response reveals his habit of judging by appearances and his need, in a crowded public square on a feast day, not to be seen taking fright at a stranger's words; he speaks of himself in the third person as "Caesar", the public image rather than the man. Because the audience knows that the Ides of March is the day of his death, the dismissal is heavy with dramatic irony: the man he calls a dreamer is the only one awake to the truth. It is also the first instance of a pattern — he will later brush aside Calpurnia's dream and the augurers — so the moment characterises Caesar and foreshadows his fall at once.'

Notice what the strong answer does that the weak one does not: it quotes exactly, it names the device (dramatic irony) and explains *how* it works here, it reads a detail (the third person, the demand to see the face), and it connects forward. Four moves, one paragraph.

Relationship to later events: where the Ides of March goes next

Everything below is a **GLANCE AHEAD** beyond the verified Act 1 text. Later-act wording is given only as paraphrase in single quotes; do not quote these as if they were exact.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 2 Scene 1. Brutus, unable to sleep, has his servant check the calendar for the date; the conspirators gather in his orchard before dawn. The Ides are now hours away, and Brutus is the one counting.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 2 Scene 2. Calpurnia — the woman whose pale cheek Brutus noticed in Act 1 — has dreamt of Caesar's death and begs him not to go to the Capitol. The priests' sacrifice yields a bad omen. Caesar wavers, then lets Decius Brutus reinterpret the dream as a lucky one, and goes. This is the Soothsayer scene replayed at length: warning, hesitation, dismissal. What Act 1 did in fifteen lines, Act 2 does in a whole scene, so that the audience can watch the pattern harden into fate.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 2 Scene 3 and Scene 4. Artemidorus writes Caesar a letter naming the conspirators — a warning that, unlike the Soothsayer's, gives real information — and Caesar will not read it. Then the Soothsayer himself returns, met by Portia in the street; he tells her he fears what may happen to Caesar and goes to find a place from which to speak to him again. Shakespeare brings back the nameless man so that the Ides do not arrive without their prophet.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 3 Scene 1. On the way to the Senate, Caesar sees the Soothsayer and, in effect, taunts him: the Ides of March have come. The Soothsayer answers that they have come, but not yet gone. Within a few minutes Caesar is dead. The exchange is the direct payoff of Act 1 Scene 2, and examiners writing on Act 3 extracts assume you know its origin.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 5 Scene 1. Before Philippi, Brutus tells Cassius that this same day must end 'that work the ides of March begun'. The date has become the name of the entire enterprise — the assassination, the civil war, and his own approaching death. The Soothsayer's five words have travelled from a warning to Caesar into the epitaph (the words written over a grave) of the men who killed him.

THE FORESHADOWING MAP

Act 1 warning / omen	How it gains meaning later (GLANCE AHEAD)	What you should say about it
The Soothsayer: "Beware the ides of March." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Caesar is killed on that date in Act 3 Scene 1, having mocked the Soothsayer moments before; Brutus names the date as the beginning of his 'work' in Act 5.	Prophecy inside the story and foreshadowing in the design; dramatic irony because the audience knows the date; the play's first statement of fate.
Caesar: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Caesar dismisses Calpurnia's dream, the priests' omen and Artemidorus's letter in Act 2, and the Soothsayer again in Act 3.	Establishes a pattern of ignored warnings; shows the public Caesar who cannot be seen to fear; characterises and foreshadows at once.
Brutus: "Calpurnia's cheek is pale" (Act 1 Scene 2)	Calpurnia's terrified pleading and her dream in Act 2 Scene 2.	The silent, watchful wife is a barometer of danger; her paleness anticipates her fear.
Antony: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Antony's total loyalty drives the funeral oration in Act 3 Scene 2 and the pursuit of the conspirators.	Loyalty as Antony's defining trait; ironic because the man of pure obedience will become the most independent actor in Rome.

Act 1 warning / omen	How it gains meaning later (GLANCE AHEAD)	What you should say about it
Brutus: "I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Brutus underestimates Antony, spares him in Act 2 Scene 1, and lets him speak at the funeral in Act 3.	Brutus reads Antony as a mere sportsman; that misjudgement is fatal to the conspiracy.
Cassius: "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" (Act 1 Scene 2)	Brutus reads the forged letters in his orchard in Act 2 Scene 1 and is pushed over the edge.	Deception at the root of the 'honourable' conspiracy; Cinna carries the papers in 1.3.
Casca: "Marullus and Flavius... are put to silence." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Caesar's intolerance of dissent; the mob's silencing of Cinna the poet in Act 3 Scene 3.	Casual delivery of a chilling fact; the first casualty of Caesar's power; the republican tribunate under attack.
Casca on the crowd: "as they use to do the players in the theatre" (Act 1 Scene 2)	The crowd is swayed by Brutus, then reversed by Antony, in Act 3 Scene 2; it tears a poet apart in 3.3.	The crowd as an audience that applauds whoever performs best; the decisive force of the play has no fixed loyalty.
The storm and prodigies (Act 1 Scene 3)	Calpurnia lists the same kind of portents in Act 2 Scene 2; Caesar's ghost appears in Act 4.	The supernatural as warning; characters 'construe' the signs to suit themselves.
Cicero: "men may construe things after their fashion" (Act 1 Scene 3)	Decius construes the dream; Brutus construes Caesar's ambition; the crowd construes Antony's speech.	The interpretive key to the whole play: meaning is made by the reader of the sign.
Cassius: "Men at some time are masters of their fates." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Cassius dies at Philippi on his birthday, having misread a battlefield report; he admits he has begun to credit omens.	The free-will pole of the play's central tension; ironically fulfilled and undercut at once.
Casca: "he sits high in all the people's hearts... like richest alchemy" (Act 1 Scene 3)	Brutus's reputation legitimises the murder in Act 3 and briefly wins the crowd.	The conspiracy needs Brutus's name more than his sword; explains why Cassius works so hard on him.

CHARACTER MAP OF ACT 1

Where a cell records an inference rather than something stated in the text, it is marked (*inferred*).

Character	Wants	Fears	Relationship to Caesar	Relationship to Brutus
Caesar	Public honour; to be seen as fearless; an heir (<i>inferred from the Lupercal ritual</i>)	Nothing, he claims ("always I am Caesar"); privately, lean men like Cassius, who "thinks too much"	—	Trusts him; Brutus stands close enough to answer for him
Brutus	To act honourably for "the general good"; to be left alone with his thoughts	That the people "Choose Caesar for their king"; loss of honour more than death	Loves him: "I love him well"	—
Cassius	To pull Caesar down; to win Brutus	Living "In awe of such a thing as I myself"	Resents his rise; saved him from the Tiber; Caesar "doth bear me hard"	Old friend; flatters and manipulates him

Character	Wants	Fears	Relationship to Caesar	Relationship to Brutus
Antony	To serve Caesar; sport and pleasure	<i>(none shown)</i>	Executor and confidant: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed"	Contrasted with him by Brutus as "gamesome"
Casca	To seem unimpressed; later, safety and "redress"	The storm and the gods' "dreadful heralds"	Attendant in his train; contemptuous witness of his fit	Old schoolfellow; recognises his value to the plot
Cicero	To keep his head clear	Bad weather, not bad omens: the sky "Is not to walk in"	Critical: angered in the Senate; mocks in Greek	<i>(none in Act 1)</i>
Cinna	To win "the noble Brutus"	The "fearful night"	Conspirator against him	Places the letters aimed at him
Calpurnia	<i>(unspoken)</i> to obey; a child <i>(inferred)</i>	<i>(shown only as a pale cheek)</i>	Wife; publicly named "barren"	<i>(none)</i>
The Soothsayer	To be heard by Caesar	The ides of March	Warns him; is dismissed as "a dreamer"	Brutus relays his warning
Flavius and Marullus	To strip Caesar's images and disperse his supporters	Caesar soaring "above the view of men"	Opponents; "put to silence"	<i>(none)</i>
The Crowd (Cobbler, Carpenter, "the rabblement")	A holiday; a hero to cheer	The tribunes' anger, briefly	Cheers him, is shamed for it, cheers him again	Later, its love for Brutus is the plot's "richest alchemy"

ICSE EXAM BOX How Act 1's supporting cast earns marks in the Class X paper

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Since Acts III–V are the examined portion, Act 1 knowledge about these figures surfaces indirectly: Antony's oration (Act 3 Scene 2), Casca's first blow (Act 3 Scene 1), Cinna the poet (Act 3 Scene 3), any extract containing 'the ides of March', the omens recalled in later acts, and Cicero's death in the proscriptions (the triumvirs' death-lists) reported in Act 4 — each section above ends with the specific Act 1 evidence to bring. In the 16-mark drama extract question (sub-parts of 3, 3, 3, 3 and 4 marks), the 'what had happened earlier' and 'what does this reveal about character' sub-parts are precisely where a sentence of Act 1 evidence lifts a 2-mark answer to full marks. For Class IX, Act 1 extracts on any of these figures are the direct target. No question is guaranteed; every one of these connections is fair game.

REVISION Ten things to carry out of this chapter

1. The Ides of March = 15 March, a marker-day sacred to Jupiter; Caesar died on it in 44 BC.
2. The Soothsayer speaks the warning twice, in identical words; Brutus relays it; Cassius fetches the man.
3. "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." — three shrinking sentences; the public Caesar; judging by faces.
4. Dramatic irony: the audience knows the date; Caesar hears only a date.
5. Prophecy is what a character does; foreshadowing is what the author does. The Soothsayer is both.
6. Fate (the Soothsayer) versus free will (Cassius: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars") is the play's central tension, and the conspirators' free choice fulfils the fated date.
7. Antony: four speeches, six lines; the executor whom everyone underestimates.
8. Casca: prose cynic in 1.2, verse coward in 1.3, first recruit, first blow in Act 3.
9. Cicero: "men may construe things after their fashion" — the key to how every sign in the play is read; excluded later for thinking for himself.
10. The crowd: named and witty in 1.1, nameless and decisive in 1.2; an audience that claps and hisses "the players in the theatre".

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next in this book

The tribunes, the Cobbler and the Carpenter are read line by line in *Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd*. The Soothsayer exchange in its full context, and Cassius's mirror speech, are in *Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus*; Casca's report is in *Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)*; the storm, Cicero and Cinna in *Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm*. Fate, free will, superstition and mob psychology are developed as themes in *Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)*. The forward links in the Foreshadowing Map are traced act by act in *The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later*. Practice extracts on the Soothsayer passage and Casca's report are in the two *Extract-Based Training* chapters, and the marking logic behind the weak and strong answers above is set out in *ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned*.

QUOTATION QUICK-INDEX

Use this table on the second and later readings. 'Best use' names the kind of answer in which the line does most work: an Act 1 extract question (Class IX), a character or theme question, or an Act 3–5 answer (Class X) where the Act 1 line supplies motive, irony or earlier context. Themes are given in their shortest form; the full entries above carry the detail.

No.	First words	Speaker	Theme	Best use
1	"Hence! Home, you idle creatures"	Flavius	Public opinion; class	Opening of the play; the crowd as something to be commanded
2	"a mender of bad soles"	Cobbler	Appearance vs reality; wordplay	Pun and comic relief; the commoners' wit
3	"a surgeon to old shoes"	Cobbler	Public opinion; irony	Mock-heroic; the apolitical citizen
4	"You blocks, you stones"	Marullus	Fickle crowd; loyalty	The crowd's amnesia; link to Act 3 Forum

No.	First words	Speaker	Theme	Best use
5	"That Tiber trembled"	Marullus	Mob psychology; memory	The shout that serves two masters
6	"That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood"	Marullus	Ingratitude; betrayal	The Pompeian grievance; Pompey's statue in Act 3
7	"These growing feathers"	Flavius	Tyranny; liberty	First attempt to cut Caesar down; link to the conspiracy
8	"When Caesar says 'Do this,'"	Antony	Loyalty; power	Antony underrated; Act 3 revenge
9	"Beware the ides of March"	Soothsayer / Caesar	Fate; omens; pride	Prophecy and dismissal; irony of the assassination
10	"poor Brutus, with himself at war"	Brutus	Inner conflict	The tragic hero's division; Act 2 soliloquy
11	"I, your glass"	Cassius	Manipulation; reflection	Persuasion disguised as revelation; the letters
12	"The name of honour more than I fear death"	Brutus	Honour; idealism	Brutus's creed; every later error made in honour's name
13	"I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor"	Cassius	Jealousy; Caesar's body	The private root of the conspiracy
14	"Like a Colossus"	Cassius	Power; jealousy	Caesar's size as insult; imagery of unnatural growth
15	"The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars"	Cassius	Fate vs free will	The founding belief, and its irony
16	"'Brutus' will start a spirit"	Cassius	Names; honour; ancestry	The auction of vanity; old Brutus's statue
17	"Brutus had rather be a villager"	Brutus	Republicanism; liberty	Conditional consent; link to Act 2 decision
18	"a lean and hungry look"	Caesar	Appearance vs reality; danger	Caesar's shrewdness and his failure to act
19	"for always I am Caesar"	Caesar	Public vs private self	The deaf ear; Caesar's self-mythology
20	"he would fain have had it"	Casca	Ambition; point of view	The crown-offering; Antony's reversal in Act 3
21	"as they use to do the players in the theatre"	Casca	Mob psychology; theatre	Politics as performance; the Forum scene
22	"we have the falling sickness"	Cassius	Jealousy; Caesar's body	The grim pun; Brutus's compassion contrasted
23	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"	Cassius	Manipulation; forgery	Soliloquy of intent; the letters
24	"a tempest dropping fire"	Casca	Omens; disorder	Pathetic fallacy; change of register
25	"let not men say / 'These are their reasons'"	Casca	Superstition vs reason	The catalogue of prodigies
26	"men may construe things after their fashion"	Cicero	Misreading; scepticism	The play's theory of misinterpretation

No.	First words	Speaker	Theme	Best use
27	"Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone"	Cassius	Fate; manliness	The rationalist turned prophet
28	"yet prodigious grown"	Cassius	Tyranny; manipulation	Caesar as the storm; Casca names him
29	"Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius"	Cassius	Liberty vs bondage; suicide	Stoic creed; forecast of Act 5
30	"Hold. My hand."	Casca / Cassius	Faction; recruitment	Casca joins; contrast with Brutus's slow consent
31	"But win the noble Brutus to our party"	Cinna	Reputation	Why the conspiracy needs Brutus
32	"like richest alchemy"	Casca / Cassius	Appearance vs reality	A crime in search of a face; Act 3 exposure

REVISION The ten lines to know if you can know only ten

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. If time is short, make sure of numbers 4, 9, 11, 12, 14, 15, 18, 20, 26 and 32. Between them they cover the crowd, fate, manipulation, honour, Caesar's two selves, the crown, misreading and the conspiracy's dependence on Brutus — and each of them is a line that a later act answers. Learn them with their speaker, their listener and the sentence that precedes them, not as bare words.

HOW TO EMBED A QUOTATION

ICSE EXAM BOX How to embed a quotation so that it earns marks

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Examiners reward quotations that are *used*, not displayed. Three rules, each with a worked example from this bank.

Rule 1 — Quote short and embed. A quotation should sit inside your own sentence, grammatically, and be no longer than the point needs. Compare: 'Cassius says: "Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves."' That is four lines of Shakespeare and no marks, because nothing has been argued. Now: 'Cassius makes Caesar's greatness a personal insult, shrinking Brutus to one of the "petty men" who "peep about" beneath a "Colossus".' Three fragments, one sentence, and the analysis is already under way.

Rule 2 — Never let a quotation speak for itself. Every quotation must be followed by analysis: what the word choice does, what it reveals, where it leads. The pattern is claim → quotation → comment. Example: 'Caesar's self-image is a role rather than a man (claim); he insists "for always I am Caesar" even as he admits "this ear is deaf" (quotation); the gap between the public name and the failing body in consecutive lines is Shakespeare's compact portrait of a ruler who can no longer hear what he needs to (comment).' A quotation without the comment is a quotation left to do your work for you, and the examiner will not do it either.

Rule 3 — Show line breaks with a slash. When you quote more than one line of verse inside your prose, mark the end of each line with a forward slash with a space on either side, and keep the capital letter that begins the new line: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." If you set out three or more lines, you may instead write them as separate lines, indented, exactly as printed. Casca's prose needs no slashes — quote it as ordinary sentences: "to my thinking, he would fain have had it".

Three further habits. Name the speaker and the listener the first time ('Cassius tells Brutus that...'), because the same words from a different mouth would mean something else. Put a single word in quotation marks when the word itself is the point — Brutus loves "The name of honour", and the word 'name' is where the analysis lies. And keep your own words in single quotation marks and Shakespeare's in double, so the examiner can see at a glance where the text ends and your thinking begins.

An honest note on marks. In the current ICSE paper the drama extract carries 16 marks in sub-parts, and the higher sub-parts reward the explained link — context to meaning, meaning to theme, theme to the wider play. Act 1 itself is examined in Class IX; in the Class X paper on Acts III–V an embedded Act 1 line is the surest way to show that you understand why a later moment matters. Nothing here guarantees a question; everything here raises the quality of whatever answer you write.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

Every **Scene connection**: in this bank is followed through Acts 2–5 in 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'. To practise embedding under examination conditions, work through 'Extract-Based Training (Part One)' and '(Part Two)', where these same lines appear inside full extract questions with weak and excellent model answers. The devices named here are defined in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank', and the terms under **ICSE keywords**: are unpacked in 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'.

WEAK WORD → STRONG WORD: The Conversion Table

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Read the left column and recognise yourself; then practise the right column until it is reflex. The third column tells you where in Act 1 the stronger word honestly fits.

Weak word students write	Stronger alternatives	Where it fits in Act 1	Sample phrase
jealous	resentful, envious, aggrieved	Cassius's Tiber and fever anecdotes	'Cassius's resentment at having to "bend his body" to a man he once rescued'
proud	self-mythologising, assured of his authority, overconfident	Caesar on the Soothsayer and on Cassius	'Caesar's self-mythologising "for always I am Caesar"'
tricks	manipulates, insinuates, works upon, flatters	Cassius with Brutus	'Cassius insinuates Brutus's hidden worth through the mirror conceit'
bad weather	portentous storm, prodigies, omens	Scene 3	'the portentous storm that Casca reads as a warning'
the people	the plebeians, the populace, the fickle crowd, the commons	Scene 1; Casca's report	'the fickle plebeians who once cheered Pompey'
says	asserts, concedes, insinuates, confesses, protests	Any speech	'Brutus concedes "yet I love him well"'
shows	reveals, exposes, betrays, dramatises	Any analysis	'the deaf ear betrays the man behind the myth'
good man	man of honour, principled, idealistic, high-minded	Brutus	'Brutus's idealistic devotion to "the general good"'
bad	tyrannical, illegitimate, base, cynical	Caesar (as the conspirators see him); Cassius	'Cassius's cynical plan to forge letters'
scared	apprehensive, fearful, filled with foreboding	Brutus at the shouts; Casca in the storm	'Brutus's apprehension that the people "Choose Caesar for their king"'
angry	indignant, aggrieved, incensed	Marullus; Cassius on Rome	'Marullus's indignation at the crowd's ingratitude'
wants to be king	aspires to monarchy, ambitious for the crown, courts sovereignty	Caesar, as inferred by others	'Caesar's inferred ambition for the crown he refuses'
plan to kill	conspiracy, assassination plot, tyrannicide (as they would call it)	Scene 3	'the conspiracy taking shape at "Pompey's Porch"'
friends (of the plot)	confederates, conspirators, allies, a faction	Casca's "factious"	'Casca pledges himself to the faction'
thinks a lot	reflective, introspective, brooding, self-divided	Brutus; Cassius ("He thinks too much")	'the brooding Cassius whom Caesar distrusts'
nice things	flattery, blandishments, appeals to vanity	Cassius with Brutus	'Cassius's flattery of Brutus's "hidden worthiness"'
makes him feel	plays upon, appeals to, exploits	Cassius with Brutus and Casca	'Cassius exploits Casca's fear of the heavens'
weird things	prodigies, unnatural signs, portents	Scene 3	'the prodigies Casca lists to Cicero'

Weak word students write	Stronger alternatives	Where it fits in Act 1	Sample phrase
the crowd changed sides	the crowd's fickleness, inconstancy, mutability	Scene 1	'the inconstancy of a populace that forgets Pompey'
it means that	it implies, suggests, signals, anticipates	Any analysis	'the hyphen in "honourable-dangerous" signals a fusion of motives'

ICSE EXAM BOX Do not force a keyword where it does not fit

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. The vault is a set of precise tools, and a precise tool used in the wrong place does more harm than a blunt one. Three rules. First, a Type A word belongs only to the moment it comes from: do not describe the crowd in Scene 1 as a "rabblement", because that is Casca's word for a different crowd on a different occasion, and the examiner who knows the text will mark the confusion. Second, a Type B word must be earned by evidence in the same sentence: 'Cassius manipulates Brutus' is an assertion; 'Cassius manipulates Brutus by offering to be his "glass"' is an analysis. Third, the cautions in this chapter are not optional. Calling the storm 'pathetic fallacy', calling Caesar's death 'hubris' or labelling Brutus 'a Stoic' as if the play said so will be read as reaching for impressive words without understanding them, and in a Class X answer on Acts III to V that habit costs more marks than plain English would. If the only word you are sure of is the plain one, use the plain one and add the evidence. Vocabulary is scored as a sign of thought, never as a substitute for it.

REVISION How to drill the vault

Work through one group a day, covering the right-hand side of each entry and reconstructing it from the keyword alone: the meaning, one piece of verified evidence, the character or theme, and a sentence of your own in the style of the sample. Then reverse the drill: read the sample sentence and name the keyword it is built around. Finally, take any paragraph you wrote in Class IX about Act 1, underline every word in the left-hand column of the conversion table, and rewrite the paragraph with the right-hand column. The rewritten paragraph will be shorter, sharper and worth more. For the quotations themselves in longer form, pair this chapter with 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'; for the devices the Type B terms often accompany (rhetorical question, metaphor, soliloquy), pair it with 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; for how an examiner actually awards the marks these words earn, read 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'.

The Honest Starting Point: Where Act 1 Sits in Your Examinations

Before any technique, one fact must be perfectly clear, because a student who misunderstands it will prepare for the wrong examination.

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE: Act 1 of *Julius Caesar* is prescribed for Class IX. Your school examines it, usually through reference-to-the-context or extract questions. The ICSE Class X board paper examines Acts III, IV and V. Act 1 is therefore never set as an extract in the board paper. Yet the board paper leans on Act 1 constantly: the 2025 paper asked candidates what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to, a question that cannot be answered by a student who does not remember the Soothsayer's warning in Act 1 Scene 2. Every character motive, every piece of foreshadowing and every relationship that Acts III–V exploit was planted in Act 1. So this chapter trains you for two examinations at once: the Class IX paper that sets Act 1 directly, and the Class X paper that assumes it.

ICSE EXAM BOX The 2025 paper structure in one glance

The Literature in English paper (Paper 2) carries 80 marks and lasts 2 hours, plus reading time; 20 further marks come from internal assessment. In the 2025 board paper the structure was: Section A, compulsory, Question 1 with 16 one-mark MCQs across drama, prose and poetry; Sections B (Drama), C (Prose) and D (Poetry), each with extract-based questions of 16 marks. Candidates had to attempt one question from each of B, C and D, and one more from any section. Each 2025 drama extract question had five sub-parts marked [3], [3], [3], [3], [4]. The four 3-mark parts typically moved from context and recall through explanation to character; the 4-mark part asked for judgement or personal response supported from the text. Nothing in this chapter predicts what will be set. It describes what has been set and how marks were earned on it.

Keep the shape [3][3][3][3][4] in your head as you read. Almost every piece of advice below is calibrated to it.

WHAT MAKES AN ANSWER WEAK / AVERAGE / STRONG / EXCELLENT

Examiners do not mark by instinct alone. Whether or not they use a printed grid, they are judging an answer on a small number of qualities, and each quality can be present at four strengths. The table below names eight of those qualities and describes what each looks like at each strength. Use it diagnostically: after writing a practice answer, find the row for each quality and ask honestly which column you are in.

Quality	Weak	Average	Strong	Excellent
Textual precision	Vague or wrong: 'Antony gives Caesar a crown'; speakers confused; events misordered	Correct in outline, but approximate ('Cassius says something about a Colossus')	Exact: right speaker, right moment, short accurate quotation	Exact and selective: the quotation chosen is the one word or phrase that proves the point ("coronets", "put it by thrice")
Context	None, or the whole plot retold from Scene 1	Where and when stated, but loosely ('in Rome, during a festival')	Precise placement: 'just after Caesar's train has left the stage, Casca pulled by the cloak'	Placement plus relevance: the context is used ('because this is reported, not shown, we see it through Casca's cynicism')
Analysis	Absent: the answer describes what happens	A single general observation ('this shows Cassius is clever')	Each point moves from evidence to inference ('the rescue inverts the hierarchy, so...')	Inference with awareness of alternatives ('one reading is..., though Cassius's own bitterness colours the account')
Evidence	No quotation, or a long block copied from the extract	One quotation, often too long and not explained	Short quotations woven into sentences, each followed by a comment	Quotations chosen for a key word and the key word itself discussed ('fain' tells us Casca is guessing Caesar's desire)
Terminology	None, or wrong ('simile' for a metaphor)	Terms named but not used ('there is irony here')	Term, quotation and effect linked ('dramatic irony: we know what Caesar does not')	Terms used only where they sharpen the point; never decoration

Quality	Weak	Average	Strong	Excellent
Cause and effect	Events listed in sequence with 'then... then...'	One cause noted ('Brutus is worried so he is distant')	Chains traced: 'because X, Y; and Y makes Z possible'	Chains traced and weighed: the main cause distinguished from contributing ones
Character motivation	Labels: 'Cassius is jealous', 'Brutus is good'	Label plus one reason	Motive derived from the character's own words and actions	Motive shown as mixed or contested, with the text left open where it is open ('envy and principle are both present in the soliloquy')
Significance	Not addressed, or 'this is very important'	'This foreshadows what happens later' without saying what	Specific link to a later moment or a theme ('the deaf ear anticipates his refusal of the Soothsayer and Calpurnia')	Significance that explains why Shakespeare placed it here, in this form, through this speaker

Two patterns in this table deserve attention. First, the move from Weak to Average is usually about accuracy; the move from Average to Strong is about linking evidence to inference; the move from Strong to Excellent is about selectivity and judgement. Most students who have 'done the notes' sit in the Average column on every row. Second, the Excellent column never requires more writing than the Strong column. It requires better choices. The excellent answer is often shorter than the strong one.

THE ANATOMY OF A 3-MARK SUB-ANSWER

A 3-mark sub-answer is the basic unit of the ICSE literature paper; four of them make up three-quarters of an extract question. Build it to a fixed design and you will never again stare at a question wondering how much to write.

Structure

Think of three marks as three distinct, markable points, each of which must be visible to a tired examiner at reading speed. The cleanest design is:

1. **Direct answer in the first sentence.** The question's verb answered immediately: the reason, the meaning, the speaker and moment.
2. **Development with evidence.** The second and third sentences each add a point, and each point is pinned to a short quotation or an exact textual detail.
3. **A closing clause of significance or effect,** only where the question invites it ('What does this reveal...?' invites it; 'Who is being addressed?' does not).

Length

Five to seven sentences, roughly 70 to 110 words. If you are writing a second paragraph on a 3-mark question, you are either repeating yourself or answering a question that was not asked. If you have written two sentences, you have probably made one point and are hoping it counts for three.

How many points

Three. Not one point explained three ways, which examiners spot instantly, and not five points, which crowds out the explanation each one needs. If the question has two clear parts ('What does Brutus fear, and how does Cassius respond?'), split the marks accordingly: usually two points for the larger part and one for the smaller.

When to quote

Quote when the exact word matters, and always quote short: a phrase, half a line, at most a line and a half. For a recall question, quotation is confirmation ('Casca calls it "one of these coronets"'). For an understanding question, quote the phrase you are unpacking and then put it into your own words; do not paraphrase around the quotation and leave it unexplained. For a 'why' or 'what does this reveal' question, quote the words that carry the evidence for your inference. If you cannot remember the exact words, do not invent them: a precise paraphrase ('Caesar admits that his ear is deaf') earns the point; an invented quotation can lose it, because the examiner knows the text.

A worked 3-mark answer, annotated

Question: 'Why does Brutus say he is "not gamesome"? What does his reply reveal about his state of mind?'

Answer: Brutus declines Cassius's invitation to watch the race because he lacks the appetite for sport, admitting "I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony" [point 1: the direct reason, with the exact words]. The reply reveals a man turned inward: he has, by his own confession, been "with himself at war", troubled by "passions of some difference", so that he has neglected his friends [point 2: state of mind derived from his own words]. The contrast with Antony, the man of "quick spirit" who runs in the games, quietly sets up the opposition between the reflective Brutus and the physical, pleasure-loving Antony that the whole play will exploit [point 3: significance, kept to one sentence].

Three points, three pieces of evidence, six sentences. That is the shape.

THE ANATOMY OF A 4-MARK EVALUATIVE SUB-ANSWER

The final sub-part of a drama extract in the 2025 paper carried 4 marks and asked for judgement: which argument had the greatest impact, whether a character is justified, how far a statement is true, what the extract reveals about a relationship. It is marked differently from a 3-mark part, and students who write it as a longer recall answer lose marks they could easily have had.

What the extra mark is for

The fourth mark is for judgement. Three marks can be earned by making well-supported points; the fourth is earned by committing to a position and defending it against the obvious objection. An answer that says 'both Cassius and Brutus have good reasons' and stops has refused to evaluate. An answer that says 'Cassius's strongest argument is the appeal to Brutus's ancestor, because it attacks Brutus's honour rather than Caesar's weakness; the Tiber story is vivid but it reveals Cassius's envy more than Caesar's unfitness' has evaluated.

Structure

1. **Position, stated in the first sentence.** 'The argument with the greatest impact is...'; 'Caesar is not justified in dismissing the Soothsayer because...'; 'I agree only partly, because...'
2. **Two supporting points, each with evidence.** These are the same evidence-plus-inference moves as in a 3-mark answer.
3. **The counter-consideration.** One sentence acknowledging the strongest fact against your view, and one sentence showing why your view survives it.
4. **A closing sentence that sharpens the position,** not merely repeats it.

Length

Eight to ten sentences, roughly 120 to 160 words. A 4-mark answer is not twice a 3-mark answer in length; it is one-third longer and differently shaped.

How many points

Two main points and one counter-consideration. Three or four thin points are weaker than two developed ones, because evaluation is about depth of reasoning, not breadth of coverage.

When to quote

Quote to support each main point and, ideally, once for the counter-consideration, since an objection you can support from the text is far more convincing than one you merely mention. Keep every quotation short. The 4-mark answer is the one place where the examiner wants to hear your voice; do not drown it in the text's.

The two words that save the fourth mark

'Because' and 'although'. 'Because' forces you to give a reason for your judgement. 'Although' forces you to acknowledge the other side. A 4-mark answer that contains both words, each doing real work, has almost always evaluated. An answer that contains neither has almost always described.

HOW TO STOP WRITING STORY SUMMARIES

The single most common cause of lost marks in literature answers is retelling. It is not laziness. Students retell because retelling feels safe, because it fills the space, and because for years 'tell me what happened' was the question they were asked. The examiner at this level is asking a different question, and the cure is to learn to hear the difference.

Diagnosing the habit

You are summarising when your sentences begin with a character's name followed by a past- or present-tense action verb ('Cassius then tells Brutus...', 'Caesar comes back and says...') and are joined by 'then', 'after that', 'next'. You are answering when your sentences begin with a reason, a quality, a judgement or a textual word ('Cassius's purpose is...', 'The word "fain" shows...', 'This is ironic because...').

A quick test: delete the question from the top of your answer. If a reader could not reconstruct what was asked from your first two sentences, you have summarised.

The rewrite exercise

Below is a weak answer to a Scene 1 question, followed by the same material rewritten. Read both slowly, then do the exercise that follows.

Question (3 marks): 'Why are Flavius and Marullus angry with the commoners in Act 1 Scene 1?'

Before (summary):

'In the beginning of the play, some commoners are walking on the street. Flavius and Marullus are two tribunes. They see the commoners and ask them what their trade is. The carpenter says he is a carpenter. Then the cobbler makes jokes and says he is a mender of bad soles. Flavius and Marullus get angry and ask them why they are not working. The cobbler says they have come to see Caesar. Then Marullus gives a long speech about Pompey and tells them to go home. Flavius tells Marullus to pull down the decorations from Caesar's statues. This shows the tribunes are angry with the commoners.'

This is 113 words, accurate, and worth perhaps one mark. Every sentence narrates. The word 'why' is never answered until the last sentence, and that sentence does not answer it either; it merely restates the question as a conclusion.

After (answer):

'The tribunes are angry for two connected reasons. The first is political: the commoners are celebrating Caesar's triumph over Pompey's sons, a victory over fellow Romans, and Marullus is disgusted that the very people who once climbed "to chimney tops" to see "great Pompey pass the streets of Rome" now "strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". Their rejoicing is, to him, ingratitude and a betrayal of Pompey's memory. The second reason is fear: Flavius sees Caesar's popularity as "growing feathers" that must be plucked before he can "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". The commoners' holiday is dangerous because it feeds the power of a man the tribunes believe threatens the Republic. Their anger at the idle workmen is really anger at Rome's forgetfulness and alarm at Caesar's rise.'

This is 143 words and worth three marks. Compare the openings: 'In the beginning of the play, some commoners are walking' against 'The tribunes are angry for two connected reasons'. Compare the use of the text: the first version mentions Pompey; the second quotes the exact contrast Marullus builds between past devotion and present fickleness. Compare the endings: the first restates the question; the second names what the anger is really about.

Your turn

Take this question and write a summary answer deliberately, then rewrite it: 'Why does Cassius want to recruit Casca in Act 1 Scene 3?' Your rewrite must open with a reason, must quote Casca's own pledge ("Be factious for redress of all these griefs") or Cassius's description of the men waiting at "Pompey's Porch", and must not contain the word 'then'. When you have finished, check your first two sentences against the insight box above. If an examiner could not tell from them that the question was 'why', start again.

The three sentence-openers that cure retelling

Train yourself to begin sub-answers with one of these shapes until it becomes reflex:

- **The reason-first opener:** 'X does this because...' / 'The purpose of this speech is...'
- **The quality-first opener:** 'The speech reveals a man who...' / 'What stands out is...'
- **The word-first opener:** 'The key word is "fain", which...' / 'Casca's phrase "mere foolery" tells us...'

Each of these makes narration grammatically awkward. You cannot comfortably follow 'The purpose of this speech is' with a plot summary. The sentence shape does the discipline for you.

WEAK VS EXCELLENT ANSWERS

Seven questions follow, each of a kind that Act 1 extract papers regularly ask and that Act 3–5 questions silently depend on. Each is answered twice. The weak answer is not a bad student's answer; it is the answer a reasonably prepared student writes under time pressure when technique fails. The excellent answer is what the same knowledge looks like when it is organised to earn marks. The dissection after each pair uses six fixed labels so that you can see exactly which move earns which mark. Treat all seven as 3-mark answers unless marked otherwise.

Question 1: Why do the tribunes drive the commoners home?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Flavius and Marullus are tribunes who do not like Caesar. At the start of the play they find the commoners in the street on a working day and scold them. The cobbler makes jokes and says he is a surgeon to old shoes. The tribunes are angry because the people have come to see Caesar's triumph. Marullus reminds them about Pompey and says they are ungrateful. Then they send them home and go to remove decorations from the statues because they are jealous of Caesar's power.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The tribunes drive the commoners home because the crowd's celebration is both a betrayal and a danger. It is a betrayal because the triumph honours a victory "over Pompey's blood", and Marullus is appalled that people who once waited "The livelong day, with patient expectation, / To see great Pompey pass" now "cull out a holiday" for the man who destroyed Pompey's cause; his insult "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" treats their fickleness as a failure of memory and feeling. It is a danger because, as Flavius makes explicit after they leave, popular adoration is the material of tyranny: Caesar's "growing feathers" must be "plucked" or he will "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". Sending the crowd home and stripping the images are therefore the same act, an attempt to deny Caesar the public worship that the tribunes, as guardians of the people's liberty, believe will end the Republic.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer has one accurate detail ("surgeon to old shoes") that is irrelevant to the question, and no quotation that bears on motive. The excellent answer selects three: the Pompey contrast, the insult, and the feathers metaphor, each of which is a reason rather than an event.

Keyword: 'Ingratitude' and 'liberty' are the two concepts the examiner expects. The weak answer gestures at the first ('ungrateful') and replaces the second with 'jealous', which is a misreading of the tribunes' office. The excellent answer names betrayal and danger and explains both.

Analysis: The weak answer narrates in sequence; its only analytical sentence attributes jealousy, for which the text offers no support. The excellent answer reads the feathers image as a political theory of how tyranny grows, which is what the image is.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why removing decorations and dispersing a crowd are the same action, a connection the weak answer never makes because it treats them as consecutive events.

Significance: The excellent answer's closing phrase, 'guardians of the people's liberty', tells the examiner the student knows what a tribune is for. That is the difference between a student who knows the plot and one who understands the scene.

Connection: Casca's later report that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" completes this scene's argument: the men who tried to pluck Caesar's feathers are themselves plucked. The excellent answer leaves room for that connection in a 4-mark version; the weak answer has no framework into which it could fit.

Question 2: How does Cassius persuade Brutus?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Cassius is jealous of Caesar and wants Brutus to join the conspiracy. He tells Brutus that he has noticed he has been distant. Then he says he will be a mirror to Brutus. He tells the story of how Caesar nearly drowned in the Tiber and how he had a fever in Spain and shook like a girl. He says Caesar is like a Colossus and that Brutus's name is as good as Caesar's. He also mentions Brutus's ancestor who drove out the kings. Brutus says he will think about it. So Cassius uses many arguments to persuade Brutus.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

Cassius persuades Brutus by working on his self-image rather than on his politics. He begins by offering himself as a mirror, "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of", so that whatever follows will seem to Brutus like self-discovery rather than persuasion. Having heard Brutus declare that he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death", Cassius announces "honour is the subject of my story" and tailors every argument to it. The Tiber and the fever anecdotes degrade Caesar into a man who cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!" and groaned "As a sick girl", so that bending to him becomes dishonourable. The Colossus image then makes Brutus's passivity shameful: "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves". Finally he turns to ancestry, reminding Brutus of "a Brutus once" who would have endured "Th' eternal devil" in Rome "As easily as a king". The sequence moves from flattery to disgust to shame to inherited duty, and each step is an appeal to honour, which is why Brutus, who is unmoved by envy, is moved.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: Both answers mention the same four episodes. The weak answer mentions them; the excellent answer quotes the operative phrase from each and tells the examiner what the phrase does.

Keyword: 'Honour' is the keyword, and the excellent answer shows it is Cassius's keyword too ("honour is the subject of my story"). The weak answer's keyword is 'jealous', which describes Cassius's motive and leaves the question (how does he persuade?) unanswered.

Analysis: The weak answer's final sentence ('uses many arguments') is a list disguised as a conclusion. The excellent answer identifies a method (flattery, then disgust, then shame, then duty) and a reason the method works (every step targets honour).

Explanation: The excellent answer explains the mirror image as a technique for disguising persuasion as self-knowledge. The weak answer reports that Cassius 'will be a mirror' without saying why that matters.

Significance: The excellent answer's last clause, that Brutus is unmoved by envy but moved by honour, prepares the student for the soliloquy, where Cassius admits that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought". Persuasion and manipulation are shown as the same process seen from two sides.

Connection: In Act 3 Brutus will justify the killing to the people on exactly these terms, as a matter of honour and the general good. A student who has written the excellent answer already understands why Brutus's funeral speech sounds the way it does.

Question 3: What does Caesar's speech about Cassius reveal?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Caesar tells Antony that he wants fat men around him who sleep at night. He says Cassius has a lean and hungry look and thinks too much. Antony says Cassius is not dangerous. Caesar says he is not afraid of Cassius but if he were afraid of anyone it would be Cassius, because he reads a lot and does not like plays or music and rarely smiles. Then he tells Antony to come to his right side because his left ear is deaf. This shows Caesar is a good judge of character but also proud.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The speech reveals a Caesar who sees others clearly and himself not at all. His portrait of Cassius is exact: a man who "reads much", who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", who "loves no plays" and "hears no music", and who "Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself". Caesar understands the psychology of envy perfectly when he says such men "be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". But every insight is cancelled by his need to be seen as fearless: "I fear him not"; "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar". The third-person self-naming shows that Caesar has begun to believe in 'Caesar' as a public institution immune to private danger. Shakespeare then undercuts the whole speech with one physical detail, "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf", so that the great reader of men ends by admitting he cannot hear on one side. The deafness is not in the historical record; it is Shakespeare's emblem for a ruler whose perceptiveness is defeated by his vanity.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer paraphrases the whole speech evenly, giving equal weight to every detail. The excellent answer quotes selectively and places the heaviest weight on the two lines that matter most for the question, "for always I am Caesar" and the deaf ear.

Keyword: 'Irony' and 'self-image' (or 'hubris', used carefully) are the terms the examiner expects. The weak answer offers 'proud', which is correct but unexplained.

Analysis: The weak answer's last sentence contains the right two ideas (good judge, proud) but does not relate them. The excellent answer's opening sentence relates them at once: sees others, not himself. That one relation is the analysis.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why the third-person 'Caesar' is significant (a man becoming an institution), and what the deaf ear does dramatically (undercuts the speech). The weak answer records the deaf ear as a stage instruction.

Significance: The excellent answer notes that the deafness is Shakespeare's invention, labelled as such, which signals to an examiner that the student can separate the play from history. That is a mark of genuine understanding, not decoration.

Connection: The same pattern, acute perception defeated by self-regard, governs Caesar's refusal of Calpurnia's warnings in Act 2 and his speech to the Senate in Act 3. The excellent answer has defined the pattern; the weak answer has only listed the symptoms.

Question 4: What is the significance of the Soothsayer?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

The Soothsayer is a fortune teller who appears in Act 1 Scene 2. When Caesar is going to the games, the Soothsayer calls out to him and warns him to beware the ides of March. Caesar asks who it is and Brutus repeats the warning. Caesar calls the Soothsayer before him and the Soothsayer repeats the warning. Caesar says he is a dreamer and ignores him. This is significant because Caesar is killed on the ides of March, so the Soothsayer was right. It shows the theme of fate.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The Soothsayer is significant for what he says, how he is answered, and where he is placed. His warning, "Beware the ides of March", is the play's first naming of the date on which Caesar will die, so from this moment the audience watches every scene against a deadline that the characters do not know they are living under; this is the source of the play's dramatic irony. His voice is unmistakable even in a crowd, "a tongue shriller than all the music", which suggests a truth that cuts through ceremony. Caesar's response is the second significance: he gives the man a full hearing, "Set him before me. Let me see his face", and then dismisses him, "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." The dismissal shows that Caesar's failure is not deafness to warnings but refusal of them, a choice rather than an accident. Finally, the placement matters: the warning interrupts the Lupercal procession, so that Caesar's hope for an heir, voiced a moment earlier in his instruction to Antony to touch Calpurnia, is immediately shadowed by a prophecy of his death. The text leaves open whether the Soothsayer speaks for fate or merely for shrewd observation of Rome's mood; Shakespeare gives him no explanation, and that silence is part of his power.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer quotes nothing; the excellent answer quotes the warning, the "shriller" line and both halves of Caesar's response, each quotation attached to a point.

Keyword: 'Dramatic irony' and 'foreshadowing' are expected, and the excellent answer uses the first exactly: the audience knows what the characters do not. The weak answer offers 'the theme of fate' without showing how the Soothsayer creates it.

Analysis: The weak answer's analysis is 'the Soothsayer was right'. The excellent answer analyses the dismissal as a choice, which converts Caesar from victim of fate to agent of his own fall, the central question of the play.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why the placement next to the fertility ritual matters (hope for heirs against prophecy of death). This is Level 3 thinking, 'why did Shakespeare put it here?', and it is what separates Strong from Excellent.

Significance: The excellent answer closes by refusing to settle what the text leaves unsettled (fate or observation), and says so. Examiners reward this precision; it is the opposite of vagueness.

Connection: The 2025 board paper's question about 'the work the ides of March begun' is answerable only by a student who can place this warning and its fulfilment. The excellent answer has already done the placing.

Question 5: How does Casca describe the crown offering, and what does it reveal about Caesar and the crowd?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Casca tells Brutus and Cassius what happened at the games. Antony offered Caesar a crown three times and Caesar refused it three times. The people shouted every time he refused. Then Caesar fainted because of the bad smell of the crowd and fell down foaming at the mouth. When he woke up he said sorry to the people. Casca also says Cicero spoke Greek and that Marullus and Flavius have been punished. This shows that Caesar wanted the crown and the people are foolish.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

Casca describes the offering in deliberately contemptuous prose, calling it "mere foolery" and insisting the crown was really "one of these coronets". The description is slanted at every point, and that slant is the evidence. Of Caesar he says that although he "put it by thrice", he did so "every time gentler than other", that "to my thinking, he would fain have had it" and was "very loath to lay his fingers off it". The repeated 'to my thinking' tells us this is Casca's interpretation of Caesar's desire, not a fact, but the interpretation reveals a Caesar performing reluctance before a crowd whose approval he needs, and whose disapproval literally fells him, since he "swooned and fell down" when the "rabblement hooted". Of the crowd, Casca is merciless: they "clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps", and they praised and hissed Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". That simile is the key: Rome's politics has become a performance, Caesar an actor who even "offered them his throat to cut" for effect, and the people an audience whose love is as cheap as their applause. The report thus reveals a Caesar whose power depends on the mob and a mob that can be played.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer is factually sound but quotes nothing and treats the report as neutral. The excellent answer quotes the words that carry Casca's bias ("fain", "loath", "to my thinking") and the words that carry his contempt ("rabblement", "sweaty nightcaps").

Keyword: 'Reported, not staged' and 'fickle' are the two keywords. The excellent answer builds its whole argument on the first (the slant is the evidence) and earns the second through the theatre simile rather than asserting it.

Analysis: The weak answer's conclusion ('Caesar wanted the crown') states as fact what Casca offers as guess. The excellent answer separates Casca's inference from the event, which is exactly the discipline the examiner is testing.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains the theatre simile, the most quotable line in the report, as a diagnosis of Roman politics. The weak answer omits it.

Significance: Caesar's dependence on the crowd, and the crowd's dependence on performance, are the two facts that make Antony's funeral oration in Act 3 possible. The excellent answer has stated both.

Connection: The weak answer wastes a sentence on Cicero's Greek and the tribunes, which are not part of the question. Relevance is itself a marked quality: an examiner reads an irrelevant sentence as a sign the student is unsure what was asked.

Question 6: Why is the storm in Scene 3 significant?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

In Act 1 Scene 3 there is a big storm with thunder and lightning. Casca is very frightened and tells Cicero about the strange things he has seen, like a slave whose hand was on fire, a lion near the Capitol, women who saw men on fire and an owl in the daytime. Cicero is calm and goes home. Then Cassius comes and says he is not afraid of the storm. He uses the storm to convince Casca to join the conspiracy. The storm is significant because it shows something bad is going to happen.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The storm is significant because Shakespeare uses it as a test of how each man reads the world, and the readings predict the men. Casca reads it as divine anger: "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction", and his catalogue of prodigies, the slave's burning hand "Not sensible of fire", the lion that "went surly by", the owl "Even at noonday", is the frightened piety of a man who believes the gods still speak. Cicero reads it sceptically: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves", a warning that omens mean whatever the interpreter wants, which is precisely what Cassius then proves. Cassius calls the storm "A very pleasing night to honest men" and construes it as "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", then makes the tempest an image of Caesar himself, "a man / Most like this dreadful night". The storm is thus significant on three levels: as atmosphere it makes the conspiracy feel like a convulsion of nature; as foreshadowing it anticipates the violence Cassius names when he calls the night's "complexion" "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible"; and as a study of interpretation it dramatises the theme that signs are made, not found. Whether the heavens truly warn Rome is left open; Cicero's sentence is the play's own caution.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer lists the prodigies accurately but cannot use them. The excellent answer quotes one phrase from each reader of the storm, so the structure of the answer is the structure of the scene.

Keyword: 'Pathetic fallacy' (nature mirroring human disorder) and 'omen' are expected; 'interpretation' is the keyword the best students add. The excellent answer earns all three without listing them as labels.

Analysis: The weak answer's analysis is 'something bad is going to happen', which is foreshadowing at its vaguest. The excellent answer analyses the storm as a device for contrasting three minds.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains Cicero's line and then shows Cassius illustrating it, which converts a quotation into an argument. The weak answer notes only that Cicero 'is calm'.

Significance: The three-level structure (atmosphere, foreshadowing, interpretation) is a reusable template for any question about setting or weather in Shakespeare. The weak answer offers nothing reusable.

Connection: Calpurnia's dream and the augurers' findings in Act 2 continue this argument about reading signs, as does the Soothsayer's reappearance on the morning of the Ides. The excellent answer has given the student the thread; the weak answer has given a list of frightening things.

Question 7: What does Cassius's soliloquy reveal?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

After Brutus leaves, Cassius speaks alone. He says Brutus is noble but can be influenced. He says Caesar does not like him but likes Brutus. He plans to write letters in different handwriting and throw them through Brutus's window pretending they are from citizens, saying how much Rome respects Brutus and hinting at Caesar's ambition. This shows that Cassius is cunning and jealous and will do anything to bring down Caesar.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The soliloquy reveals the gap between what Cassius has said to Brutus and what he thinks. He grants Brutus's virtue, "Well, Brutus, thou art noble", but immediately turns it into material: "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed", where 'wrought' is a metalworker's word, so that Brutus's honour becomes something to be heated and bent. His general maxim, "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?", shows a man who believes no integrity is proof against skilled pressure. Personal grievance surfaces in "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus", and the contrast that follows, "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me", admits that Cassius would not be swayed as Brutus is being swayed, a confession that he sees Brutus as weaker. The plan for forged letters, "In several hands", "As if they came from several citizens", in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at", reveals a conspiracy that will secure its noblest member by fraud. Yet the soliloquy also contains a principle: the fear that Caesar will "seat him sure" unless Rome acts. The text leaves envy and republican conviction intertwined, and the honest reading is that both are real.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer paraphrases the plan correctly. The excellent answer quotes the words that reveal attitude rather than action: 'wrought', 'seduced', 'humour', 'as if'.

Keyword: 'Manipulation' and 'soliloquy as truth' are expected, and the excellent answer uses the convention of the soliloquy (a character alone speaks his mind) as its organising idea: the gap between said and thought.

Analysis: The weak answer's analysis is the label 'cunning and jealous'. The excellent answer analyses the metalworking metaphor and the hypothetical reversal, each of which yields a specific insight about how Cassius sees Brutus.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why forged letters are needed (argument has produced only "thus much show of fire") and what they cost (the conspiracy's honour). The weak answer records the letters as a plan.

Significance: The excellent answer refuses to reduce Cassius to envy and says so explicitly, while giving envy its full weight. Examiners reward the writer who can hold two motives in view; they do not reward the writer who picks the simpler one.

Connection: When Brutus accuses Cassius of corruption in their quarrel in Act 4, the audience remembers that the conspiracy was founded on a forgery. A student who has written the excellent answer can bring this soliloquy to an Act 4 question and earn marks with it.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where these seven questions are taught in full

The scene-by-scene reasoning behind each answer is in Chapter 3 (the tribunes), Chapters 4 and 5 (Cassius's persuasion, the Soothsayer, Casca's report, the soliloquy), Chapter 6 (the storm) and Chapter 7 (Caesar's speech about Cassius). The exact wording for every quotation used above is collected in Chapter 15, The Act 1 Quotation Bank, and the terms the dissections rely on are defined in Chapter 14, The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1.

HOW ACT 1 KNOWLEDGE EARNS MARKS IN ACT 3–5 QUESTIONS

This section is the honest answer to a question students ask constantly: 'If the board paper only sets Acts III–V, why am I studying Act 1 so carefully?' The answer is that an extract from Act 3, 4 or 5 is a surface; the marks lie underneath it, in motives, relationships and promises that Act 1 established. The five worked examples below each take a kind of question the board paper could set from Acts III–V and show precisely where an Act 1 fact or quotation converts an average answer into a strong one. In each case the Act 3–5 material is paraphrased, not quoted, so that you are not tempted to learn later-act lines from this book rather than from your text.

Worked example 1: A Brutus funeral-speech extract

The kind of sub-question: 'What reason does Brutus give the people for killing Caesar? How far is this reason consistent with what you know of him?'

The Act 1 key: In Act 3 Scene 2 Brutus tells the crowd, in prose, that he loved Caesar but loved Rome more, and that Caesar died because he was ambitious. He asks the citizens whether they would rather live as slaves under a living Caesar or as free men with Caesar dead, and he stakes the whole speech on his own honour. An average answer explains this reasoning from the extract. A strong answer shows that it is not new: Brutus announced the principle in Act 1 Scene 2 when he told Cassius that for "the general good" he would "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" and that he loved "The name of honour more than I fear death". He also declared he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions". The funeral speech is these two sentences spoken to a crowd. The strong answer therefore earns its consistency mark by proof rather than assertion, and can add the sharper point that the word 'ambitious' comes to Brutus from Cassius, whose forged letters were designed so that "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at".

Worked example 2: An Antony funeral-oration extract

The kind of sub-question: 'How does Antony use the word honourable in this extract? What does his success reveal about the crowd?'

The Act 1 key: Antony's oration turns the conspirators' claim to honour into a weapon by repeating that Brutus is an honourable man until the phrase means its opposite. An average answer identifies the irony. A strong answer brings two Act 1 facts to it. First, Caesar's own estimate of Antony in Act 1: Cassius "loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony", so Caesar saw Antony as a lover of pleasure, and Antony's own earlier words were those of a loyal subordinate, "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed". The orator of Act 3 is therefore a man everyone, including Cassius, has underestimated, and the student can say so. Second, the crowd Antony turns is the crowd Shakespeare characterised in Act 1: the commoners who switched from Pompey to Caesar

so completely that Marullus called them "blocks" and "stones", and the mob Casca saw clap and hiss Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". Antony's success reveals nothing new about the crowd; it confirms the diagnosis Act 1 made. That sentence, properly supported, is worth a mark in itself.

Worked example 3: The 'ides of March begun' question

The kind of sub-question: The 2025 paper asked what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to. The words are Cassius's, spoken to Brutus at Philippi in Act 5 before the battle, as they contemplate that this day may finish what the assassination started.

The Act 1 key: The answer is the assassination of Caesar on 15 March, and a mark is earned simply by knowing that. But the fuller answer shows where the date entered the play: the Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March" in Act 1 Scene 2, repeated when Caesar demanded "Speak once again", and dismissed with "He is a dreamer". The student can then explain the weight of Cassius's phrase: 'the work' began on a day the conspirators were warned about through the man they meant to kill, and it is still unfinished at Philippi, so that the Soothsayer's date has become the measure of the whole tragedy. A question that looks like simple recall becomes, for the prepared student, an opportunity to show understanding of the play's architecture.

Worked example 4: The quarrel scene in Act 4

The kind of sub-question: 'What does this quarrel reveal about the relationship between Brutus and Cassius?'

The Act 1 key: In the tent at Sardis Brutus accuses Cassius of taking bribes and of having an itching palm, and Cassius, wounded, protests that Brutus has wronged him; the quarrel exposes Brutus's rigid honour against Cassius's practical corruption. An average answer describes this clash. A strong answer explains why it was inevitable, using the soliloquy of Act 1 Scene 2. Cassius said there that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed", and that "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me". The alliance was built by a realist bending an idealist. In Act 4 the idealist, now awake, is judging the realist by the standard the realist used to recruit him. The strong answer can add that Cassius's "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" showed from the start that Cassius needed Brutus more than Brutus needed Cassius, which is why, in the quarrel, it is Cassius who finally yields.

Worked example 5: Caesar's last speech in the Senate (Act 3 Scene 1)

The kind of sub-question: 'What impression of Caesar do you form from his refusal of the conspirators' petition? Is it consistent with the Caesar we have seen earlier?'

The Act 1 key: Moments before he is stabbed, Caesar refuses to recall Publius Cimber, comparing himself to the fixed northern star and declaring that he alone of men is unshakeable. An average answer calls this arrogance. A strong answer shows the arrogance has a history. In Act 1 Scene 2 Caesar spoke of himself in the third person, "for always I am Caesar", and claimed to be above fear while admitting a deaf ear in the same breath. He dismissed the Soothsayer as "a dreamer". He told Antony what "is to be feared" rather than what he feared. The Senate speech is the end point of a self-image the student has watched forming since the Lupercal. The strong answer also notes who strikes first: Casca, the man Brutus remembered as "quick mettle when he went to school" and whom Cassius described as swift "in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise". A student who knows Act 1 can explain why it is Casca's hand that begins the killing; a student who does not can only report it.

ICSE EXAM BOX Using Act 1 in a board answer: the rule of proportion

Act 1 material in an Act 3–5 answer is a key, not a second answer. One precise reference, with a short quotation and a sentence showing its relevance, earns the mark. A paragraph on Act 1 in an Act 3 question signals that the student would rather answer a different extract, and examiners read it that way. Bring the Act 1 fact, use it, and return to the extract in front of you.

MCQ TRAINING

Section A of the 2025 paper carried 16 one-mark MCQs across the three genres, and MCQs on the drama can reach back to earlier acts for context. The twelve questions below are written in the ICSE manner: a short stem, four options, one correct answer, and distractors built from the errors students actually make. Answer all twelve before reading the key. A score below ten means the Common Errors section that follows is urgent reading.

1. Who speaks the first line of the play? (a) Marullus (b) Flavius (c) the Cobbler (d) Caesar
2. The Cobbler describes himself as a "surgeon to old shoes". He means that he (a) treats injured feet (b) repairs worn footwear (c) sells leather to surgeons (d) mends the tribunes' tempers
3. Marullus reminds the commoners of the days when they waited "To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome" in order to (a) praise Caesar's generosity (b) expose the crowd's fickleness (c) describe Pompey's triumph over Caesar (d) explain the feast of Lupercal
4. Caesar asks Antony to touch Calpurnia during the race because (a) she is ill (b) the elders say it cures barrenness (c) Antony has asked to meet her (d) it is a sign of Caesar's authority
5. Caesar's response to the Soothsayer's warning is (a) to arrest him (b) to ask Brutus to question him (c) to call him a dreamer and move on (d) to postpone the games
6. When Cassius tells Brutus "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself", he means he will (a) show Brutus his own hidden worth (b) protect Brutus from Caesar (c) report Brutus's words to Caesar (d) reflect Caesar's greatness
7. The crown Casca describes was offered by (a) Brutus (b) Casca himself (c) Antony (d) the Senate
8. According to Casca, Caesar refused the crown (a) once (b) twice (c) three times (d) four times
9. Casca says that Caesar "foamed at mouth and was speechless". Brutus explains this as (a) poison (b) the falling sickness (c) exhaustion from the race (d) a trick to win sympathy
10. "It was Greek to me" is said by Casca about (a) Cicero's words (b) Antony's speech (c) the Soothsayer's warning (d) Caesar's apology
11. In Act 1 Scene 3, Cassius asks Cinna to place one of the papers (a) on Caesar's statue (b) in Antony's house (c) in the praetor's chair (d) at the Capitol
12. Which of the following is NOT one of the prodigies Casca reports to Cicero? (a) a slave's hand burning without harm (b) a lion near the Capitol (c) an owl hooting at noon in the marketplace (d) blood raining on the Capitol

Answer key with one-line justifications

1. **(b) Flavius.** His "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" opens the play; Marullus speaks second. Students confuse the two because they share one role.
2. **(b) Repairs worn footwear.** The joke is that he 'recovers' (re-covers) shoes "when they are in great danger", a surgical pun on his trade.

3. **(b) Expose the crowd's fickleness.** The memory of their devotion to Pompey is set against their present rejoicing "over Pompey's blood".
4. **(b) The elders say it cures barrenness.** Caesar says "The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse"; the detail reveals his wish for an heir.
5. **(c) Call him a dreamer and move on.** "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." He does look the man in the face first, which option (a) and (b) ignore.
6. **(a) Show Brutus his own hidden worth.** Cassius will "discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of".
7. **(c) Antony.** Casca answers "Why, Antony" when Cassius asks who offered it; students who answer (a) have confused the offerer with the questioner.
8. **(c) Three times.** "he put it by thrice, every time gentler than other". Plutarch records two offers; Shakespeare's Casca says three.
9. **(b) The falling sickness.** Brutus: "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness." Cassius's reply turns the phrase into a metaphor for Rome.
10. **(a) Cicero's words.** Casca says Cicero "spoke Greek" and that those who understood "smiled at one another and shook their heads".
11. **(c) In the praetor's chair.** "lay it in the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it"; the others go in at Brutus's window and on old Brutus's statue, not Caesar's.
12. **(d) Blood raining on the Capitol.** Casca reports the burning hand, the lion, the women who saw men in fire, and the "bird of night" at noon; raining blood is not among them.

ICSE EXAM BOX Reading an MCQ the examiner's way

Distractors are built from predictable confusions: the two tribunes swapped, the questioner for the offerer, Caesar's statue for Brutus's, Plutarch's two offers for Shakespeare's three. Before choosing, ask which confusion each wrong option is testing. If you can name the confusion, you have usually found the answer.

COMMON ERRORS

Each error below has cost real students real marks. Each is stated, corrected from the text, and followed by the habit that prevents it.

1. Attributing Casca's report of the crown to Antony or Brutus. Antony offered the crown; Casca reported the offering; Brutus and Cassius listened and asked questions. Students write 'Antony tells Brutus that Caesar refused the crown' or 'Brutus saw Caesar refuse the crown'. Neither happened. Brutus and Cassius were off-stage in conversation when the offering occurred, which is why Brutus must ask "Tell us the manner of it, gentle Casca". Prevention: whenever you write about the crown, write 'Casca reports' before anything else.

2. Calling the Cobbler a carpenter. There are two commoners who speak. The Carpenter answers Flavius's question in one line; the Cobbler makes all the puns, including "a mender of bad soles" and "all that I live by is with the awl". Students who merge them write 'the carpenter jokes about mending souls', which an examiner marks as a textual error. Prevention: the pun on soles belongs to the man who makes soles.

3. Saying the crown was offered on stage. The offering happens in the marketplace while Brutus and Cassius talk elsewhere; the audience hears only shouts and flourishes, and learns what happened from Casca afterwards. This is not a technicality. Shakespeare chose to show us the event through Casca's cynical eyes so

that we cannot know whether Caesar truly wanted the crown. A student who writes 'we see Caesar refuse the crown' has missed the dramatic method. Prevention: write 'reported, not staged' in the margin of your notes on this scene.

4. Treating Caesar's deaf ear as history. "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" is Shakespeare's addition; no ancient source records it. Students write 'Caesar was historically deaf in one ear', which is an invented fact. Caesar's falling sickness, by contrast, is in Plutarch. Prevention: label the deafness as Shakespeare's dramatic emblem and the epilepsy as recorded, and keep the two separate.

5. Saying Cicero joins the conspiracy. In Act 1 Cicero speaks with Casca during the storm and leaves before Cassius arrives; he is never recruited, and in Act 2 the conspirators decide against including him. Historically he was not a conspirator. Students write 'Cicero and Casca plan the conspiracy' because both are in Scene 3. Prevention: remember that Cicero's exit line, "This disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in", removes him from the stage before any plotting begins.

6. Writing 'jealous' for Cassius without analysis. 'Cassius is jealous of Caesar' is true and earns nothing on its own. The mark comes from showing how the jealousy appears (the Tiber rescue, the fever, "this god did shake"), what it is mixed with (republican conviction, the fear that Caesar will "seat him sure"), and where the text lets the two motives show at once (the soliloquy). Caesar himself gives the analysis the student should give: such men "be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Prevention: never write 'jealous' without a 'because' and a quotation following it.

7. Saying Brutus joins the conspiracy in Act 1. He does not. He agrees to listen, "What you have said / I will consider", and Cassius's soliloquy and the forged letters exist precisely because Brutus is not yet won. His decision comes in Act 2. Prevention: track Brutus's commitment scene by scene; in Act 1 it is 'moved, not committed'.

8. Placing the storm on the night of the Lupercal. Cicero's question "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" fixes Scene 3 on the eve of the Ides, so a month passes silently between Scenes 2 and 3. Students who write 'that same night' miscount the play's time scheme. Prevention: write the date beside each scene when revising.

9. Confusing the two Cinnas. The Cinna of Act 1 Scene 3 is a conspirator who carries Cassius's letters. The Cinna torn apart by the mob in Act 3 is a poet who shares the name. Prevention: 'Cinna the conspirator' and 'Cinna the poet' in your notes, always with the label.

10. Inventing quotations. Under pressure students produce lines that sound Shakespearean but are not in the play, or splice two lines together. Examiners know the text. A paraphrase introduced with 'Cassius says that...' is safe; an invented quotation in quotation marks is a visible error. Prevention: learn fewer quotations and learn them exactly; Chapter 15 gives you the set.

REVISION The examiner-mode checklist

Before you write any sub-answer: find the verb in the question and name the level it demands (recall, understanding, application, analysis, evaluation). First sentence: answer the verb, with a textual anchor, no stalling. Three-mark answer: three points, three short pieces of evidence, five to seven sentences. Four-mark answer: a position, two supported points, one 'although', one 'because', eight to ten sentences. Never begin with a character's name and an action verb. Never write 'jealous', 'proud', 'important' or 'foreshadows' without the evidence that earns it. In an Act 3–5 answer, use Act 1 as a key, in one precise sentence, and return to the extract. And remember what the examiner reads first: the first two lines.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

Chapter 18, Extract-Based Training (Part One), and Chapter 19, Extract-Based Training (Part Two), apply everything in this chapter to twelve full Act 1 extracts with marked model answers. Chapter 16, The Scene Connection Engine, maps every Act 1 moment that resurfaces in Acts 3–5, and is the natural companion to the worked examples above. Chapter 14, The ICSE Keyword Vault, supplies the terminology the dissections used.

Connections in ten lines

REVISION The connection engine in ten lines

1. Act 1 is a system: every event is a cause of something later and an echo of something earlier.
2. Scene 1 plants the crowd's fickleness and the cost of opposing Caesar; both return in Act 3.
3. Scene 2 plants Caesar's body, Brutus's inner war, Cassius's method and the Soothsayer's date.
4. Scene 3 turns talk into organisation: dagger, handshake, letters, headquarters, and the plan to secure Brutus.
5. The nine threads to know by heart: public opinion, Caesar's body, Brutus's conflict, Cassius's method, omens, the Ides, the letters, Antony, the tribunes.
6. Every omen is *construed* by someone; Cicero's sentence is the key to all of them.
7. The forged letters make Brutus co-author of his own deception; he never finds out.
8. Antony is misread by everyone in Act 1, and the misreading is the conspiracy's fatal error.
9. 'Be sure of him' is the hinge: securing Brutus is what unsecures the plot.
10. In the exam, Act 1 is context, not subject: one accurate backward reference, early, then analyse the extract.

REVISION The act in ten lines

1. Scene 1: holiday broken up; the tribunes fear a bird that "would soar above the view of men".
2. Scene 2: Caesar's image — command, third person, "He is a dreamer".
3. Scene 2: Brutus is "with himself at war" before Cassius speaks politics.
4. Scene 2: Cassius as mirror — "I, your glass" — and the honour lever.
5. Scene 2: the private Caesar — "this god did shake"; the coronet refused thrice, reported by Casca.
6. Scene 2: Caesar reads Cassius rightly and does nothing — "for always I am Caesar".
7. Scene 2: soliloquy — "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?"; forged letters planned.
8. Scene 3: the storm; Cicero on construing; Cassius reads the sky as Caesar.
9. Scene 3: Casca's hand, Cinna's errand, Pompey's Porch, the widening circle.
10. Scene 3: "be sure of him" — the act ends on Brutus, asleep, about to be woken by a lie.

CHAPTER 1

Extract Practice: Six Exam-Style Extracts

What this chapter does: six extracts from Act 1 in ICSE format, each with questions worth [3][3][3][3][4], model answers, and the reasons each answer earns marks. Write your own answer before reading the model.

Extract 2 — Marullus Remembers Pompey

EXTRACT Extract 2 — Act 1 Scene 1, Marullus turns on the crowd

Marullus: *Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?
What tributaries follow him to Rome
To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?
You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!
O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome,
Knew you not Pompey? Many a time and oft
Have you climbed up to walls and battlements,
To towers and windows, yea, to chimney tops,
Your infants in your arms, and there have sat
The livelong day, with patient expectation,
To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome.
And when you saw his chariot but appear,
Have you not made an universal shout,*

Context: Still the opening scene, moments after Extract 1. The Cobbler has finally given a straight answer to the tribunes' question about why the shops are shut: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." The word rejoice detonates this speech. Marullus, who has so far only interrogated, now delivers the play's first passionate verse oration.

Speaker: Marullus, tribune of the people.

Listener: The assembled commoners, with Flavius beside him. The speech is public, and that is its point: Marullus is trying to shame a crowd into remembering.

Before: Flavius has asked "But wherefore art not in thy shop today?" and "Why dost thou lead these men about the streets?"; the Cobbler has joked that he leads them about "to wear out their shoes, to get myself into more work", then admitted the truth about Caesar's triumph.

After: Marullus finishes the picture of the old days, when the people's shout was so loud "That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds / Made in her concave shores?" He then hammers the contrast with a triple question: "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?" He dismisses them with orders to go home, kneel and "Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude." Flavius adds a gentler command to weep into the Tiber, and the commoners leave without a word.

Meaning: 'Why celebrate? What conquest has he brought home? What conquered peoples, paying tribute, walk behind him to Rome as chained prisoners decorating his chariot? You blocks of wood, you stones, you things with even less feeling than that! You hard-hearted, cruel Romans, did you not know Pompey? Time and again you climbed up walls and battlements, towers and windows, even chimney tops, carrying your babies, and sat there all day waiting patiently just to watch great Pompey pass through the streets. And the moment his chariot came into view, did you not all shout together...' Difficult words: tributaries (subject peoples or rulers who pay tribute to a conqueror), captive bonds (the chains of prisoners of war), grace (adorn), senseless (without the power to feel), livelong (the whole, long), replication (echo), concave shores (hollowed, curving river banks).

Subtext: The first two questions are an accusation in disguise. A triumph was meant to display foreign captives and foreign wealth; there are none here, because Caesar has defeated Romans, the sons of Pompey. Marullus cannot say 'this triumph is illegal' to a festive crowd, so he asks them to notice what is missing from the procession. The reminder of Pompey is also a charge of betrayal: the crowd has transferred its love to the man who destroyed its old hero. But the speech contains an irony Marullus does not intend. His own picture of the people climbing chimneys to watch a chariot proves that they have always loved the spectacle more than the man. They cheered Pompey's chariot; now they cheer Caesar's. The very memory he uses to shame them shows that they cannot be relied on by either side.

Character: Marullus is passionate, eloquent and brave, and he has a sense of history that the crowd lacks. He is also a partisan: his grief for Pompey is personal, and his contempt for the crowd is open. He attacks the people he ought to be winning over, calling them stones and cruel men, and he ends by predicting divine punishment for them. He is the republic at its most sincere and least skilful.

Theme: Public opinion and its fickleness; ingratitude as a political sin; the illegitimacy of power won over fellow citizens in civil war; the contest between memory (Pompey) and spectacle (Caesar's chariot). Beneath all of these lies the play's central anxiety: a republic whose survival depends on a crowd that changes its mind.

Device: Marullus begins with a barrage of rhetorical questions, which demand agreement rather than information. He turns to invective (violent abuse) and apostrophe (direct address) in "You blocks, you stones", a metaphor that reduces men to lifeless objects, then intensifies it: they are "worse than senseless things", because stones at least cannot be ungrateful. The list of vantage points is a climax, an ascending order from walls to battlements to towers to windows to chimney tops, so that the crowd's devotion seems to rise physically before our eyes. The detail of infants in arms is pathos, an appeal to feeling. In the lines that follow, the personified Tiber trembling at the echo is hyperbole, and the repeated "And do you now" is anaphora, the repetition of an opening phrase, which turns the contrast between then and now into a drumbeat.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: A Roman triumph was granted by the Senate for victory over a foreign enemy. The procession moved from the Campus Martius through the city to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitoline hill: captives in chains and the spoils of war went before, and the general rode in a four-horse chariot wearing a purple-and-gold toga and a laurel wreath. A triumph for a civil-war victory was considered improper, and Plutarch records that Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC, which celebrated the defeat of Pompey's sons at Munda, was resented for exactly this reason. Pompey the Great had celebrated three

triumphs and was for years the most popular man in Rome; he was defeated by Caesar at Pharsalus in 48 BC and murdered in Egypt shortly afterwards. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare places this triumph on the day of the Lupercalia, which historically fell four months later; the compression lets the tribunes' grievance and the crown-offering collide in a single afternoon.

Scene connection: The appetite for spectacle Marullus describes is exactly what Casca reports later in Scene 2, when the crowd claps and hisses Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". The fickleness will become the engine of Act 3, where the same crowd is turned by Brutus and then by Antony within minutes. Pompey's name keeps returning: the conspirators gather at Pompey's Porch in Scene 3, and Caesar's death in Act 3 is staged in Pompey's shadow. Marullus's contempt for the people also anticipates Cassius's outburst in Scene 3 that Rome has become trash and rubbish for serving as fuel to Caesar's fire: the republicans of this play never quite respect the republic's citizens.

Keywords: rhetorical question; invective; apostrophe; metaphor; climax; anaphora; hyperbole; personification; pathos; fickle; ingratitude; tributaries; triumph; civil war; partisan; Pompeian.

QUESTIONS Extract 2 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) Who is the speaker, and to whom is he speaking? What has just been said that provokes this outburst, and on what occasion? [3]
- (ii) Explain the lines "What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?" Why can this question be called a hidden accusation against Caesar? [3]
- (iii) What picture does Marullus paint of the people's former devotion to Pompey? Select two details from the extract and explain the effect of each. [3]
- (iv) Identify two rhetorical devices used in the extract and show how each one strengthens Marullus's attack on the crowd. [3]
- (v) Marullus calls the people "worse than senseless things". In your view, does his own speech prove or disprove this judgement? Refer to what happens immediately after the speech and to the crowd's behaviour later in Act 1. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Knew you not Pompey?" Who was Pompey, and what had happened to him? Why does the speaker bring up his name at this moment?
- (b) "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" Who is being addressed? Name the figure of speech and comment on the tone of the line.

Multiple-choice questions

1. In the extract, tributaries means: (a) small rivers flowing into a larger one (b) conquered peoples who pay tribute to Rome (c) members of the Roman Senate (d) Caesar's veteran soldiers
2. In the play, Caesar's triumph celebrates his victory over: (a) the tribes of Gaul (b) the sons of Pompey (c) the Parthians (d) the Egyptians
3. When Marullus finishes speaking, the commoners: (a) argue with him (b) attack the tribunes (c) leave in silence (d) begin to cheer for Pompey

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The speaker is Marullus, one of the two tribunes of the people, and he is addressing the crowd of working men whom he and Flavius have stopped in a street of Rome. The occasion is the public holiday for Caesar's triumphal return after defeating the sons of Pompey, which falls on the feast of Lupercal. The Cobbler has just admitted that the men have shut their shops in order to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph, and it is the idea of rejoicing at such a victory that provokes Marullus's anger.

Why this answer earns marks: Speaker, listener and occasion are given precisely (context and recall). The trigger for the speech is identified from the text, with the key word rejoice picked out, so the examiner sees that the student has located the extract exactly and understood why it begins with the question Wherefore rejoice.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Marullus asks what conquered peoples are walking behind Caesar to Rome as prisoners in chains, decorating his chariot as trophies of victory. In a proper Roman triumph the general displayed foreign captives and plunder to prove that he had enlarged the power of Rome. Marullus's question expects the answer none, because Caesar has not conquered a foreign enemy; he has defeated fellow Romans, the sons of Pompey, in a civil war. The question is therefore an accusation in disguise. Without ever saying that the triumph is improper or that Caesar is dangerous, Marullus invites the crowd to see for themselves that there is nothing to celebrate, and that the man they are cheering has spilt Roman blood.

Why this answer earns marks: The paraphrase is accurate and glosses the two hard words (tributaries, captive bonds). The answer then explains the historical logic of a triumph, which is needed to see why the question wounds, and finally answers the second part directly, explaining what is hidden and why it is an accusation. Understanding, context and analysis are all present.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Marullus describes a people so devoted to Pompey that they would climb to any height and wait any length of time for a glimpse of him. Two details stand out. First, the rising list of places, from "walls and battlements" up to "chimney tops": the climax makes the crowd's eagerness seem to grow taller as he speaks, and the comic exaggeration of the chimney tops mocks how far they were once willing to go. Second, "Your infants in your arms": the people brought their babies, as if to a family festival, and this detail adds pathos, reminding them that their love for Pompey was tender and shared, not merely political. Both details make the present celebration of Pompey's conqueror look like a betrayal of something intimate.

Why this answer earns marks: The question asks for two details and their effects, and the answer delivers exactly that structure with short accurate quotations. Each effect is explained in terms of a named device (climax, pathos) and linked to Marullus's purpose. The last sentence draws the two points together into the argument of the speech, which shows analysis rather than description.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

The first device is the rhetorical question. Marullus opens with a volley of them: "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?" and so on. They are not requests for information but challenges; each one forces the crowd to supply an answer that condemns them, so that they seem to accuse themselves. The second device is apostrophe combined with metaphor: in "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" he addresses the people directly and reduces them to lifeless objects, then intensifies the insult by saying they are worse than stones, since stones cannot be ungrateful. The direct address makes the attack personal and inescapable, and the metaphor strips the crowd of the very humanity, memory and feeling, that he is about to appeal to when he recalls Pompey.

Why this answer earns marks: Two devices are correctly named (terminology), each is quoted, and each is explained in terms of its effect on the listener, which is what the word strengthens in the question demands. The answer does not stop at identification, the commonest way to lose marks on a device question; it says what the device does.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

Marullus's speech comes closer to proving his charge than he might wish, though not in the way he means. Immediately after it the commoners do not defend themselves; as Flavius observes, they "vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness". Their silence suggests that they had never thought about what they were celebrating, and that they can be shamed out of a mood as easily as they were talked into it. Later in Scene 2 Casca describes the same crowd shouting at every refusal of the crown, throwing up their sweaty nightcaps, and then forgiving Caesar "with all their hearts" when he faints, behaving, in Casca's words, like an audience at a play. Their reactions are instant and emotional, driven by spectacle rather than judgement. Yet senseless is the wrong word. The Cobbler shows quick intelligence, and the crowd's love of Pompey, which Marullus himself recalls, was real while it lasted. The truth Act 1 establishes is that the people feel strongly but remember briefly, which makes them dangerous rather than stupid. Marullus's speech proves their fickleness; it disproves the claim that they have no feeling at all.

Why this answer earns marks: The verdict is stated at once and then argued. The answer uses the immediate aftermath (connection to the lines after the extract), a second piece of evidence from Scene 2 (quotation and connection), and a counter-argument from the extract and the Cobbler. It distinguishes between fickle and senseless, which is the precise judgement the question invites, and it closes with a balanced conclusion in one sentence.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Pompey the Great was Caesar's former ally and later his rival, a hugely popular general who had celebrated three triumphs and whom the Roman people had adored. He was defeated by Caesar in the civil war and afterwards killed in Egypt; the triumph being celebrated in this scene is for Caesar's victory over Pompey's sons. Marullus raises his name to shame the crowd: the people who once climbed to chimney tops to see Pompey pass are now dressing in their best to cheer the man who destroyed him and his family.

(b) Marullus addresses the commoners of Rome. The line is an apostrophe, a direct address, built on metaphors that compare the people to blocks of wood and stones, objects without the power to feel. The tone is contemptuous and furious; the repeated you strikes like a series of blows, and the escalation to "worse than senseless things" shows a speaker who has abandoned argument for abuse.

Why these answers earn marks: Each identifies the speaker, the listener and the situation before interpreting. Answer (a) supplies the historical fact the question expects (who Pompey was and what happened to him) and then explains the speaker's purpose. Answer (b) names the devices correctly and describes tone with precise adjectives rather than vague ones.

MCQ key: 1 (b); 2 (b); 3 (c). The distractor in question 1 is the modern geographical meaning of tributary; in question 2, (a) is a real Caesarian victory but not the one the play's triumph celebrates.

Extract 4 — Caesar, Antony and the Soothsayer

TEXT NOTE About the length of this extract

This passage is a little longer than a board extract usually is, because the three moments named in it, the fertility instruction, the warning and the dismissal, form one dramatic unit and are best trained together. In an examination you would be given ten to fourteen lines from within it; the labels and questions below would apply to any such window.

EXTRACT Extract 4 — Act 1 Scene 2, the opening of the scene

Caesar: *Forget not, in your speed, Antonius,
To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say
The barren, touchèd in this holy chase,
Shake off their sterile curse.*

Antony: *I shall remember.
When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed.*

Caesar: *Set on, and leave no ceremony out.*

Soothsayer: *Caesar.*

Caesar: *Ha! Who calls?*

Casca: *Bid every noise be still. Peace, yet again!*

Caesar: *Who is it in the press that calls on me?
I hear a tongue shriller than all the music
Cry 'Caesar.' Speak. Caesar is turned to hear.*

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *What man is that?*

Brutus: *A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *Set him before me. Let me see his face.*

Cassius: *Fellow, come from the throng. Look upon Caesar.*

Caesar: *What sayst thou to me now? Speak once again.*

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

Context: The opening of Scene 2, moments after the tribunes have left. A flourish of trumpets and the stage fills: Caesar enters with his train, Antony stripped for the race, Calpurnia, Portia, Decius, Cicero, Brutus, Cassius, Casca and a crowd, among whom stands a Soothsayer. It is the feast of Lupercal, and Antony is about to run the ritual course. This is our first sight of Caesar, and Shakespeare shows him doing two things in quick succession: giving a domestic order in public, and receiving a warning in public.

Speaker: Caesar dominates; Antony, Casca, Brutus and Cassius each speak a line; the Soothsayer speaks four words, twice.

Listener: Antony and Calpurnia are addressed, but the true audience is the whole crowd. Everything Caesar says here is said to be overheard.

Before: Caesar has twice called "Calpurnia", and Casca has silenced the crowd with "Peace, ho! Caesar speaks." Caesar has told his wife to "Stand you directly in Antonius' way / When he doth run his course."

After: A sennet sounds and the whole procession leaves for the games. Only Brutus and Cassius remain, and Cassius opens the conversation of Extract 5 by asking "Will you go see the order of the course?" While they talk, off-stage, Antony offers Caesar the crown three times; we learn of it only from Casca's report later in the scene.

Meaning: Caesar tells Antony not to forget, as he runs, to touch Calpurnia, because the old belief is that childless women touched during this sacred race are freed from the curse of barrenness. Antony answers that he will remember, and adds that whatever Caesar commands is done. Caesar orders the procession forward with instructions to omit no part of the ritual. A voice calls his name; he asks who it is, Casca calls for silence, and Caesar says he hears one voice, sharper than all the festival music, crying his name, and that he has turned to listen. The Soothsayer tells him to beware the fifteenth of March. Caesar asks who the man is; Brutus repeats the warning; Caesar demands to see the man's face; Cassius brings him forward. Caesar asks him to speak again, hears the same four words, and dismisses him as a dreamer before ordering the procession on. Difficult words: speed (haste; here, the running itself), elders (people of former times), barren (childless), holy chase (sacred race), sterile curse (the curse of childlessness), set on (go forward), press (crowd), shriller (more piercing), soothsayer (a foreteller of the future, literally a truth-sayer), ides (the fifteenth day of March), dreamer (a man who sees visions; a fantasist).

Subtext: Caesar's first public act announces before all Rome that his wife is barren. **LITERARY**

INTERPRETATION: many readers take this as a hint of dynastic thinking, a ruler who wants an heir; the text does not say so, and leaves the motive open. What is certain is that Caesar treats a private matter as a public ceremony, and that Antony's reply is the language of a servant, not of a fellow consul. It tells us how power now works in Rome: Caesar speaks, and things happen. The Soothsayer episode is then a study in performance. Caesar hears one thin voice through the music, which suggests a man alert to threat; he demands to see the face, which suggests curiosity, even unease; he asks to hear the warning again, which suggests he has taken it in. Then, having listened in full view of the crowd, he dismisses it. He cannot be seen to fear, so he performs not fearing. The dismissal is as much for the onlookers as for himself.

Character: Caesar is commanding, ceremonious and image-conscious; he refers to himself by name, as if Caesar were a public office he occupies. He is superstitious enough to insist on every detail of a fertility rite, yet dismisses a warning about his own life, a contradiction the play will return to. Antony is devoted, athletic and obedient, the loyal lieutenant. The Soothsayer is calm, nameless and unmoved: he does not argue, he repeats. Casca plays the officious herald, silencing the crowd for the man he will be the first to stab. Brutus is the one who relays the warning to Caesar, and Cassius the one who brings the Soothsayer face to face with him: the two future conspirators literally deliver the prophecy.

Theme: Fate and free will, in the first prophecy of the play and the first refusal to heed it. Superstition and omens, and the inconsistency with which Caesar treats them. Appearance versus reality, in the gap between the public Caesar who fears nothing and the private man who turns to listen. Power and obedience, in Antony's reply. Leadership, in the question of whether a great man can afford to be seen taking advice from a stranger in a crowd.

Device: The dominant device is dramatic irony: the audience knows what the ides of March will bring, so Caesar's confident dismissal is heard against knowledge he lacks. The warning itself is foreshadowing, made heavier by repetition, since the Soothsayer says the identical words twice and Brutus repeats them a third time. Caesar's third-person self-reference, "Caesar is turned to hear", is sometimes called illeism; it separates the man from his public role. There is contrast between the loud festival music and the single shrill voice that cuts through it, an aural image of truth interrupting celebration. The dismissal ends in anticlimax: one word, "Pass", closes an episode that the audience knows to be the most important warning in the play.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: The Lupercalia was held on 15 February. The Luperci ran through the city striking bystanders, especially women, with strips of goat-hide, which was believed to promote fertility; Antony, consul in 44 BC, ran as one of them. Calpurnia had married Caesar in 59 BC and the marriage was childless; Caesar's only legitimate child, Julia, had died in 54 BC. Plutarch and Suetonius both record that a seer named Spurinna warned Caesar of a danger that would come no later than the ides of March.

The ides were one of the three fixed marker days of the Roman month, falling on the fifteenth of March, May, July and October and on the thirteenth of the other months; they were sacred to Jupiter. Caesar was killed on 15 March 44 BC. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare makes the seer anonymous, moves the warning into a public crowd, and fuses it with the Lupercalia, so that celebration and doom occupy the same minute of stage time.

Scene connection: Antony's promise of instant obedience prepares for Caesar's later request in this scene that Antony tell him truly what he thinks of Cassius, and for Antony's loyalty after Caesar's death in Act 3. Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer is the first in a series: in Act 2 he will brush aside Calpurnia's dream and the priests' warnings, and on the ides he will meet the Soothsayer again. The barren Calpurnia of this extract is the frightened Calpurnia of Act 2. Casca's cry for silence is the first thing this man does for Caesar; the last is to strike him. And the warning about the ides is the thread that the Class X paper picks up in Act 5, when the conspirators speak of the work begun on the ides of March.

Keywords: dramatic irony; foreshadowing; omen; prophecy; soothsayer; ides; Lupercal; fertility rite; illeism; public persona; superstition; dismissal; anticlimax; fate versus free will.

QUESTIONS Extract 4 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) What festival is being celebrated in this scene? What does Caesar ask Antony to do, and what belief lies behind the request? [3]
- (ii) Explain Antony's reply, "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." What does it tell us about Antony, and about Caesar's position in Rome? [3]
- (iii) Trace, step by step, how Caesar reacts to the Soothsayer's warning. What is the effect of his final words, "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."? [3]
- (iv) Caesar says "Caesar is turned to hear", speaking of himself by name. What does this habit reveal about him? Support your answer with one other example of Caesar's self-presentation from Act 1. [3]
- (v) The Soothsayer's warning is spoken twice and dismissed in a few seconds. What dramatic purposes does this brief exchange serve for the play as a whole? In your view, is Caesar's dismissal more a sign of strength or of weakness? Give reasons. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Beware the ides of March." Who speaks, to whom, and where? What are the ides of March, and why is the warning important?
- (b) "Forget not, in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia". Explain the custom Caesar refers to. What does the request reveal about Caesar?

Multiple-choice questions

1. The ides of March fall on: (a) 1 March (b) 13 March (c) 15 March (d) 31 March
2. In this scene Antony is about to: (a) deliver a speech to the Senate (b) run in the Lupercal race (c) fight in the games (d) offer a sacrifice to Jupiter
3. The person who repeats the Soothsayer's words to Caesar is: (a) Antony (b) Casca (c) Brutus (d) Cassius

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The festival is the feast of Lupercal, an ancient Roman celebration in which young men ran a ritual race through the streets. Caesar asks Antony, who is one of the runners, not to forget to touch Calpurnia, his wife, as he passes her. The belief behind the request is the traditional one Caesar himself quotes: that childless women who are touched by the runners during this holy race are freed from the curse of barrenness. Caesar has already told Calpurnia to stand directly in Antony's path so that the touch will not be missed.

Why this answer earns marks: The festival is named with a brief accurate description (recall and context), the request is stated, and the belief is explained in the student's own words with the supporting detail from just before the extract (connection). Three clean points for three marks, with no drifting into interpretation that the question did not ask for.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Antony means that whatever Caesar commands is carried out at once; a wish of Caesar's is as good as an accomplished fact. The reply shows Antony as utterly loyal and obedient, a lieutenant who takes pride in serving, and who is happy to say so in front of a crowd. It also reveals the reality of power in Rome. Antony is himself a consul, in law Caesar's equal, yet he speaks like a servant to a master. His words announce, before Caesar has done anything on stage, that one man's will has become the law of the city, which is exactly what the tribunes feared in the previous scene and what Cassius will complain of in a moment.

Why this answer earns marks: The line is paraphrased, then the two parts of the question are answered separately and explicitly: what it shows about Antony and what it shows about Caesar. The point about consuls being equals supplies the historical understanding that makes the second point sharp, and the closing sentence connects the reply to Scene 1 and to the coming conversation, showing awareness of the scene's design.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Caesar first hears a single voice through the festival music and asks who is calling; the fact that he picks out one shrill tongue shows how alert he is. When Brutus repeats the warning, Caesar orders the man to be brought before him so that he can see his face, which suggests curiosity, and perhaps a flicker of unease. He then asks the Soothsayer to say the words again, so he hears the warning twice in full. Only then does he dismiss it: the man is a dreamer, they will leave him, the procession must pass. The final words are brisk and contemptuous, and their effect is double. To the crowd they display a Caesar above fear; to the audience, who know what the ides will bring, they are heavy with dramatic irony, and the single word Pass, closing so grave a warning, sounds like a man waving away his own death.

Why this answer earns marks: The question says step by step, and the answer follows the sequence exactly, interpreting each step briefly. The comment on the final words names the device (dramatic irony), distinguishes the effect on the crowd from the effect on the audience, and ends with a precise observation about a single word, which is the kind of close reading that earns the full mark.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

By speaking of himself as Caesar rather than I, Caesar treats his own name as a title and himself as a public institution. It suggests a man who watches himself from the outside, conscious of how he appears, and who has begun to think of Caesar as something larger than the individual who bears the name. The habit is both grandeur and self-protection: the institution Caesar cannot be frightened by a stranger in a crowd, even if the man might be. The same self-presentation appears later in the scene when, having told Antony that thin men like Cassius are dangerous, he insists "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." There too he claims that the name itself rules out fear, moments before admitting that one of his ears is deaf.

Why this answer earns marks: The habit is explained in terms of character (public role, self-consciousness) rather than merely noticed, and the analysis is balanced, seeing both grandeur and defence. The second example is quoted accurately from Act 1 as the question requires (quotation and connection), and the closing remark about the deaf ear shows that the student can see the gap between the name and the man.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The exchange does far more than its few seconds suggest. First, it plants the play's central prophecy: from now on the audience measures every scene against the ides of March, and the phrase returns in Act 2, on the day of the murder in Act 3 and in the conspirators' words as late as Act 5. Second, it establishes Caesar's relationship with fate, a man who is warned and chooses not to hear, which is repeated with Calpurnia's dream and the priests in Act 2. Third, it arranges the future conspirators around the warning: Brutus repeats it, Cassius escorts the Soothsayer, Casca silences the crowd, so that the men who will fulfil the prophecy are shown delivering it. Fourth, it gives the first sample of Caesar's public manner, the third-person grandeur and the refusal to show fear. As for the dismissal itself, it is strength in one sense: a ruler who trembled at every stranger's cry would not be Caesar, and his composure before the crowd is real courage. But it is weakness in a deeper sense. He listens carefully, asks to hear the warning twice, and still rejects it, not because he has weighed it but because Caesar must be seen to be above it. The public image decides what the man may believe. That is the flaw the play will punish: not superstition, and not scepticism, but the inability to let the private man act on what the public man has heard.

Why this answer earns marks: The first half answers what dramatic purposes with four distinct, textually grounded points and connections forward through the play. The second half gives a genuine evaluation, granting the case for strength before arguing for weakness, and ends with a precise formulation of Caesar's flaw. Structure, evidence, terminology and judgement are all visible, which is what a 4-mark evaluative question rewards.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) A Soothsayer, a nameless fortune-teller in the crowd, speaks these words to Caesar in a public place in Rome during the feast of Lupercal, and repeats them when Caesar has him brought forward. The ides of March are the fifteenth of March in the Roman calendar. The warning is important because it is the play's first prophecy: Caesar will be murdered on that day, so his dismissal of the Soothsayer as a dreamer is the first of several refusals to hear the truth.

(b) Caesar refers to the belief that a childless woman touched by one of the runners during the sacred Lupercal race would be cured of barrenness; he wants Antony, who is running, to touch Calpurnia. The request reveals a Caesar who observes ritual scrupulously, who is willing to speak of his wife's childlessness before the whole city, and who expects his personal wishes to be carried out as part of a public ceremony. Many readers also hear in it a ruler's wish for an heir, though the text does not say so.

Why these answers earn marks: Both fix speaker, listener and place before explaining, both gloss the difficult term (ides; the fertility custom), and both end with an interpretative sentence that is careful to separate what the text states from what readers infer.

MCQ key: 1 (c); 2 (b); 3 (c). Question 1 tests a fact students often misremember: the ides fall on the fifteenth in March, not the thirteenth, which is the date in most other months.

Extract 6 — The Colossus

TEXT NOTE About the length of this extract

The Colossus speech runs to nineteen lines and is printed here whole, because the giant, the stars and the two names form a single argument that is best learnt as one. An examination window would take ten to fourteen of these lines, most often beginning at "Why, man" and ending somewhere between "underlings" and "noble bloods". Everything below applies to any such window.

EXTRACT Extract 6 — Act 1 Scene 2, Cassius answers the second shout

Cassius: *Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world
Like a Colossus, and we petty men
Walk under his huge legs and peep about
To find ourselves dishonourable graves.
Men at some time are masters of their fates.
The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars,
But in ourselves, that we are underlings.
'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'?
Why should that name be sounded more than yours?
Write them together, yours is as fair a name;
Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well;
Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with 'em,
'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'
Now, in the names of all the gods at once,
Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed
That he is grown so great? Age, thou art shamed!
Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!*

Context: Still Scene 2, still the two men alone, a few minutes after Extract 5. Cassius has told his two stories against Caesar, the near-drowning in the Tiber and the fever in Spain, and has ended on his amazement that "A man of such a feeble temper should / So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone." A second shout and flourish come from the games. Brutus says "Another general shout! / I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar." Cassius answers with this speech, the most famous passage in Act 1.

Speaker: Cassius, uninterrupted. Brutus says nothing for the whole speech and for the eleven lines that follow it, and his silence is part of the drama; we watch him listen.

Listener: Brutus alone. But the speech is shaped for two ears at once: for Brutus the Roman, who is told that Rome has shrunk to one man, and for Brutus the descendant, who is told that his name is as good as Caesar's.

Before: The Tiber and fever stories were personal: a Cassius who saved Caesar's life and watched him shake with fever, now forced to bow if Caesar "carelessly but nod on him". Brutus's remark about "new honours" turns the talk from the man to the city, and Cassius follows him there.

After: Cassius goes on without pause. He asks when any age "since the great flood" was famous for only one man, and plays on the city's name: "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man." Then he reaches for the ancestor: "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." Only then does Brutus speak, and his reply is cautious and dignified: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." He asks not to be pressed further for the present, promises to consider what has been said, and leaves Cassius with a sentence to "chew upon": "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us." Cassius is satisfied: "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus." Caesar then returns with his train, "The angry spot" glowing on his brow, and the scene moves to Caesar's judgement of Cassius and Casca's report.

Meaning: 'Why, man, Caesar straddles this cramped world like the Colossus, and we small men walk about between his enormous legs, peering around for a place to be buried without honour. There are moments when men control their own destinies. The blame, dear Brutus, does not lie in the stars under which we were born; it lies in ourselves, that we accept the position of inferiors. Brutus and Caesar: what is so special about the word Caesar? Why should that name be proclaimed more loudly than yours? Write the two side by side, and yours is as handsome a name; speak them, and yours fits the mouth just as well; weigh them, and yours is just as heavy; use them in a spell, and Brutus will raise a ghost as quickly as Caesar will. Now, by all the gods together, what food does this Caesar of ours eat that he has grown so huge? Our age should be ashamed. Rome, you have lost your stock of noble families.' Difficult words: *bestride* (stand with a leg on each side of), *Colossus* (a giant statue; here the famous one at Rhodes), *petty* (small, insignificant), *peep about* (peer around timidly), *underlings* (inferiors, subordinates), *sounded* (proclaimed, spoken aloud), *become* (suit), *conjure* (summon spirits by magic), *start* (raise, rouse), *meat* (food in general), *breed* (stock, lineage).

Subtext: The speech has three movements, and each attacks Brutus from a different side. The Colossus humiliates: it makes Caesar not merely great but monstrously disproportionate, and makes every other Roman, Brutus included, a small creature scuttling about beneath him. The word dishonourable is aimed with care, since Brutus has just sworn that he loves honour more than life; Cassius is telling him that under Caesar even his grave will be shameful. The lines about the stars then turn humiliation into responsibility. If the cause of Rome's condition were fate, nothing could be done and no one would be to blame; Cassius insists that the cause is human, which means that the cure is human too. He includes himself, "ourselves", "we", so the reproach does not sound like an accusation of Brutus but like a shared confession. The third movement is the subtlest: the game with the two names. Cassius never says 'you should rule instead of Caesar'; he says only that there is nothing in the sound or weight of the name Caesar that makes it superior, and lets Brutus feel the implication. The verb *conjure* reaches past the living Brutus to the dead one, the ancestor whose name could indeed raise a spirit in Rome, and Cassius will name him openly a few lines later. The closing exclamations turn personal envy into civic grief, so that the speech ends not with Cassius's wound but with Rome's.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: whether the envy or the grief is the truer motive is one of the oldest debates about the play; the extract contains evidence for both, and an honest answer says so.

Character: Cassius is a brilliant persuader and a passionate republican, but a passion for equality shades here into resentment at being outshone, and the speech lets us hear both. He is quick, physical in his imagination, scornful and grand by turns, and he is at his most eloquent when he is most personal. Brutus, silent throughout, is characterised by what he does not do: he does not interrupt, protest, or defend Caesar, and when he finally speaks he admits that he has some idea what Cassius is driving at. The listener who lets such a speech run to its end has already half consented. Caesar, absent, is characterised too, as a giant who has grown by eating something no one else was offered, an image that makes his greatness seem unnatural rather than earned.

Theme: Fate and free will, in the play's most quoted statement that men, not stars, make their condition, spoken in the same scene as a prophecy that will prove true. Power and its disproportion, the republic's horror at a city that holds only one man. Honour, in the "dishonourable graves" that await those who submit. Jealousy and the politics of names, since the speech argues that reputation is arbitrary and can be redistributed. Republican nostalgia, in the lament for an age that has lost "the breed of noble bloods". Individual against state, since Cassius's case is that one individual has swallowed the state.

Device: The opening is a simile, Caesar "Like a Colossus", developed into a visual image of giant legs and tiny men, and heightened by hyperbole; the world itself becomes "narrow" beside him. "Men at some time are masters of their fates" is a sententia or aphorism, and the two lines on the stars are an antithesis, our stars against ourselves, which makes the argument feel as balanced as a law. The passage on the names is a sustained tricolon with anaphora-like parallel imperatives, "Write them", "Sound them", "Weigh them", followed by a fourth, "conjure with 'em", so that the names are tested in four ways like coins and found equal.

There is a metaphor of magic in conjure and "start a spirit", and a metaphor of unnatural feeding in "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed", which makes Caesar's growth bestial. The last two lines are apostrophe, direct address to the abstractions Age and Rome, and exclamations that lift the voice from argument to lament; "breed of noble bloods" is alliterative and bitterly ironic, since Cassius himself belongs to that breed. Underneath everything runs rhetorical questioning, five questions in nineteen lines, each designed to be answered by the listener in Cassius's favour. In the lines immediately after, the pun on Rome and room, which many editors note were pronounced alike in Shakespeare's day, caps the speech with a bitter joke.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: The Colossus of Rhodes was a huge bronze statue of the sun-god Helios set up at the harbour of Rhodes in about 280 BC and counted among the Seven Wonders of the ancient world; it had fallen in an earthquake long before Caesar's time. The picture of it straddling the harbour mouth with ships passing between its legs is a medieval legend, not ancient fact, and Shakespeare's image depends on that legend. Lucius Junius Brutus led the expulsion of King Tarquin the Proud in 509 BC, by tradition the founding act of the Roman Republic, and Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him; this is the Brutus who could, in Cassius's words, "start a spirit". In February 44 BC Caesar had been made dictator for life, breaking the old six-month limit on the office, and had already held unprecedented honours; the shouts off-stage, in Plutarch's account, greeted Antony's offer of a diadem at the Lupercalia. Cassius had been pardoned by Caesar after the civil war and made praetor, but received the less prestigious praetorship while Brutus received the urban one, and ancient writers treat this as a grievance. Plutarch also reports that Caesar said he feared not fat, long-haired men but pale, thin ones, meaning Brutus and Cassius, which Shakespeare dramatises moments after this speech. Historically, too, Cassius followed Epicurean philosophy, which denied that the gods or the stars govern human affairs; the line about the stars sits naturally in his mouth. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the talk of astrology ("our stars") is Elizabethan rather than Roman in flavour, and the audience of 1599 would have heard a familiar debate about whether the heavens fix a man's fortune.

Scene connection: The Colossus answers Flavius's hawk at the end of Scene 1: there Caesar was to "soar above the view of men", here he towers over them, and both images turn the fear of Caesar into a problem of height and scale. Cassius's "dishonourable graves" picks up Brutus's own oath about honour and death from Extract 5 and threatens him with the one thing he said he did not fear, a death without honour. The claim that the fault is in ourselves is answered in the same scene by Caesar's judgement that "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.", a judgement that is itself a kind of fate closing in. In Scene 3 Cassius repeats the method with Casca, describing a man "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown", and he turns the argument about names into action with the forged letters that will praise Brutus's name and glance at Caesar's ambition. Brutus's reply, that he would rather be a villager than call himself a son of Rome under such conditions, is his first step; the orchard soliloquy of Act 2, where he reasons his way to Caesar's death, is the second. And the confident denial of the stars returns with heavy irony on the battlefield in Act 5, where Cassius admits that he has come partly to credit the omens he once dismissed, and dies on his birthday.

Keywords: simile; Colossus; hyperbole; sententia; aphorism; antithesis; fate versus free will; tricolon; anaphora; rhetorical question; apostrophe; exclamation; metaphor of conjuring; metaphor of feeding; underlings; republican nostalgia; envy versus principle; lineage; pun.

QUESTIONS Extract 6 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) Who is speaking, to whom, and where? What has just been heard, and how has the listener explained it? [3]
- (ii) Explain the image of the Colossus. Who are the "petty men", and what does Cassius mean by "dishonourable graves"? [3]
- (iii) Explain the lines "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." How does this view of human life compare with the Soothsayer's warning earlier in the scene? [3]
- (iv) What does Cassius do with the two names Brutus and Caesar in this extract? Identify the devices he uses and explain what he hopes to achieve. [3]
- (v) Cassius has been described as 'a patriot driven by envy'. Using this extract and the stories about Caesar that come just before it, say how far you agree with this description. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" Who says this, and in what circumstances? Name the figure of speech and explain what the speaker is lamenting.
- (b) "Men at some time are masters of their fates." Who is speaking to whom? Explain the statement and say why it is important to the speaker's argument.

Multiple-choice questions

- The Colossus to which Cassius compares Caesar was: (a) a Roman general (b) a giant statue at Rhodes (c) a god of war (d) a mountain near Rome
- In the extract, underlings means: (a) children (b) soldiers (c) inferiors or subordinates (d) rebels
- Immediately after this extract, Cassius reminds Brutus of: (a) the Soothsayer's warning (b) the death of Pompey (c) his ancestor who would not tolerate a king in Rome (d) the storm over the city

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Cassius is speaking to Brutus in a public place in Rome on the feast of Lupercal. The two men are alone; Caesar and his followers have gone to the games, and Cassius has been working on Brutus's discontent, telling him how he once saved Caesar from drowning in the Tiber and watched him shake with fever in Spain. A second shout and a flourish of trumpets have just been heard from the games. Brutus has explained the noise as applause for some new honours being heaped upon Caesar, and it is this remark that prompts Cassius's speech.

Why this answer earns marks: Speaker, listener and place are given at once (context), the situation is fixed by reference to what Cassius has just been saying (recall and connection), and the question's two final parts, what was heard and how Brutus explained it, are both answered with Brutus's own phrase. The answer ends by linking the remark to the speech, which shows the student understands why the extract begins as it does.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Cassius compares Caesar to the Colossus, the giant statue at Rhodes which legend pictured standing astride a harbour so that ships sailed between its legs. Caesar, he says, straddles the whole world in the same way, and the world has become narrow, too small for anyone but him. The petty men are all other Romans, Cassius and Brutus included, reduced to the size of insects walking about between the giant's legs. The dishonourable graves are the shameful deaths that await such men: if they live out their lives as Caesar's inferiors, the only thing left for them to find is a place to be buried without honour. The phrase is aimed at Brutus, who has just declared that he loves honour more than he fears death; Cassius is warning him that under Caesar he will lose the one and still suffer the other.

Why this answer earns marks: The image is explained in both halves, the statue and what it stands for (terminology: simile, explained). The petty men are identified, with the important detail that Cassius includes himself. The dishonourable graves are glossed accurately and then connected to Brutus's oath a few lines earlier, which is the analytical point that lifts the answer above a glossary.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Cassius means that the blame for Rome's condition does not lie in destiny, in the position of the stars at a man's birth, which astrologers believed fixed his fortune. It lies in men themselves: Romans are inferiors because they have agreed to be inferiors. The statement is a claim for free will, and it serves Cassius's purpose exactly, because if the fault is human then the remedy is human too, and Brutus cannot excuse inaction by calling Caesar's greatness fate. The view stands in sharp contrast to the Soothsayer's warning. The Soothsayer speaks as the voice of fate: a fixed day is coming, and the only choice is whether to heed it. Cassius speaks as the voice of will: nothing is fixed, and men make their own fates. Shakespeare places the two voices in the same scene so that the audience, who know what the ides will bring, can hear the irony. The conspirators will act as free men and will walk straight into the day the Soothsayer named.

Why this answer earns marks: The lines are paraphrased with the key cultural idea, astrology, explained (understanding). The function of the statement in Cassius's argument is stated (analysis). The comparison asked for is made directly, fate against will, with both positions characterised fairly, and the answer closes by naming the dramatic irony that results from putting them together (terminology and connection).

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Cassius sets the two names side by side and tests them as if they were coins. He asks what is so special in the word Caesar, and why it should be proclaimed more loudly than Brutus. Then he puts the names through four trials in a sustained parallel structure: written together, Brutus looks as fair; spoken, it suits the mouth as well; weighed, it is as heavy; used in a spell, Brutus will raise a spirit as quickly as Caesar. The devices are rhetorical question, parallelism or tricolon with repeated imperatives, and a metaphor of magic in the word conjure. His aim is to make Caesar's supremacy look arbitrary, a matter of mere sound, so that Brutus will feel that nothing but his own submission separates him from Caesar. He also hopes to wake the ancestor: the name Brutus can start a spirit because it belongs to the man who drove out Rome's kings, and Cassius names him openly a few lines later.

Why this answer earns marks: The question asks what Cassius does, which devices he uses and why; the answer gives all three in order. The devices are named precisely and illustrated from the text rather than merely listed, and the purpose is explained at two levels, the immediate one of making supremacy look arbitrary and the deeper one of invoking the ancestor, with a connection to the lines that follow the extract.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The description fits Cassius closely, provided that both halves of it are taken seriously. The patriot is real. In this extract his grief is for Rome, not only for himself: the age is shamed, the city has lost its breed of noble bloods, and the argument about the stars is a call to Romans to recover their freedom by their own will. He includes himself among the underlings and the petty men, which is the language of shared responsibility rather than private spite. Yet the envy is just as real, and it shows most clearly in the stories that precede the extract. Cassius dwells on the moment Caesar cried for help in the Tiber and on the fever in Spain when this god shook and begged for drink like a sick girl, and his fury is that so feeble a man has got the start of the majestic world and must now be bowed to. His complaint is not that Caesar is unjust but that Caesar is no better than Cassius, and the questions about the names, which prove only that Caesar is not superior, continue the same thought. The two motives are not in competition; they feed each other. Cassius hates Caesar's elevation because he is a republican and because he is Caesar's equal who has been made to feel small, and his eloquence comes from the wound. I agree with the description, with one refinement: envy supplies his energy and patriotism supplies his argument, and Brutus, who hears only the argument, is persuaded by the one while being moved by the other.

Why this answer earns marks: The answer treats the quotation in the question as a claim to be tested, not accepted. It supplies evidence for patriotism from the extract and evidence for envy from the preceding stories, as the question requires, with accurate paraphrase of both. It then does the hardest thing a 4-mark evaluation asks, relating the two motives to each other rather than merely listing them, and ends with a personal judgement stated in a single precise sentence that returns to Brutus and the extract's purpose.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Cassius says this to Brutus, when the two are alone during the Lupercal games, at the climax of his speech about Caesar's monstrous greatness. The line is an apostrophe, a direct address to the city as if it were a person, and an exclamation. Cassius laments that Rome, once famous for producing many great men in every generation, has lost its stock of noble families and now holds only one man; the republic of equals has shrunk to a single giant and a crowd of underlings.

(b) Cassius is speaking to Brutus. He means that there are times when men hold their destiny in their own hands and can shape it by their actions. The statement is central to his argument because he must persuade Brutus that Caesar's rise is not fate but the result of Roman submission; if men can master their fates, then Brutus can and must act. It also tells us about Cassius himself, a man who refuses to believe in powers beyond human control, and it sets up the play's long argument between free will and the prophecy of the ides.

Why these answers earn marks: Each fixes speaker, listener and moment, then names the device where asked, then explains meaning and purpose. Answer (b) goes one step further by relating the line to the speaker's character and to the play's theme, which is how a 'reference to the context' answer shows understanding beyond recall.

MCQ key: 1 (b); 2 (c); 3 (c). In question 3, option (a) is a common error, because students remember the Soothsayer from the same scene; but it is the ancestor Brutus, not the Soothsayer, whom Cassius invokes to close his argument.

Extract 1 — Caesar Reads Cassius: "Let me have men about me that are fat"

EXTRACT Act 1 Scene 2 — Caesar to Antony, as the procession returns from the games

Caesar: *Let me have men about me that are fat, Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.* **Antony:** *Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. He is a noble Roman, and well given.* **Caesar:** *Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. Yet if my name were liable to fear, I do not know the man I should avoid So soon as that spare Cassius. [...] I rather tell thee what is to be feared Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, And tell me truly what thou think'st of him.*

Context: Act 1 Scene 2, the day of the Lupercal. Caesar's procession has returned from the games and is crossing the stage on its way out. Brutus has just observed that "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow" and that Calpurnia and Cicero look shaken. Caesar draws Antony aside for this private exchange in the middle of a public crowd — the two men are, in effect, talking behind their hands while Brutus and Cassius watch from a distance, waiting to catch Casca.

Speaker: Caesar, with one short interjection from Antony. This is Caesar's longest speech in Act 1 and his only extended private conversation in the act.

Listener: Antony — the man who, according to Casca a few moments later, was the one who offered Caesar the crown. Brutus and Cassius are on stage but out of earshot, which matters: the audience hears Caesar's judgement of Cassius while Cassius stands there unaware of it.

Before: Cassius has spent the whole middle of the scene working on Brutus — the mirror image ("I, your glass"), the Tiber story, the fever in Spain, the Colossus, the argument from names ("Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'"). Brutus has asked for time and left Cassius with "chew upon this". Offstage the crowd has shouted three times. Then the procession re-enters and Brutus reads the faces before anyone speaks.

After: Caesar and his train exit. Casca remains because Brutus has pulled him by the cloak, and delivers his report of the crown (our Extract 2). Notice the design: the audience receives Caesar's private opinion of Cassius, then immediately receives Casca's private opinion of Caesar. Scene 2 is a scene of assessments — everyone is reading everyone else.

Meaning: Caesar tells Antony that he prefers to be surrounded by contented men — fat, "Sleek-headed" (smooth-haired, well-groomed, at ease), and able to sleep at night ("a-nights"). Cassius, over there ("Yond Cassius"), looks thin and unsatisfied — "lean and hungry" — and he thinks too much; men like that are dangerous. Antony reassures him: Cassius is not dangerous, he is a noble Roman and "well given" (of good disposition). Caesar wishes Cassius were fatter, then insists he does not fear him — but if his name were "liable to fear" (open or subject to fear), Cassius is the man he would avoid first. The lines the extract skips explain why: Cassius "reads much", is "a great observer", and "looks / Quite through the deeds of men"; he "loves no plays", "hears no music", and "Seldom he smiles" — and when he does, it is as if he mocked himself for smiling. Such men are never at ease while they see someone greater than themselves. Caesar then closes: he is describing what ought to be feared, not what he fears, because he is always Caesar — and he asks Antony to move to his right side because his left ear is deaf, and to tell him honestly what he thinks of Cassius.

Subtext: Two things run beneath the surface. First, Caesar's reading of Cassius is exactly right — the audience has just watched Cassius do everything Caesar describes — and yet Caesar refuses to let his own insight alter his conduct. The line "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not" is the hinge: the wish admits the danger, the denial cancels it. Second, "for always I am Caesar" is the statement of a man who has begun to treat his name as a guarantee. Shakespeare places the boast one line before a confession of physical infirmity: "this ear is deaf". The god who cannot fear cannot hear either. A strong reading (though not the only one) is that Caesar's pivot to the deaf ear is not incidental staging but the play's quiet joke — he asks Antony to "tell me truly" what he thinks of Cassius, but Antony has already told him, and was wrong, and Caesar is now turning his working ear towards the flatterer.

Character: Caesar emerges as a superb judge of men and a poor judge of himself. The shrewdness is genuine: he notices Cassius's reading, his observation, his refusal of pleasure, his mirthless smile — a psychological portrait of the ascetic malcontent that Cassius's own speeches have confirmed. But the shrewdness is swallowed by the public role; Caesar speaks of himself in the third person ("always I am Caesar") as though the office had replaced the man. Antony is shown as loyal, generous and easy — "Fear him not" — a man who takes people at face value, which the whole play will test. Cassius, seen from outside for the first time, is confirmed as the thinker and watcher he has shown himself to be — which means Caesar's error is not in perception but in pride.

Theme: Appearance versus reality (Caesar sees the reality and prefers his self-image); leadership and its blind spots; the public self versus the private man; fate and character (Caesar's downfall is prepared by a decision he takes knowingly); ambition observed from the top rather than from below.

Device: Dramatic irony — the audience knows Cassius is dangerous and hears Caesar dismiss the danger. Antithesis structures the speech: fat against lean, sleeping against thinking, men who love plays against the man who hears no music, "what is to be feared" against "what I fear". Illeism — referring to oneself in the third person — in "always I am Caesar", which the play repeats whenever Caesar is most vulnerable. Physiognomy, the old belief that the body reveals the mind, underlies "lean and hungry look". And the deaf ear is a physical symbol: an infirmity placed exactly where a boast of invulnerability has just been made. Note also that this is verse, formal and balanced, immediately before Casca's jagged prose.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch reports that Caesar said he did not fear fat, long-haired men but the pale, thin ones, meaning Brutus and Cassius; Shakespeare has taken the remark and turned it into a scene. Cassius and Brutus were both praetors in 44 BC, and Brutus received the more prestigious urban praetorship — ancient sources make this a grievance of Cassius, which sits behind Shakespeare's "Caesar doth bear me hard" later in the scene. Antony was Caesar's consular colleague in 44 BC. The deafness is different: no ancient source gives Caesar a deaf ear, and scholars treat it as Shakespeare's addition. That makes it doubly important for you — a detail Shakespeare chose rather than inherited is a detail he wanted you to notice.

Scene connection: Everything Caesar says here is verified within a hundred lines. Cassius's soliloquy (Extract 4) shows the man who "thinks too much" thinking his way to forgery; Scene 3 shows him baring his chest to the lightning and declaring that "dangers are to me indifferent". Caesar's confidence that he cannot be threatened by his own name is the same confidence that, in Act 3 Scene 1, keeps him in the Senate House until the daggers are out. Antony's misjudgement here is also the first note of the Antony–Cassius antagonism that shapes Acts 3 to 5: Cassius, who reads men "Quite through", will want Antony dead; Brutus will spare him.

Keywords: shrewd, perceptive, physiognomy, complacent, hubris, self-mythologising, dramatic irony, infirmity, misjudgement, foreshadowing, public persona, ascetic.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 1

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Where does this exchange take place, and from what has Caesar just returned? What has Brutus noticed about Caesar and his followers moments before Caesar speaks? What does Cassius suggest Brutus should do "As they pass by"? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words what kind of men Caesar wants about him. What does the phrase "lean and hungry look" suggest about Cassius? Why, according to Caesar, is such a man "dangerous"? [3]
- (iii) In the lines omitted from this extract, Caesar gives further reasons for distrusting Cassius. State any three of them. Which of these reasons does the rest of Act 1 most clearly confirm? [3]
- (iv) What does Antony's reply reveal about his character? How is Antony's judgement of Cassius proved wrong before the end of Act 1? [3]
- (v) What is ironic about Caesar's words "for always I am Caesar" being followed by "this ear is deaf"? Do you think Caesar's refusal to fear Cassius is a strength or a weakness in a leader? Give a reason for your answer, supported by the text. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." — Who speaks these words and to whom? What is the occasion? Explain their meaning and say what they reveal about the speaker.
- (b) "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." — Explain these lines with reference to the context. What weakness in the speaker do they expose?

Multiple-choice questions:

1. Caesar wants men around him who are 'fat' and 'sleek-headed' because such men are (a) better soldiers (b) contented and therefore not plotting (c) more entertaining company (d) easier to bribe
2. Antony describes Cassius as (a) "a great observer" (b) "a noble Roman, and well given" (c) "quick mettle" (d) "a dreamer"
3. Caesar asks Antony to move to his right side because (a) it is the place of honour (b) Antony must guard him from Cassius (c) Caesar's left ear is deaf (d) the crowd is pressing on his left

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Caesar and Antony are in a public place in Rome on the feast of Lupercal; Caesar's procession is passing through on its way home from the games, where Antony has run his course and where (as Casca will report) a crown was offered to Caesar three times. Just before Caesar speaks, Brutus has observed that "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow", that the followers look "like a chidden train", that Calpurnia's cheek is pale, and that Cicero has the fiery, "ferret" eyes he wears when crossed by senators. Cassius has told Brutus to "pluck Casca by the sleeve" as they pass, so that Casca, in his "sour fashion", can tell them what happened.

Why this answer earns marks: It places the extract exactly (Lupercal, the returning procession), answers each of the three parts separately, and supports two of them with short, accurate quotations. An evaluator awards the three marks quickly because nothing has to be searched for.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Caesar wants to be surrounded by comfortable, contented men — well-fed, well-groomed, able to sleep soundly at night — because a satisfied man has no reason to plot. The "lean and hungry look" suggests that Cassius is thin, restless and unsatisfied, hungry not for food but for something he lacks — power, recognition, or Caesar's downfall. Caesar believes such a man is dangerous because "He thinks too much": a man who broods, observes and is never at ease is the kind of man who turns his discontent into action.

Why this answer earns marks: The paraphrase is in the candidate's own words, the metaphor of hunger is actually explained rather than repeated, and the third part links the adjective to Caesar's stated reason. Explaining a phrase means unpacking the image; this answer does that.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

In the omitted lines Caesar says that Cassius "reads much", that he is "a great observer" who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", that he "loves no plays" and "hears no music" as Antony does, and that he "Seldom he smiles" — and when he does, it is as if he mocked himself for smiling. Caesar adds that such men are never at ease while they see someone greater than themselves. The rest of Act 1 most clearly confirms the last of these: Cassius's speeches to Brutus are consumed by the injustice that Caesar has "become a god" while Cassius "must bend his body", and his soliloquy shows a man who reads other men accurately enough to plan how to seduce Brutus.

Why this answer earns marks: Three reasons are stated with textual precision (more than three, in fact, which protects the candidate if one is judged weak), and the second part does not merely name a reason but shows it being confirmed with evidence from elsewhere in the act. That cross-referencing is what separates a two-mark from a three-mark answer.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Antony's "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given" reveals a man who is loyal, generous in his judgements, and inclined to take people at their public face value; he sees a fellow noble and assumes good nature. He is also a soothing presence for Caesar rather than a challenging one. His judgement is proved wrong within the same scene, when Cassius alone on stage announces that he will forge letters in "several hands" to work on Brutus and that "we will shake him, or worse days endure", and again in Scene 3, when Cassius wins Casca to the conspiracy and sends Cinna out with the forged papers.

Why this answer earns marks: It infers character from the exact words rather than asserting it, it names two qualities plus a role (the reassurer), and it answers 'how is he proved wrong' with two specific events in the correct order. The evaluator can tick recall, inference and connection.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The irony is that Caesar claims a godlike constancy — he is not a man who fears, he is simply "Caesar", a name that stands above fear — and in the very next breath confesses an ordinary human weakness: one ear cannot hear. The boast of being above human limits is undercut by a bodily limit, and the deaf ear becomes a symbol of a man who will not hear warnings — he has already dismissed the Soothsayer as "a dreamer". There is further irony in the fact that he turns his good ear towards Antony, who has just misjudged Cassius, and asks him to "tell me truly". In my view, Caesar's refusal to fear Cassius is a weakness, because the refusal is not based on information — his information is excellent — but on image: he says "Would he were fatter!", which admits the danger, and then overrides his own judgement to protect the idea of himself as fearless. A leader who can see a threat and chooses not to act on it, in order to seem invulnerable, has made himself more vulnerable, and the play confirms this when the man he correctly suspects leads the conspiracy against him.

Why this answer earns marks: The four marks are spread deliberately: two for the irony (the boast against the infirmity, plus the extra layer of turning the ear to Antony), one for a clear, committed opinion, and one for a reason anchored in a quotation ("Would he were fatter!") and in the outcome of the play. An evaluator rewards a personal response that is argued, not merely stated.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 1 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Caesar to Antony, as the procession returns from the games on the Lupercal; the "angry spot" is on Caesar's brow after the crown episode. Caesar reads Cassius's thinness and restlessness as signs of a brooding, discontented mind; the lines reveal a shrewd observer of men who nevertheless treats his insight as an intellectual exercise rather than a warning. Reference to the context (b): Caesar distinguishes between describing what is fearful in general and admitting fear in himself; the third-person "Caesar" shows a man who has fused himself with his public title, and the refusal to fear what he has just called dangerous exposes pride that overrides judgement. MCQs: 1 (b); 2 (b); 3 (c).

Extract 2 — Casca Reports the Crown: "he would fain have had it"

EXTRACT**Act 1 Scene 2 — Casca to Brutus and Cassius, after Caesar's procession has left**

Casca: *Why, there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting. [...]* **Brutus:** *Tell us the manner of it, gentle Casca.* **Casca:** *I can as well be hanged as tell the manner of it. It was mere foolery; I did not mark it. I saw Mark Antony offer him a crown (yet 'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets), and, as I told you, he put it by once; but for all that, to my thinking, he would fain have had it. Then he offered it to him again; then he put it by again; but to my thinking, he was very loath to lay his fingers off it. And then he offered it the third time. He put it the third time by, and still as he refused it the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps and uttered such a deal of stinking breath because Caesar refused the crown that it had almost choked Caesar, for he swooned and fell down at it.*

Context: Act 1 Scene 2, immediately after Caesar's train has gone. Brutus has pulled Casca by the cloak, and Casca — surprised that Brutus, who was in the procession, needs to ask — explains what happened at the games while Brutus and Cassius were talking. Between the two halves of the extract lie the quick exchanges in which Brutus asks what the second and third shouts were for and Casca answers "Why, for that too", and confirms that the crown was offered three times and refused "every time gentler than other".

Speaker: Casca, in prose. Every other noble in the scene speaks verse; Casca's choice of prose is itself a characterising device, the 'sour fashion' Cassius promised.

Listener: Brutus and Cassius — the two men most anxious to know whether Rome has just acquired a king. Brutus asks the eager, factual questions ("Was the crown offered him thrice?"); Cassius supplies the count ("They shouted thrice").

Before: The three offstage shouts punctuated Cassius's temptation of Brutus, and Brutus interpreted them fearfully: "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Then Caesar returned looking angry and, in Extract 1, privately named Cassius as the man to be feared.

After: Cassius asks, "What, did Caesar swoon?" and Casca describes the fit in the market-place — "foamed at mouth and was speechless" — which leads into Extract 3: the "falling sickness" pun, Cicero's Greek, and the news that Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence".

Meaning: Casca says a crown was offered to Caesar and Caesar pushed it away "with the back of his hand, thus" — Casca mimes the gesture as he speaks — at which the people shouted. Pressed for the manner of it, he claims he would as soon be hanged as describe it, that it was nonsense ("mere foolery") and he paid no attention ("I did not mark it"). Then he describes it in detail. Antony offered Caesar a crown — though, Casca sneers, it was not a real crown but one of these little "coronets" — and Caesar refused it; but in Casca's opinion ("to my thinking") he "would fain have had it" — would gladly have accepted it. Offered again, he refused again, but was "very loath" — extremely reluctant — to take his fingers off it. Offered a third time, he refused a third time, and each time he refused, the mob ("rabblement") hooted, clapped their rough, cracked ("chopped") hands, threw up their sweaty caps and let out such a quantity of foul breath because Caesar had refused that it nearly suffocated him — for he fainted ("swooned") and fell down.

Subtext: Casca is not reporting; he is interpreting, and he tells you so twice with "to my thinking". Strip that phrase out and the facts are: a crown offered three times, refused three times, applause each time, a collapse. Put it back and the account becomes a charge of hypocrisy — Caesar wanted the crown and staged the refusals. Notice too what Casca does to the crowd: he cannot admit that ordinary Romans cheered a principled refusal, so he turns their joy into a physical assault of smell and sweat that literally knocks Caesar down. The comic causation — Caesar fainting from the people's breath — is a joke, but a political one: Casca finds both the ruler and the ruled contemptible. And his opening pose of boredom ("I did not mark it") is contradicted by the precision of what follows; a man who noticed the reluctance in Caesar's fingers was watching very closely indeed.

Character: Casca appears blunt, cynical and snobbish, with a gift for deflating grandeur — the coronet, the sweaty nightcaps, the swoon. Yet he is also a shrewd observer whose scepticism about Caesar's motives makes him natural material for Cassius; Brutus's later remark that he was "quick mettle when he went to school" tells us the bluntness is a manner, not a limit. Caesar, seen through Casca, is a man performing humility while (perhaps) desiring the crown, and a man whose body fails him in public. Antony is the instrument of the offer — whether as a loyal friend testing the crowd or as a partner in a piece of theatre, the text does not say. Brutus, through his questions, is revealed as anxious and dependent on others' eyes for what he did not see.

Theme: Ambition and its concealment; appearance versus reality; public opinion and the fickleness of the crowd; politics as performance; the unreliability of report.

Device: Reported action — an offstage event delivered through a biased narrator, which is the central device of this passage. Repetition builds the structure ("Then he offered it... then he put it by again... And then he offered it the third time") and the doubled "to my thinking" flags the narrator's bias. Anticlimax and bathos deflate the ceremony: a crown becomes "one of these coronets"; the divine Caesar faints from bad breath. The sensory imagery is deliberately coarse — tactile ("chopped hands"), visual ("sweaty nightcaps"), olfactory ("stinking breath") — and hyperbole turns applause into near-suffocation. The gesture in "with the back of his hand, thus" is a stage direction hidden in the dialogue: the actor playing Casca reproduces Caesar's hand. And the whole thing is prose, set against the verse that surrounds it, which makes Casca sound like a man who refuses to dignify what he saw.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch describes the Lupercalia of 15 February 44 BC: Antony, running as one of the Luperci while serving as consul, offered Caesar a diadem wreathed in laurel; the crowd applauded thinly at the offer and loudly at the refusal; Caesar finally ordered the diadem carried to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitol. In Plutarch the offer and refusal happen twice; Shakespeare's Casca makes it three times, a number with a stronger rhythm on stage. Shakespeare also adds what Plutarch does not supply — the cynical inner reading, "he would fain have had it". The word "coronets" is worth a moment: Romans loathed the title of king (rex) so intensely that even the object had to be diminished; Casca's sneer echoes an ancient Roman anxiety. Whether the historical Caesar wanted the diadem is debated by historians, and the play deliberately leaves it open too.

Scene connection: This report completes the three shouts Brutus and Cassius heard but could not interpret. It also completes Scene 1: the "coronets" and the crowd's cheering are the same populace the tribunes scolded, now cheering Caesar's refusal exactly as they cheered his triumph. Looking forward, Antony will remind the Roman crowd in his funeral oration in Act 3 Scene 2 that Caesar three times refused a crown at the Lupercal, using the identical event to prove that Caesar was not ambitious — the same facts, the opposite reading. Casca's "to my thinking" is thus the first battle in a war of interpretation that the whole play fights.

Keywords: reported action, unreliable narrator, cynicism, political theatre, anticlimax, bathos, mob, fickle, class contempt, scepticism, ambiguity, prose.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT How examiners reward 'reported action' awareness

The crown is never seen. Everything you know about it comes from Casca, a witness who announces his bias ("to my thinking") and his contempt for the crowd, and who has already been introduced to you by Cassius as a man who speaks in a "sour fashion". Weak answers write 'Caesar refused the crown three times but secretly wanted it' as though the play had shown this. Strong answers write 'According to Casca, Caesar refused the crown three times; Casca believes he wanted it' — and then go further, asking why Shakespeare kept the event offstage at all. Three effects are worth knowing. First, ambiguity: because we never see Caesar's face, his desire for the crown remains an open question, and the play can keep Caesar poised between tyrant and victim. Second, alignment: the audience is placed exactly where Brutus and Cassius stand — dependent on a report — so we experience the conspiracy's own epistemic problem, deciding a man's guilt on hearsay. Third, thematic rehearsal: Julius Caesar is a play about how events are read — Cicero will say in Scene 3 that "men may construe things after their fashion" — and Casca's report is the first great demonstration of construing. An ICSE evaluator marking a [4] question on this passage is looking for a candidate who can separate what Casca says happened from what Casca thinks it meant, and who can name a reason for Shakespeare's choice. That separation is not pedantry; it is the difference between reading the play and reading a summary of it.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 2

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Who has asked Casca to speak, and how has he been detained? Why is Casca surprised to be asked? What three shouts did Brutus and Cassius hear earlier in the scene, and what does Casca say they were for? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words the phrases "he put it by", "he would fain have had it" and "very loath to lay his fingers off it". What do these phrases, taken together, suggest about Caesar's true wish? [3]
- (iii) Who offered the crown to Caesar? Why does Casca correct himself with the words "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets"? What does his description of the crowd reveal about his attitude towards the common people? [3]
- (iv) Casca says, "It was mere foolery; I did not mark it." How does the rest of his report contradict this claim? What does this contradiction tell us about Casca? [3]
- (v) Shakespeare chose not to stage the offering of the crown but to have Casca report it. Suggest two effects of this decision. Do you trust Casca's account of Caesar's behaviour? Give a reason for your answer. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Why, there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting." — Who is the speaker and who are his listeners? What has just happened on stage? Explain the significance of the phrase "with the back of his hand, thus".
- (b) "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps" — Who is being described, and on what occasion? What does the language reveal about the speaker's opinion of them?

Multiple-choice questions:

1. According to Casca, the crown was offered to Caesar (a) once (b) twice (c) three times (d) four times
2. The person who offered Caesar the crown was (a) Brutus (b) Cassius (c) Antony (d) Cicero
3. Casca's remark that it was "one of these coronets" is best described as (a) a factual correction showing his respect for accuracy (b) a sneer that diminishes the ceremony (c) evidence that Caesar was legally crowned (d) a compliment to Antony's generosity

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Brutus has asked Casca to speak; Casca has stayed behind because Brutus pulled him by the cloak as the procession passed, following Cassius's advice to "pluck Casca by the sleeve". Casca is surprised because Brutus was part of Caesar's train — "Why, you were with him, were you not?" — and so ought to know what happened; Brutus replies that if he did, he would not need to ask. Earlier in the scene Brutus and Cassius heard three shouts from the crowd; Casca explains that all three were for Caesar's refusals of the crown — the first when "he put it by", and the second and third, in his curt phrase, "for that too".

Why this answer earns marks: Each of the three parts is answered in turn, with the detail of the cloak and sleeve, Casca's actual question, and the three shouts correctly attached to the three refusals. The evaluator sees that the candidate knows the mechanics of the scene, not just its gist.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

"He put it by" means Caesar pushed the crown aside, refusing it. "He would fain have had it" means that in Casca's judgement Caesar would gladly have accepted it. "Very loath to lay his fingers off it" means Caesar was extremely reluctant to let go of the crown, as though his hand lingered on it even while refusing. Together they suggest that Caesar's refusals were a performance for the crowd and that his real wish was to be crowned — though the candidate should note that this is Casca's interpretation, twice signalled by "to my thinking", rather than something the audience witnesses.

Why this answer earns marks: Three phrases, three clear paraphrases in the candidate's own words, and a conclusion that draws them together. The final sentence adds the 'reported action' awareness that a discriminating evaluator rewards — the candidate shows that they know the difference between Casca's facts and Casca's opinion.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Antony offered the crown. Casca corrects himself because he wants to deflate the whole ceremony: a coronet is a small, lesser crown, and by insisting on the diminished object he suggests that the offer was a piece of theatre rather than a true coronation — and perhaps also that Caesar's supporters did not dare offer a real crown to a people who hated kings. His description of the crowd — a "rabblement" with "chopped hands", "sweaty nightcaps" and "stinking breath" — reveals contempt for the common people; he sees them as a foul-smelling, mindless mob whose applause is worthless, not as citizens exercising judgement.

Why this answer earns marks: The factual part is stated at once; the explanation of "coronets" offers two reasons (a deflating sneer and a political caution), showing analytical range; and the attitude is inferred from quoted words rather than asserted. Naming the sensory details is what turns a general statement about 'contempt' into evidence.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Casca claims to have paid no attention, yet he then reports the event with remarkable precision: he counts the offers and refusals, notices that each refusal was gentler than the last, records that Caesar was reluctant to let his fingers leave the crown, and even reproduces Caesar's gesture with his own hand. A man who did not mark it could not describe it so exactly. The contradiction tells us that Casca's boredom is a pose — a way of seeming above the vulgar spectacle — and that beneath the sour manner he is an acute and interested observer. It also warns us to read him carefully: his blunt style is a disguise for sharp political judgement, which is exactly why Cassius wants him and why Brutus later recalls that he was "quick mettle when he went to school".

Why this answer earns marks: The contradiction is proved with four specific details from the report, not merely claimed. The inference about Casca is then developed in two directions — his pose and his real capacity — and connected to how other characters see him. That is what 'what does this tell us' invites: inference supported by text.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

Two effects of reporting the crown rather than staging it. First, Caesar's motive stays ambiguous: we never see his face as he refuses, so the question of whether he wanted the crown is left open, and the play can keep Caesar balanced between ambitious tyrant and wronged man. Second, the audience is placed in the same position as Brutus and Cassius, who must judge Caesar on hearsay; we share their dependence on a witness, which is precisely the situation of the conspirators throughout the play — they act on interpretation, not on proof. I do not fully trust Casca's account. His facts may be accurate — the three offers, the applause, the fainting — but his reading of Caesar's inner wish is openly labelled "to my thinking", he despises the crowd whose applause he describes, and he pretends indifference while watching closely, all of which mark him as a biased narrator. A cautious reader accepts Casca's events and suspends judgement on his motives.

Why this answer earns marks: Two distinct effects are named and explained (two marks), a clear position is taken on trust (one mark), and the reason is built from three pieces of textual evidence rather than a feeling (one mark). The distinction between accepting the facts and doubting the interpretation shows the highest level of reading the extract allows.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 2 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Casca to Brutus and Cassius, just after Caesar's procession has left; Brutus has pulled him by the cloak to ask why Caesar looks sad. The phrase "with the back of his hand, thus" tells us Casca mimes Caesar's gesture — a stage direction inside the speech — so that the offstage crown is re-enacted, mockingly, by a hand on stage. Reference to the context (b): the common people of Rome at the Lupercal games, cheering Caesar's refusals of the crown; the coarse physical detail (hooting, cracked hands, sweaty caps) reveals Casca's aristocratic disgust and his refusal to credit the crowd with judgement. MCQs: 1 (c); 2 (c); 3 (b).

Extract 5 — Casca and Cicero in the Storm: "men may construe things after their fashion"

EXTRACT**Act 1 Scene 3 — Casca to Cicero, in a street at night, with thunder and lightning**

Casca: *Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth Shakes like a thing unfirm? O Cicero, I have seen tempests when the scolding winds Have rived the knotty oaks, and I have seen Th' ambitious ocean swell and rage and foam To be exalted with the threat'ning clouds; But never till tonight, never till now, Did I go through a tempest dropping fire. Either there is a civil strife in heaven, Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, Incenses them to send destruction. [...]*

Cicero: *Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time. But men may construe things after their fashion, Clean from the purpose of the things themselves.*

Context: The opening of Act 1 Scene 3. The stage direction calls for thunder and lightning, and the scene begins with Cicero meeting Casca in the street and asking two questions: whether he has brought Caesar home, and why he is breathless and staring. Casca's reply is the first speech of the extract. A month has passed

since Scene 2 without the play saying so — Cicero's question a few lines later, "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?", fixes this as the night before the ides of March.

Speaker: Casca, then Cicero. Notice at once that Casca speaks verse. In Scene 2 he was the only noble who spoke prose — flat, mocking, refusing to be impressed. Here, in the storm, he speaks in elevated blank verse full of personification and alliteration. The text does not explain the change; many critics read it as fear stripping away his pose, others as Shakespeare using the register the scene needs regardless of consistency. Either way, you should notice it and be ready to comment on it.

Listener: Cicero — Rome's greatest orator and a man of learning, who in Scene 2 was reported to have spoken Greek at the games and to have looked at Caesar with "ferret and such fiery eyes". He is the only character in Act 1 who hears a list of omens and declines to interpret it. He leaves before Cassius arrives and plays no further part in the conspiracy; when Cassius later proposes recruiting him in Act 2, Brutus will refuse.

Before: Scene 2 ended with Cassius's soliloquy and the plan of the forged letters (Extract 4). Between the scenes, offstage and unmentioned, the letters have presumably begun their work — by the end of this scene Cassius will say that Brutus is "Three parts" won. Casca's bringing Caesar home tells us he has been in Caesar's company that evening, which is how he knows that Caesar has sent word to Cicero about tomorrow.

After: Cicero asks whether Casca has seen anything "more wonderful", and Casca gives his catalogue of prodigies: a slave whose left hand "did flame and burn / Like twenty torches joined" without being scorched; a lion met "Against the Capitol" which "went surly by" without harming him; a hundred terrified women who swore they saw "Men all in fire walk up and down the streets"; and "the bird of night" — the owl — sitting at noon in the market-place, "Hooting and shrieking". He insists that when such prodigies "conjointly meet" no one should say they are natural: "I believe they are portentous things / Unto the climate that they point upon." Cicero answers with the two lines that close the extract, asks about tomorrow, remarks that this "disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in", and goes. Cassius enters, and the scene turns into Extract 6.

Meaning: Casca asks Cicero whether he is not shaken when the whole established order of the earth ('sway' — rule, dominion, balance) shakes like something unsteady ('unfirm'). He has seen storms in which scolding winds split ('rived') the gnarled ('knotty') oaks, and he has seen the ocean, ambitious to climb, swell and rage and foam as if to be raised up ('exalted') to the level of the threatening clouds; but never until tonight has he walked through a storm that rains fire. He offers two explanations, both supernatural: either the gods are fighting one another — "a civil strife in heaven" — or the world has grown so insolent ('saucy') towards the gods that it has provoked ('Incenses') them to send destruction. After the catalogue of omens, Cicero replies with careful courtesy: yes, it is a strangely ordered ('strange-disposèd') time; but men may interpret ('construe') things according to their own inclination ('after their fashion'), completely apart from ('Clean from') what the things themselves actually mean ('the purpose of the things themselves').

Subtext: Casca's two explanations are both political metaphors wearing religious dress. "Civil strife in heaven" is civil war among the gods — and civil war is exactly what Rome has just lived through and is about to live through again. A world "too saucy with the gods" is a world in which a man has risen too high — and Cicero, who looked at Caesar with fiery eyes, does not need to be told who. Casca never names Caesar in this scene until Cassius forces him to, but his storm is already a political storm. Cicero's reply is the subtlest moment in Act 1, and you must get it right. He does not say the omens mean nothing; he does not say the time is ordinary — "Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time" grants Casca his alarm. What he says is that the meaning men find in such things is their own: a frightened man reads a storm as a threat, an ambitious man as an opportunity, a conspirator as a summons. Within a hundred lines Cassius will prove him right by reading the same storm as a portrait of Caesar and a licence to act. Cicero's lines are therefore a warning placed exactly

before the thing they warn against — and they are also, a strong reading suggests, Shakespeare's instruction to the audience about how to watch the rest of the play: everyone in it construes, and the construing is the tragedy.

Character: Casca here is frightened, superstitious and eloquent — a different man from the sneering prose-speaker of Scene 2, or the same man with the mask off. The fear is real: he has not put up his sword, he is breathless, he reasons from the omens to a coming catastrophe. Yet it is this frightened man whom Cassius, minutes later, will recruit by shaming him for his fear. Cicero is the detached intellectual: courteous, sceptical, unwilling to be hurried into meaning, and at the same time practical — his real interest is whether Caesar goes to the Capitol tomorrow. His scepticism is admirable and also, within the play, useless; he sees clearly and does nothing, and Shakespeare removes him from the stage before the conspiracy forms. Caesar, who never appears in the scene, is present in every image: the fire from the sky, the lion at the Capitol, the owl at noon.

Theme: Superstition and omens against reason and scepticism; fate and free will (do the prodigies foretell, or do men make them foretell?); appearance versus reality in its sharpest form — the gap between things and the meanings men give them; the disorder of nature mirroring disorder in the state; fear as the raw material of politics.

Device: Pathetic fallacy and the Elizabethan doctrine of correspondences — the storm in the heavens matches the coming storm in the state, a pattern Shakespeare uses again in *Macbeth* and *King Lear*. Personification throughout: "scolding winds", "Th' ambitious ocean", a sky that drops fire, gods who are incensed. Alliteration binds the pictures together — "swell and rage and foam", "Shakes like a thing unfirm". Hyperbole and accumulation in the catalogue of prodigies ('twenty torches', 'a hundred ghastly women'). Rhetorical question in the opening line. Antithesis in Cicero's couplet — things against the construing of things, their "purpose" against men's "fashion" — expressed as an aphorism, a compact general truth that stands apart from the scene and can be quoted alone. Dramatic irony: Cicero's warning against misconstruction is immediately followed by the play's great misconstruer, Cassius. And the shift from prose to verse in Casca is itself a device of register, if you choose to read it so.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch and other ancient writers list portents before Caesar's death: lights in the sky, strange noises at night, birds of ill omen in the Forum, and the memorable detail of men on fire who were not burned; Shakespeare's catalogue draws on this stock of prodigies and adds the lion. Cicero's historical reputation fits his lines here — he was Rome's most famous orator and a writer on philosophy, including a work on divination that treats the reading of omens with scepticism — though you should not claim that Shakespeare had read it. The real Cicero was not a conspirator; he welcomed Caesar's death but was not told of the plot in advance, and he was killed on the orders of the triumvirs in December 43 BC. The ELIZABETHAN CONTEXT also matters: audiences in 1599 lived with a widespread belief that disorder in the heavens signalled disorder in the state, and with real anxiety about the succession to an ageing, childless queen. Audiences may have felt the storm as more than scenery. The dating is Shakespeare's compression: Scene 3 is the night of 14 March 44 BC, and the Capitol to which Caesar is to come tomorrow is Shakespeare's relocation of an assassination that historically took place in the Curia of Pompey.

Scene connection: Backwards, Casca's fear completes the picture of him begun in Scene 2 — the cynic was never as untouched as he pretended — and Cicero's smiling, head-shaking Greek is here translated into plain Latin: he distrusts how people read things. Forwards, within the scene, Cassius will take the identical prodigies and construe them "after their fashion" as a description of Caesar (Extract 6). In Act 2 Scene 1 Brutus will read a forged letter and construe it as the voice of Rome; in Act 2 Scene 2 Calpurnia and Caesar will construe the same night's omens in opposite ways, and Decius Brutus will reinterpret Calpurnia's dream to lure Caesar out; in Act 3 Scene 2 Antony will construe Caesar's wounds for the crowd. Cicero's couplet is the key that opens every one of those scenes.

Keywords: omen, prodigy, portent, superstition, scepticism, construe, interpretation, pathetic fallacy, correspondences, aphorism, register, detachment, foreboding.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Cicero's two lines are the most useful sentence in Act 1 for a Class X candidate

No extract from this scene will appear in your board paper, but Cicero's remark will serve you in almost any Act 3–5 answer that touches interpretation, deception or the crowd — and most of them do. Consider how often the later play turns on someone construing: Brutus reading a forged letter as Rome's plea; Decius Brutus turning Calpurnia's dream of blood into a vision of Rome revived; Antony turning a corpse into an argument; the plebeians turning a poet named Cinna into a conspirator because of his name; Cassius, at Philippi, reading the birds over his army as a sign of doom. A candidate who can write 'Shakespeare has already warned us through Cicero in Act 1 that men may construe things after their fashion' and then show how a later character does exactly that has demonstrated two things evaluators prize: knowledge of the whole play, and a grasp of the design behind the plot. Be careful with the quotation. It is often misremembered as 'construe things after their own fashion' — the word 'own' is not there. Learn the two lines exactly, and learn where they come from: Cicero, to Casca, in the storm, the night before the ides. A misattributed quotation earns less than no quotation at all, because it tells the evaluator that the candidate is working from memory of a summary rather than from the text.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 5

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Where does this scene take place, and at what time of day? How much time has passed since the previous scene, and how does the audience learn this? What two questions has Cicero asked Casca just before Casca speaks? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words Casca's two explanations for the storm in the lines "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction." How might each explanation be applied to the political situation in Rome? [3]
- (iii) In the lines omitted from the extract, Casca describes several "prodigies". Describe any three of them. What conclusion does Casca draw from the fact that they "conjointly meet"? [3]
- (iv) Explain Cicero's words "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." How does Cicero's attitude to the storm differ from Casca's? [3]
- (v) How does Cassius, later in the same scene, prove Cicero's remark true? Do you think Shakespeare wants the audience to share Casca's fear or Cicero's scepticism? Give a reason for your answer, with reference to what happens later in the play. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm?" — Who asks this question and of whom? What is the occasion? Explain the lines and comment on the change in the speaker's manner since we last saw him.
- (b) "But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." — Who says this, to whom, and in response to what? Explain the meaning of the lines and their importance for the play as a whole.

Multiple-choice questions:

1. Casca says that he has never before experienced a tempest (a) with thunder (b) at night (c) "dropping fire" (d) at the Capitol
2. Which of the following is NOT one of the prodigies Casca reports? (a) a slave's hand burning without being scorched (b) a lion near the Capitol (c) an owl in the market-place at noon (d) a comet over the Tiber
3. Cicero's response to Casca's account of the omens is best described as (a) terrified (b) sceptical and detached (c) angry (d) enthusiastic

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The scene takes place in a street in Rome, at night, during a violent storm of thunder and lightning. About a month has passed since the Lupercal of Scene 2: the audience learns this not from any announcement but from Cicero's question "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?", which fixes the night as the eve of the ides of March, the date the Soothsayer named. Cicero has just asked Casca whether he brought Caesar home — "Brought you Caesar home?" — and why he is breathless and staring so.

Why this answer earns marks: Place, time and weather are given; the time-gap is both stated and explained from the text, which is what 'how does the audience learn this' demands; and both of Cicero's questions are reported, one with the exact words. The link to the Soothsayer shows that the candidate sees the act as a whole.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Casca offers two supernatural explanations. The first is that there is "a civil strife in heaven" — the gods themselves are at war with one another, and the storm on earth is the overflow of their quarrel. The second is that the world has become "too saucy with the gods" — so insolent and presumptuous towards them — that it has provoked them into sending destruction as punishment. Applied to Rome, the first explanation mirrors the civil wars that have torn the Republic — Caesar against Pompey, and the new division now forming between Caesar's friends and his enemies — so that heaven's civil strife reflects Rome's. The second fits Caesar himself: a man who has risen above his fellow citizens, is treated as a god and is about to be offered a crown may be the 'sauciness' that has angered heaven — or, from Caesar's side, the insolence could be the plotting against him. Casca does not name Caesar, but both explanations point towards him.

Why this answer earns marks: Each explanation is paraphrased with its key word glossed, and each is then mapped onto Rome in a specific way, with the candidate noting that the second explanation can cut either way. That final caution shows the evaluator that the candidate is reading, not forcing, the political parallel.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Casca reports that a common slave held up his left hand, which "did flame and burn / Like twenty torches joined", yet the hand felt no fire and "remained unscorched"; that near the Capitol he met a lion, which "glazed upon me and went surly by" without attacking him; that a hundred terrified women, "Transformèd with their fear", swore they had seen "Men all in fire walk up and down the streets"; and that the previous day "the bird of night" — the owl — sat in the market-place at noon, "Hooting and shrieking". From the fact that these prodigies all occur together — "conjointly meet" — Casca concludes that no one should dismiss them as natural events with natural causes; he believes they are "portentous things", omens of disaster for the region or country ("the climate") towards which they point.

Why this answer earns marks: Four prodigies are described accurately (more than the three asked for), each with the detail that makes it strange, and the conclusion is given in Casca's own logic — the coincidence of the signs, not any single sign, is what convinces him. Glossing "the bird of night" and "climate" shows the candidate understands the words rather than copying them.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Cicero means that people interpret events according to their own temperament and wishes, and that the meaning they find may be entirely different from — "Clean from" — the true nature or purpose of the events themselves. A storm is simply a storm; a frightened man makes it a threat, a hopeful man a promise. His attitude differs from Casca's in two ways. Casca is certain that the prodigies are messages from the gods and reasons straight from them to coming destruction; Cicero grants that the time is strange — "Indeed, it is a strange-disposed time" — but refuses to say what, if anything, it means. And where Casca is overwhelmed by fear, Cicero remains detached and practical, turning at once to the real question of the night: whether Caesar will come to the Capitol tomorrow.

Why this answer earns marks: The aphorism is explained in plain language with a concrete illustration, and the contrast is drawn on two axes — belief and temperament — each supported by a phrase from the extract. Separating 'what he thinks' from 'how he behaves' gives the answer the structure that makes three marks easy to award.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

As soon as Cicero has gone, Cassius enters and reads the identical storm in the opposite way. Where Casca sees "dreadful heralds" sent by the gods to make men "fear and tremble", Cassius calls it "A very pleasing night to honest men", claims to have bared his breast to the lightning, and then construes the whole night as a portrait of one man — a man who "thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol" — so that the omens become an argument for killing Caesar. The same facts, a different fashion of construing: Cicero's warning is proved true within minutes. In my view Shakespeare wants the audience to hold both responses rather than choose. The omens are not empty — Caesar does die on the ides, and the Soothsayer is right — so Casca's fear is justified by events; but the play also shows, again and again, men bending signs to their own purposes, as Decius Brutus bends Calpurnia's dream in Act 2 and Antony bends Caesar's wounds in Act 3, so Cicero's scepticism about interpreters is justified too. The portents are real; the readings of them are human and fallible. That is why the play puts the two speeches side by side.

Why this answer earns marks: The first part answers 'how' with specific quotations from Cassius and a clear statement of the reversal. The second part takes a position that is argued rather than merely chosen, and supports it from two different acts of the play, which is exactly what 'with reference to what happens later' invites. A candidate who simply picked Casca or Cicero would earn less than one who explains why the play needs both.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 5 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Casca to Cicero, in the street on the stormy night before the ides of March; he asks how Cicero can remain unmoved when the whole order of the earth shakes like something unsteady. The sneering prose-speaker of Scene 2 now speaks fearful, elevated verse — the pose of indifference has gone. Reference to the context (b): Cicero to Casca, after Casca's catalogue of prodigies and his insistence that they are portents; Cicero replies that men read events according to their own inclinations, often quite apart from what the events actually mean. The lines foreshadow the whole play's pattern of misinterpretation — Cassius reading the storm, Brutus reading the letters, Caesar and Calpurnia reading the omens, the crowd reading Antony. MCQs: 1 (c); 2 (d); 3 (b).